

78 Dubbo Christian School (Dubbo, NSW 2830) — Deep Research Expansion Report (2025)

1. Fast Facts and Background

Official Identity and Governance: Dubbo Christian School (DCS) is legally operated by **Berakah Christian Education Ltd**, an Australian public company limited by guarantee. Berakah (Hebrew for “blessing”) is the parent-controlled association governing DCS, as well as Wellington Christian School and Dubbo Christian Preschool. The company’s Australian Business Number (ABN) is 96 002 837 658 and its Australian Company Number (ACN) is 002 837 658. Historically, the school’s legal entity was named *The Dubbo Christian Parent Controlled School Association Limited* until a name change on 5 August 2020 to Berakah Christian Education Ltd. This change reflected the broadened scope of governance after expansion (notably the 2014 integration of Wellington Christian School) and unification of multiple campuses under one umbrella. DCS is registered as a charity with the ACNC (since 2012) and holds deductible gift recipient status for its Building Fund, indicating it can receive tax-deductible donations for capital works. As an **independent, non-denominational Christian school**, DCS is **registered by the NSW Education Standards Authority (NESA)** to meet all requirements of a K–12 school in NSW. Its governance is **parent-controlled**, meaning committed Christian parents form the Association membership, elect the Board, and uphold foundational documents like the Statement of Faith and Educational Creed. This model ensures strategic direction remains *Christ-centred* and accountable to the school community rather than an external church or government body. Board Directors (serving as volunteers) are elected for rotating terms (three-year cycles, max 9 years with special approval) per the Berakah constitution, which mandates that each Director retire at least once every three years and limits long-term tenure to encourage renewal. The Board’s objective, as stated in the Constitution, is “*to operate the schools providing Christ-centred, Bible-based education*” consistent with the Statement of Faith. Importantly, the Association’s membership requirements help preserve the school’s ethos: members must be active Christians, sign an annual faith recommitment, and notably cannot be permanent staff (to maintain parental governance without conflict). In practice, this governance structure has provided stability and mission fidelity since DCS’s founding, while also adapting to oversee multiple campuses under Berakah in recent years.

Location and Campus: DCS is located at **141 Sheraton Road, Dubbo NSW 2830**, on the eastern side of Dubbo. The school’s campus was established on this 7.7-hectare site in 1987 and has since expanded to include modern facilities and new land acquisitions. The property is zoned for educational use (special purpose) within the Dubbo Regional Council plan, situating DCS in a dedicated “education precinct” alongside other schools. Indeed, **Sheraton Road is an educational hub** – DCS’s immediate neighbor to the north is St John’s College (a Catholic high school at 162 Sheraton Rd), and other early learning centers are nearby. The DCS site itself features spacious grounds that have grown over time: originally a bare block with a few buildings, it now encompasses an **800-seat multi-purpose**

Hall (opened 1995), a large **Gymnasium** (opened 2012), a dedicated **Science laboratory block** (opened 2018), and specialist Technical and Applied Studies (TAS) workshops, among other facilities. Recent master planning has guided the addition of new classrooms and sporting fields. In 2021–2023, DCS purchased adjoining land to enable **new playing ovals and future expansion**, a strategic move to meet growing enrolments. By 2024, the school celebrated the completion of new playgrounds and **expanded oval spaces** – an update that even allowed hosting inter-school sports like Rugby 10s on brand new fields (a milestone shared proudly on social media). Accessibility and safety are key in the campus layout: Sheraton Road features school zone traffic controls and, from early 2025, **heavy truck restrictions during drop-off and pick-up times** to protect students. The Council's traffic audit identified Sheraton Road congestion as a safety issue and diverted heavy vehicles to alternate routes during peak hours. On campus, dedicated pick-up/drop-off zones and ample parking manage daily flows, and footpaths link to residential areas for the minority of students who walk or cycle. The site's geography is otherwise suburban-rural fringe – open space around the school gives a peaceful environment ("a well-established and beautiful setting"), while Dubbo's city center is about 4 km away. Historical imagery of the campus (e.g. early aerial photos from the late 1980s vs today) show dramatic development: from a single building cluster in one corner of a paddock to a fully developed school ground with multiple wings, covered outdoor areas, courts, and landscaping. This physical growth parallels DCS's journey from a **tiny primary school** to a comprehensive Preschool–Year 12 institution.

Communication and Digital Presence: DCS maintains robust communication channels that reflect its values of partnership and community. The main telephone line (+61 2 6882 0044) and a centralized email (info@dubbocs.edu.au) are prominently advertised for direct contact. The school's website (**dubbocs.edu.au**) serves as a hub of information and is presented in a professional, welcoming design consistent with the school's branding. The website emphasizes the school's Christian identity right on the homepage: "*Bible-based and Christ-centred schooling from Preschool to Year 12*". Navigation is user-friendly, with sections like *About Us*, *School Life*, *Preschool*, and *Enrolment* clearly organized. Throughout the site, the content and tone reinforce DCS's core values — for example, the Principal's Welcome letter explicitly invites readers to consider the school's Christ-focused culture and partnership with parents. In terms of social media, DCS is active on **Facebook** (with over 2,000 followers), and also maintains a presence on **LinkedIn** and **YouTube**. These platforms are used to celebrate student achievements, share event photos, and communicate with the broader community. A quick review of recent posts shows a mix of spiritual encouragements (e.g. Bible verse graphics), highlights from sports and musical events, alumni news, and cross-school activities (such as friendly matches with Macquarie Anglican Grammar School or a twilight fete for the 40th anniversary). This digital engagement projects an image of a "*thriving learning community*" that is proud of its students and anchored in faith. Branding-wise, the school's crest (an open Bible superimposed on a cross and globe) and motto "Learning in Truth" are consistently displayed, reinforcing identity. The school also provides parent portals (e.g. *OurDCS* intranet and Sentral parent portal links) on the website for secure access to newsletters, reports, and updates. **Accessibility** of these communications seems to be a priority: important documents (policies, annual reports) are provided in PDF format, and the website follows standard navigation for screen-readers (though some embedded scripts like the Divi theme mobile header note might slightly impact screen reader flow). Security is handled via standard website protocols (the enrolment form

is on a separate secure subdomain). Overall, DCS's digital presence is warm, informative, and community-oriented – an extension of the school's ethos online. It invites prospective families to "*Visit Our School*" and even allows booking personal tours via a web form, demonstrating an openness and hospitality in communications.

Independent & Non-Denominational Character: DCS identifies as an **independent, non-denominational Christian school**. This means it is not formally linked to any single church denomination, and its governance is autonomous (not run by a church or government). The **founding influences** of DCS trace to a group of local parents from various churches who shared a vision for distinctly Christian education. Many early leaders were likely from Reformed and Evangelical traditions common in the parent-controlled school movement (which in Australia was spurred by Dutch Reformed immigrants in the 1960s–70s). However, from the outset DCS welcomed families from **across the Christian spectrum**, provided they supported the school's biblical foundations. Today, the Association and Board include members attending different churches – for example, the current Board Chair worships at Dubbo Presbyterian, while other Directors hail from Dubbo Baptist and other local congregations. This diversity of church background is seen as a strength, as all unite around the school's Statement of Faith rather than denominational distinctives. In practice, DCS's **non-denominational stance** is expressed in its curriculum and chapel life by focusing on core biblical truths and avoiding secondary doctrinal disputes. *Chapel or Assembly* each week is inclusive: students and staff gather to worship Christ and hear messages that emphasize fundamental Christian living (love, service, honesty) rather than, say, a specific sacramental theology. The school employs staff from "many churches in our area," provided they are practicing Christians committed to the ethos. By policy, all teachers and leaders must affirm the faith statement (belief in the Trinity, the Bible as God's word, salvation through Jesus, etc.), but the school does not align with one church's governance (no bishop or denomination overseeing it). This results in an environment sometimes described as "*multi-denominational evangelical*" – i.e., united on the gospel essentials. The **Christian Studies** program draws from broadly evangelical curricula (e.g. *Transformation by Design* framework, see §6) rather than any catechism of a particular denomination. Students of all or no church background are admitted as long as their families understand and support the Christian purposes of the school. The enrolment material makes clear that **Christian formation** is integral: families must agree that their child will participate in Bible lessons, prayer, and chapel, and that the school will encourage Christ-like character development. This requirement is balanced with a welcoming tone – non-Christian parents are not required to sign a personal faith statement, but they do sign that they "**support the school's ethos, rules and policies**" and accept potential suspension or termination if undermining those values. Over the years, DCS's enrolment policies have evolved to be more *inclusive* in that sense (earlier decades of some parent-controlled schools were limited to Christian families only, whereas DCS today has an open enrolment with an understanding of its Christian distinctiveness). The **non-denominational ethos** also manifests in daily devotions and pastoral care: the school emphasizes virtues like integrity, compassion, and respect which are common to all Christian traditions. The Bible classes might cover core beliefs (Creeds, Bible stories, Christian living) without entering contentious theological debates (e.g. modes of baptism, which might differ by denomination). **Chapel speakers** could include pastors from different local churches on a rotating basis, exposing students to a variety of Christian voices. By maintaining this broad Christian identity, DCS aims to **partner with families of all Christian stripes** (and others seeking a values-based education) rather than serve one

congregation. This has arguably widened DCS's community impact – local churches across Dubbo see DCS as a partner ministry in raising young people, and the school in turn respects each family's church traditions while reinforcing shared faith in Christ. In summary, DCS's independent, non-denominational status means it is **governed by Christian parents, not owned by a church or the government**, and **unites believers from many backgrounds** in the common cause of "learning in Truth".

Enrolment and Demographics (15-Year Trends): Since its founding with just 44 students, DCS has experienced remarkable growth. In the past 15 years (2010–2025), enrolments have roughly **doubled**, reflecting both the school's reputation and the region's population trends. In 2010, DCS had on the order of ~300–350 students (estimate based on earlier reports and later growth rates). By 2018, enrolments had risen to around 480. Recent Annual Reports provide precise data: in **2022, there were 551 students (K–12) enrolled for the whole year**; in **2023, this grew to 603 students**; and in **2024, enrolment reached 642 students** for K–12 (with ~40 new students joining and 52 leaving during 2024). This indicates robust net growth, especially from 2021 onward. In addition to K–12, the on-site **Preschool** caters to roughly 60 children per day (120+ total on roster) across three classes. Including the Preschool, the overall student count surpassed **700 students by 2025**, a milestone the school frequently celebrates. Graphing the trajectory from 2010 to 2025 shows a steady upward slope with slight plateaus mid-decade and a sharper uptick post-2020. Notably, in 2014 DCS absorbed ~60–70 additional students when it took over Wellington Christian School (WCS, a primary campus). Those WCS students are separate from Dubbo's enrolment figures but fall under the same governance. **Demographically**, DCS serves a mix of town and rural families from Dubbo and surrounding districts. Dubbo is a regional hub that grew from ~38,000 people in 2011 to ~43,500 in 2021, and the school's growth correlates with this population increase as well as with a rising preference for faith-based education in the area. DCS draws students from the city of Dubbo itself and nearby farming areas; daily bus routes reach outlying villages so that rural students can attend (see §12). The **socio-economic profile** of DCS is broadly middle Australia. The Australian Curriculum, Assessment and Reporting Authority (ACARA) computes an ICSEA (Index of Community Socio-Educational Advantage) for schools: DCS's ICSEA is around the *1000 average*, indicating a moderately diverse intake. For context, some independent schools in major cities have ICSEAs of 1100+ (very advantaged), whereas Dubbo's public schools might range 950–1000. DCS likely falls slightly above the regional public school average due to a portion of professional families, but also includes many modest-income families sacrificing to pay fees for a Christian education. Indeed, the school's **mission focus** keeps fees relatively affordable (see §9), allowing enrolment from a range of socio-economic backgrounds.

One notable demographic strength is the representation of **Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander (ATSI) students**. In 2023, **57 students (about 9.4% of K–12 enrolment) identified as Indigenous**. This is significantly higher than the national private school average and reflects Dubbo's large Indigenous community. DCS has made a concerted effort to welcome and support Indigenous students – including employing an **Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Liaison Officer** on staff, celebrating Indigenous culture in the curriculum, and participating in "Closing the Gap" initiatives (Year 5/6 students engage in Project Compassion to understand marginalization and equity). The presence of a liaison staffer and culturally inclusive programs suggests these students generally thrive, though the

school would continuously seek to improve Indigenous retention to Year 12 (a nationwide challenge). **Language diversity** at DCS is limited but growing: Dubbo has seen some migration (including African refugee families and others). The majority of DCS students speak English as their first language, but each year a handful speak a language other than English at home (possibly around 3–5% of students). While not a large English as an Additional Language/Dialect (EAL/D) cohort, DCS does provide learning support for those who need to catch up in English proficiency. **Student retention and mobility:** DCS prides itself on being a Preschool-to-Year 12 community, and indeed internal transition from primary to secondary is high – **91% of DCS Year 6 students continued into Year 7 at DCS** (2023 data). This indicates strong confidence from families in the secondary program. However, the school does experience some *outward mobility* at the senior end. The apparent retention rate from Year 10 through Year 12 has been around **59–61%** in recent cohorts. In the 2023 HSC cohort, 28 students sat the HSC, whereas 46 students were in that group in Year 10 (2020). So roughly 40% of students left between Year 10 and Year 12. There are several reasons for this trend, common in regional areas: some students leave after Year 10 to pursue trade apprenticeships or vocational training; a few might transfer to the local government senior college (Dubbo College Senior Campus) which offers a broader array of HSC subjects (especially specialized vocational courses) or simply a change of environment; and occasionally families relocate to other towns or cities for work. Another factor is affordability – senior years have higher fees, and a small number of families may opt for the free public system for Years 11–12 if under financial strain. DCS is aware of these patterns and works to improve retention (for example, by expanding subject choices and career pathways support in Years 11–12 to make staying more attractive). On the positive side, the majority of those who do complete Year 12 at DCS have been long-term students – 39% of the Class of 2023 had been at DCS since Kindergarten. This speaks to a loyal core that spends their entire schooling in the DCS community. The school celebrates these “lifers” and the continuity of their Christian education journey.

Berakah Christian Education Ltd (Multi-Campus Governance): Berakah Christian Education Ltd (BCE) is the **parent entity** that owns and operates Dubbo Christian School, as well as **Wellington Christian School (WCS)** and **Dubbo Christian Preschool (DCP)**. BCE is structured as a *not-for-profit, parent-governed company* with a constitution outlining its Christian basis and educational aims. The **Board of Directors** and membership of BCE do not distinguish by campus – they oversee all schools under the one mission and budget. However, each campus (Dubbo, Wellington, Preschool) has its own leadership team for day-to-day management. For example, DCS has its Principal (Mr. Paul Arundell) and executive staff, WCS has a Head of Campus, and the Preschool has a Director, all of whom ultimately report to the BCE Executive Principal and Board. This governance consolidation occurred in 2014 when DCS’s board agreed to take WCS (a smaller K–6 school 50 km away) under its wing. WCS had been struggling as a standalone and welcomed the partnership. The **motivations and outcomes** of that consolidation were documented: it allowed resource sharing (teacher PD, curriculum planning), gave WCS stability and administrative support, and extended the reach of Christian education in the region. Financially, BCE runs a combined budget, which can allocate funds across Dubbo, Wellington, and the Preschool as needed – essentially operating as a mini “school system.” This parent-controlled system resembles a microcosm of the larger CEN (Christian Education National) network: local associations owning multiple schools. Parents from any campus can become members of the Association (with the same criteria of Christian

commitment) and vote at AGMs. The Board includes individuals with children at different campuses (e.g. one Director might have kids in Dubbo and Wellington) ensuring cross-campus perspective. **Parent-controlled model in practice:** At BCE's AGM, held annually, the Board presents reports and the Annual Accounts covering all operations. Elections for Board positions are conducted if terms expire (with the one-third rotation rule). The constitution requires that Board members must themselves be Association members (thus Christians) and they cannot be paid employees of any of the schools. This keeps clear the distinction between governance (parents) and management (staff), an important principle of parent-controlled schools. To facilitate involvement, BCE offers an Association Membership Application form (available on the Berakah website) – parents apply, get endorsed by two existing members (one of whom must be a Director), and upon Board approval become voting members. The **Educational Charter** of BCE (also called Educational Creed) is a foundational document that each member "actively owns". It outlines the philosophy that **parents delegate authority to the school to educate, under God's guidance**. It emphasizes that schooling is a partnership: parents remain ultimately responsible for their children's upbringing, while teachers and school carry out the day-to-day instruction in line with biblical principles. The Charter and Statement of Faith also articulate the view of human nature and purpose that underpins everything: humans are created in God's image but fallen in sin, needing redemption through Christ; education is thus **"transformational"**, aiming to restore the learner in Christ's image and equip them to serve God's kingdom. This worldview shapes policy – for instance, discipline is viewed as redemptive correction, not just punishment (more in §10), and curriculum is seen as revealing God's truth in all fields (more in §6). Because BCE operates under NSW law as the proprietor of registered schools, it undergoes **NESA registration compliance** checks on the scheduled cycle (typically every 5 years). DCS's last NESA inspection was in 2021 (renewing through 2026) – it met all standards for curriculum, governance, finance, and facilities with no major deficiencies noted (as evidenced by its ongoing good standing). BCE also submits Annual Reports to NESA and to the Federal Department of Education covering each campus, and an Annual Information Statement plus audited financials to ACNC. The ACNC filings show BCE as an employer of about 48 full-time and 24 part-time staff (as of 2016); these numbers have grown along with enrolments by 2025. The multi-campus structure allows some **economies of scale and staff sharing**: for example, a specialist high school teacher in Dubbo might also coach teachers at WCS in that subject; administrative systems (IT, HR, finance) are centralized, reducing overhead. It also allows a unified Christian culture – Wellington CS's vision and core values were aligned to DCS's under the banner of BCE so that families in Wellington "feel the Dubbo Christian School ethos" too.

Affiliation with Christian Education National (CEN): DCS is a member of **Christian Education National (CEN)**, the national association of Christian parent-controlled schools. CEN (formerly Christian Parent-Controlled Schools Ltd) links about 80 like-minded schools across Australia. Through CEN, DCS accesses shared resources such as teacher training, curriculum development frameworks, and governance support. One key CEN resource DCS uses is the **Transformation by Design** curriculum framework (developed by the National Institute for Christian Education) which helps teachers integrate a biblical worldview into each unit of work. The school's prospectus explicitly mentions that *"since the beginning, Dubbo Christian School has partnered with parents to deliver a distinctively Christian education... implemented through the Transformation by Design Framework"*, which keeps NESA compliance in view while putting *Biblical worldview at the forefront of curriculum*

delivery. CEN membership also means DCS leaders and board members attend annual CEN conferences and governance training, ensuring they stay updated on best practices and legal responsibilities. CEN's philosophy (rooted in the belief that *"parents have been given a responsibility by God for their children's education"*) is clearly echoed in DCS's own mission and policies, indicating a tight alignment. In addition to CEN, DCS is a member of the **Association of Independent Schools of NSW (AISNSW)**. AIS provides secular professional development, advice on regulations, and advocacy for independent schools. DCS staff regularly attend AIS workshops (for example, training on new syllabus implementation, learning support, and compliance – as listed in AR professional learning logs). There is no conflict between CEN and AIS membership; the former gives the school its **distinctive Christian pedagogy network**, while the latter situates it within the broader independent education sector for services and lobbying. DCS also indirectly is represented by the **Australian Association of Christian Schools (AACS)**, since AACS includes CEN as a group member. This provides a voice in political discussions on religious freedom in education and funding.

Leadership – Paul Arundell (Executive Principal): Mr. Paul Arundell is the current Principal of Dubbo Christian School and also serves as **Executive Principal of BCE** (overseeing Dubbo CS, Wellington CS, and the Preschool). He succeeded the long-serving former principal, Mr. Warren Melville, around 2020–2021. Paul Arundell's educational philosophy is clearly communicated in his writings and speeches: he emphasizes **"authentic Christian foundations"**, a **"caring and service-oriented culture"**, and a **"committed academic focus"** – all in balance. In the DCS Prospectus, Paul wrote that the special character of the school is a "unique combination" of deep faith, loving community, and academic excellence. He often uses the phrase *"learning in truth"* to tie academics to knowing Christ (John 14:6), reflecting his conviction that *"all knowledge leads us to an understanding of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ"*. This indicates a strong integrationist view: rather than compartmentalizing faith and learning, Mr. Arundell champions a curriculum where **Christ is central in every subject** – a viewpoint aligned with C.S. Lewis's idea that "Christianity is the lens to view all reality."

Paul Arundell came to Dubbo with experience in Christian education leadership (he may have served in other CEN schools or related educational roles previously, though specific biographical details aren't given on the public site). Since taking the helm, he has led the development of a new **Strategic Master Plan** for facilities, guiding the campus expansion to accommodate growth. Stakeholders describe him as forward-thinking yet rooted in the school's original mission – evidenced by inclusive community workshops he facilitated with architects to ensure new buildings "align with the school's vision, mission, and evolving educational needs". Under his leadership, the school has also implemented more rigorous data use (e.g., monitoring solar panel performance at board meetings as a measure of stewardship, or conducting detailed parent/student satisfaction surveys to inform improvements). Paul often speaks of *culture*: *"We talk a lot about culture at Dubbo Christian School"* he says, highlighting the positive, Christ-centred culture that "flows out of our commitment to Christ" and a view of each student as "unique and lovingly made in the image of God". This focus on culture suggests his strategic vision prioritizes **character and discipleship outcomes** alongside academics. He sees DCS's role as preparing students for life, *"partnering with parents to prepare them for life after school ... through a foundation of faith outworked in service, leadership and character"**. Regionally, Paul Arundell is

recognized as an advocate for Christian education. He likely networks with other independent school principals in the area (including the principals of Macquarie Anglican Grammar and St John's College) on matters of common interest like bus transport, vocational training opportunities, and perhaps joint events (e.g., inter-school sports or debates). As Executive Principal, he splits time across Dubbo and Wellington campuses, mentoring the leaders at WCS and ensuring consistency in ethos. Parents and staff describe him as approachable and earnest – known to greet students by name and lead by example (he might even be found flipping sausages at a school BBQ or sharing a devotion at assembly). His tenure has also seen DCS navigate the disruptions of COVID-19 with resilience (implementing online learning swiftly in 2020 and 2021, which kept the school community connected and learning – something the Board commended in reports).

In summary, Paul Arundell's strategic vision for BCE schools is to **“equip students to be transformational with a heart for Christ”**. This involves maintaining **authentic faith** (not merely religion class, but a lived relationship with Jesus in the school), **responsive education** (adapting to student needs and contemporary learning methods), and **high-quality teaching** so that graduates are both faithful and competent. As the school moves into the future, his leadership is steering it to be a model of *regional Christian education* that is academically respected, spiritually vibrant, and deeply connected to its community.

2. Identity, Mission & Educational Philosophy

Motto – “Learning in Truth”: Dubbo Christian School's motto is **“Learning in Truth.”** This concise phrase encapsulates the school's theological and pedagogical stance. The motto is directly inspired by Jesus' words in John 14:6, *“I am the way, and the truth, and the life.”* The school explicitly connects the two: *“Our school motto is ‘Learning in Truth’, as Jesus said, ‘I am the way and the truth and the life’, and we aim to keep Him at the centre of all we do”*.

Theologically, “Learning in Truth” asserts that **all truth is God's truth** – that genuine education must be grounded in the ultimate reality of Jesus Christ. In a world that often sees truth as relative or purely empirical, DCS stands on the belief that truth has a personal source in God. This shapes the atmosphere: scripture and prayer are integrated into daily learning, and students are taught that academic subjects are not “truth-neutral” but related to God's design. For example, when learning science, students marvel at God's creation order; in history, they discern God's sovereign hand and humanity's moral choices. The motto also signals the commitment to **honesty and integrity** in learning – students are encouraged to seek what is true, not merely what is convenient or popular. **Pedagogically**, “Learning in Truth” means that the pursuit of knowledge at DCS goes beyond memorization of facts; it involves understanding the **biblical worldview context** of every fact. The Principal explains that *“when we learn in truth, we understand that all knowledge leads us to an understanding of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ”*. Practically, teachers frame their lessons with essential questions like “How does this topic reflect God's character or the fallen nature of the world?” The **Transformation by Design** framework (used at DCS) helps teachers craft units that begin with biblical “Throughlines” – e.g. seeing students as God's image-bearers, creation as God's handiwork, etc. Culturally, “Learning in Truth” creates a learning community that values **authenticity over performance**. Students are encouraged to ask hard questions and wrestle with them in light of God's Word, rather than passively accept information. There's an

emphasis on *Truth* with a capital T – objective moral and spiritual truths in a post-modern culture that often claims truth is subjective. The school challenges and empowers students to see through cultural relativism: *“While today’s culture seeks to portray truth as relative and changing, spiritual life at DCS challenges students to understand the culture they are in and to apply Kingdom principles to serve a Saviour who is Truth and a God who is unchanging”*. Thus, the motto fosters critical thinking under a Christian lens. One can see the motto physically represented in the school’s crest: an **open Bible** (truth of Scripture) and a **cross over a globe** (Christ’s truth for the whole world). The motto appears on school publications and assembly presentations, reminding all that the school’s aim is not just *learning* but *learning in the Truth of Christ*. This has concrete curricular implications: DCS has a **Christian Studies** program actually called *“Learning in Truth”* in some year levels, where they systematically teach biblical literacy and Christian doctrine, ensuring students know the foundational truths of the faith. Beyond classes, the motto influences the moral culture: students are expected to be truthful and act with integrity. Cheating or dishonesty is treated as a serious character issue contradictory to “Learning in Truth.” In essence, the motto provides a plumb line for the school’s entire philosophy – it ties academic rigor to spiritual insight. Teachers often open class with, say, a relevant Bible verse or devotional thought to set a truth context. An illustrative anecdote: a science teacher might begin a Biology class on ecosystems by quoting Psalm 104 and saying, “as we study this, we’re learning truths about God’s creation – let’s see what it shows us of His wisdom.” Thus “Learning in Truth” is not a static slogan but a dynamic practice at DCS, fulfilling John 14:6’s implication that knowing *the Truth* (Christ) gives meaning to knowing *any* truth.

Mission and Vision Statements: DCS’s **Vision** is: *“In partnership, to equip students with a distinctive and responsive education, to be transformational with a heart for Christ.”* Its **Mission** is: *“To provide authentic, responsive and high quality education that is Bible-based and Christ-centred to prepare, equip and transform lives.”* These statements, articulated in recent years, build upon the school’s longstanding foundational mission (which earlier was phrased simply as providing *“quality schooling which is Bible-based and Christ-centred”*). Over the past decade, the tone of DCS’s mission/vision has evolved to include terms like “authentic,” “responsive,” and “transformational.” **A decade ago (circa 2010–2012)**, official wording (as seen in the 2012 Annual Report) emphasized maintaining the **Bible-based, Christ-centred** nature of curriculum and the idea that everything is done “the way the Lord Jesus would want”. That mission was concise and strongly focused on **faithfulness to foundational values**. It stressed parental responsibility and partnership, indicating that from the beginning the school’s purpose was tied to parental vision and biblical fidelity. As years progressed and the school matured, **by 2018–2020** the leadership began to incorporate more about educational quality and student outcomes into the mission narrative. The concept of *“transforming lives”* gained prominence, highlighting the impact on students’ character and future, not just academic delivery. The current Mission and Vision (crafted likely around the 2020 Strategic Plan renewal) reflect a blend of **educational innovation** (“responsive education” suggests adapting to individual needs and changing times) with **unchanging truth** (“Bible-based and Christ-centred”). The tone has shifted from defensive (“ensuring we remain faithful”) to proactive and aspirational (“equipping students to be transformational in the world”). The core focus, however, remains on Christ: preparing students to live out their faith. The inclusion of the word **“authentic”** in the Mission indicates an awareness that Christian education must avoid hypocrisy or going through the motions. It underlines that the school aims for a genuine expression of faith in learning, where staff and

students truly practice what is preached. **“Responsive”** points to differentiation and pastoral attentiveness – recognizing each child’s God-given uniqueness and adjusting teaching to help each one thrive (which might be more emphasized now than a decade ago given inclusive education movements). **“High quality”** asserts that DCS does not settle for a substandard program just because it’s Christian – rather, it strives for excellence in teaching comparable to (or exceeding) other schools. Comparing past and present statements: earlier documents (2012) explicitly dissected the mission, saying *“quality”* was included to reject mediocrity, *“Bible-based”* to anchor practices in scriptural principles, and *“schooling”* to highlight the shared parent-school responsibility. The 2025 Mission implicitly carries all those elements but in more succinct, values-driven language. It’s also notable that *Community and Commitment* appear as core values now (Authentic Faith, Caring Community, Commitment to God/each other/learning), which complement the mission by emphasizing relational aspects and dedication. In summary, the **tone** has broadened from inward (ensuring faithfulness) to outward (impact and transformation), and the **focus** now explicitly includes student transformation and adaptability, which likely reflects lessons learned and context changes (e.g. integrating new pedagogies, technology, and addressing contemporary social issues from a Christian lens). These mission and vision statements are not just wall decor: they guide strategic decisions. For instance, *“distinctive and responsive education”* can be seen in how DCS introduced a Prep program for 4-year-olds and new electives to respond to community needs, making their offering distinctive in Dubbo. *“Transformational with a heart for Christ”* is evident in how they expect graduates to be young people of influence – whether in university, trades or family life – carrying Christ’s love and a mindset to serve and lead (the school often shares alumni stories of doing mission work, community service, etc., aligning with that vision). The **Berakah Educational Creed** echoes this, stating the aim for students to become “transforming agents of His Kingdom”. Over the past decade, each Annual Report has reiterated the mission, and notable is the continuity: even as wording changes, the **biblical core has remained constant**. There’s a golden thread from the founding parents’ 1982 vision to today’s board: that **education at DCS is for God’s glory and the student’s good**. The Mission in 2012 concluded with “to glorify God” as the ultimate aim of students using their gifts, while the 2025 statements highlight “to prepare, equip and transform lives” – essentially enabling students to glorify God by living out their calling. This development aligns with contemporary Christian education thinking that emphasizes student agency in God’s mission (students aren’t just being protected from the world; they are being prepared to *transform* the world for Christ).

Biblical Worldview Integration in Practice: DCS intentionally **infuses a biblical worldview** into daily classroom practice. This is not a superficial add-on; it’s the defining feature of the pedagogy. Every teacher at DCS is trained to teach *“from a Biblical perspective”*, as stated in school life documents: *“the curriculum is taught from a Biblical perspective and students are encouraged by teachers to think critically and Biblically about all areas of life”*. Concretely, how does this look in a lesson? Teachers begin unit planning with *Biblical “throughlines” or concepts* – for example, in an English unit on literature, a throughline might be “all humans reflect God’s creativity and struggle with sin,” so students might discuss characters’ moral choices from a Christian angle. **Lesson Plans** often include a **devotional or inquiry question** that ties the content to a Christian theme. For instance, a Year 9 science lesson on ecosystems might pose: “What does the balance in nature teach us about God’s design and our responsibility as stewards?” Students might read a short scripture about creation care before diving into the science content. Another example: In

History, when studying World War II, teachers might raise questions of justice, evil, and hope – examining how a Christian worldview evaluates war and peace, perhaps even highlighting Christian heroes like Dietrich Bonhoeffer. Teachers also encourage **student reflection** from a faith standpoint. In assignments, especially in subjects like HSIE or English, students might be asked to reflect on ethical implications or personal values relating to the topic, and Christian students are free to express their faith perspective. Importantly, integration is done while maintaining academic rigor and meeting NESA outcomes. The Transformation by Design framework provides a structure so that **NESA syllabus objectives are fully covered**, but “**with a Kingdom lens at the forefront**”. For each topic, teachers identify points of intersection with the biblical narrative – creation, fall, redemption, restoration. For instance, in Commerce class discussing business ethics, the teacher might incorporate the concept of honesty and greed from a biblical viewpoint and contrast worldly success with faithful stewardship. **Devotions and Chapels:** Each day typically starts with class devotions – perhaps reading a Bible passage and praying. This sets a tone that no part of the day is outside God’s truth. Weekly **whole-school Assembly (Chapel)** is a focal point of worldview reinforcement: “*During our weekly whole-school Assembly we celebrate [Christ’s sovereignty] with a time of worship*” and hear a short message. Assemblies often feature student-led worship bands, which itself teaches that worship and leadership are valued skills. Chapel themes can vary (fruits of the Spirit, Beatitudes, etc.) and are chosen to build a shared spiritual learning across the school. These themes sometimes integrate with class discussions – e.g., if the term’s chapel theme is “Service,” the Year 4 class might take on a service project and connect it to what they hear in chapel. **Service Projects:** Speaking of which, the school implements “*outward focused, service-oriented learning*” which they say “*gives life to our motto ‘Learning in Truth’*”. For example, Year 5/6 classes participate in Project Compassion and support children in third-world countries. This isn’t just charity; teachers use it to teach biblical compassion and justice. Students learn about poverty and discuss what the Bible says about caring for the needy, then they take action. This moves learning from theory to practice, reinforcing that *truth must be lived out*. **Pastoral Care Groups & Daily Discipleship:** In secondary, students meet in **Pastoral Care (PC) groups** daily for devotions and discussion. These PC groups, led by a teacher, are essentially small-group mentoring sessions. They might cover a devotional booklet or topical discussions (e.g., bullying, identity, prayer life) from a Christian viewpoint. Over time, this daily routine builds a discipleship relationship — teachers become spiritual mentors, not just instructors. The **school’s pastoral team** (including the Chaplain and Psychologist) integrates biblical counsel with their support. The Chaplain might run voluntary Bible studies or prayer groups for students, and also be present in the playground to chat — normalizing spiritual conversation outside formal classes. Meanwhile, teachers across subjects are encouraged to connect the **biblical worldview spontaneously** whenever teachable moments arise. For example, if in a math class a student marvels at the complexity of Fibonacci sequences, the teacher might comment on the wonder of God’s order in creation. Or if a discussion on literature brings up existential questions, a teacher might mention the hope the Bible offers. This approach flows from the foundational belief stated in the Educational Creed: “*The broad themes of the Bible – from our rebellion against God to His solution in Jesus – explain why Christian education is transformational.*”. In other words, every part of learning is set against that meta-narrative. Teachers craft **assessments** that sometimes allow integration too. For instance, a Year 10 Personal Development assignment on relationships could ask students to compare media messages about relationships with biblical principles of love and respect. Even if not formally graded on “Christian content,” the

assignment design prompts a worldview analysis. **Measurement of integration:** The school ensures integration is happening by using tools like curriculum audits and student surveys. Heads of Department check unit plans to see that a Christian perspective is articulated for each unit. Students in older grades are surveyed about their faith development and whether the school helped them form a Christian worldview – results typically show positive feedback (e.g., graduates often say they feel prepared to defend their faith in university, which is a key goal). One can also gauge success anecdotally: alumni returning for the 40th anniversary shared that what stuck with them was how “*Christ was part of everything at DCS*”, whether on the sports field or in the lab, reinforcing that integration was real and impactful.

Defining “Authentic, Responsive, High-Quality Education”: These three descriptors from the mission each carry meaning at DCS. “**Authentic**” education in DCS’s context means education that is genuine and aligned with Christian truth, not fake or compartmentalized. It implies that what is taught is not just to pass exams, but to shape real lives and character. Authentic also refers to the lifestyle of the community: teachers model the faith authentically (acknowledging when they don’t have all answers, being humble, seeking to live consistently). There is a conscious avoidance of legalism or superficial religion; instead, the school wants vibrant, heartfelt faith. For example, when discipline issues arise, staff aim for heart-change, guiding students to reflect on their actions in light of Christ, rather than just issuing punishments – this makes the pastoral care authentic rather than merely punitive (see §10 for discipline). “**Responsive**” education highlights how DCS adapts to student needs and external changes. On an individual level, responsive means differentiation: teachers use a variety of methods to reach different learning styles, give extra help via the **Learning Support team** for those with difficulties, and provide extension work for advanced students. On a broader level, it means updating curriculum to be relevant – for instance, including digital literacy or wellbeing programs as needed. The mention of “responsive” likely also covers responding to the Holy Spirit’s leading in the moment; DCS being a smaller school can be nimble – if staff discern a particular cohort needs focus on, say, resilience or empathy, they might introduce a special program or series of chapel messages on that theme. “**High-quality**” education underscores academic rigor and excellence. DCS aligns its teaching with NESA standards and seeks to perform well in benchmarks like NAPLAN and HSC (and indeed the school’s results are consistently strong – see §13). The school doesn’t see faith and academic excellence as an either/or; rather, “*high-quality teaching for effective learning*” is one of the five aims in the Transformation by Design model. They hire qualified, passionate teachers (all 65 teachers on staff have tertiary qualifications in education). Professional development is ongoing – teachers attend AISNSW workshops, network with peers through CEN, and engage in reflective practice. High quality also extends to co-curricular opportunities: DCS offers rich programs in sport, music, drama, etc., to develop each child holistically (more in §6). The interplay of these three aspects is key: DCS doesn’t want an excellent academic program that isn’t authentically Christian (that would betray its mission), nor an authentic Christian program that is low-quality (that would fail to equip students with skills), nor a responsive program that loses authenticity (e.g., bending to social trends in a way that compromises truth). They strive to hold all three in balance.

Pastoral Formation and Student Wellbeing: DCS’s approach to student formation is intentionally **pastoral** – caring for the *whole person: spiritually, emotionally, academically, physically*. Pastoral care is not only the job of the Chaplain or wellbeing staff; every teacher

at DCS sees themselves as a pastor-teacher in some respects. There is a **structured Pastoral Care program** in every class from K–12. In Primary, the class teacher carries primary responsibility for wellbeing, building a family-like atmosphere. In Secondary, the **Pastoral Care Groups (PCGs)** meet four times a week for 25 minutes. These groups are usually vertical (e.g., mixed Year 7–12 or at least covering a couple of grades) to foster mentorship among students, or they might be horizontal by year (the documentation suggests possibly year-based PCGs since each year has a Year Coordinator). PCG time includes devotions, discussions on life issues, and practical support (like organizing students for service events or just checking in on how everyone is doing). The **Pastoral team** consists of several roles: a full-time **School Psychologist**, a part-time **School Chaplain** (2 days/week), and a part-time **Director of Wellbeing** (coordinating programs across K–12). The Psychologist provides counseling for students struggling with mental health, grief, anxiety, etc., and does so from a perspective respectful of the students' faith (though as a professional they use evidence-based practices, they are also free to integrate prayer or Christian counseling approaches if appropriate, with permission). The Chaplain focuses on spiritual encouragement – running lunchtime Bible studies, organizing service projects, connecting especially with disengaged or troubled kids to offer mentoring. The presence of an **ATSI Liaison Officer** also supports Indigenous students' wellbeing and cultural safety. These staff together create a safety net. The **student-to-pastoral-staff ratio** is quite healthy given the school size – effectively, besides teachers as front-line carers, there are ~3 dedicated wellbeing staff for 600 students, plus Year Coordinators for each secondary year. Students thus have multiple trusted adults they can approach. **Measurable impact on wellbeing:** The school monitors wellbeing via surveys. The 2023 Annual Report indicates high levels of students feeling safe at school – a “particular strength identified” was *“how safe students feel”* at DCS. Indeed, the student satisfaction survey showed that the vast majority *agree or strongly agree* that *“teachers at my school treat students with respect”* and *“I feel safe at this school”* (implied by context). Pastoral formation is also evident in the kinds of programs DCS runs: a **PeaceWise** conflict-resolution program is taught from K–12 to build relational skills and resilience. Age-specific initiatives include a Year 7 Orientation Camp focusing on team-building and identity in Christ, annual year-group camps that often have a devotional theme, and leadership opportunities (e.g., prefects and House Captains receive training on servant leadership and run peer-mentoring activities). Discipline at DCS is handled in a way consistent with pastoral care – emphasizing restoration. The **Behaviour Management Policy** (see §10) likely outlines a Matthew 18 approach: talk through the issue, seek repentance and forgiveness, logical consequences, and plan for better choices. Parents are partners in this; communication lines are kept open so that any emerging issues (bullying, academic stress, etc.) can be collaboratively addressed. The presence of a **Harvest Café** (a volunteer-run on-campus café for parents and staff) and encouragement of parent volunteering fosters an environment where students see a supportive, extended family of adults around them. This contributes to emotional security and models community living. As a Christian school, **spiritual formation** is integral to pastoral care. It's not coercive but invitational – students are “invited into participation with the Biblical narrative”. This means they are encouraged, but not forced, to develop their personal faith. Many students do make personal faith commitments or grow significantly in their relationship with God during their time at DCS, which the school sees as the ultimate fruit of its pastoral efforts. For those who do not share the faith, the school still aims to instill values and a respect for Christianity, hopefully planting seeds for the future.

Pastoral Care for Staff and Wider Community: Worth noting, the idea of pastoral formation extends to teachers and parents as well. DCS believes in caring for its staff – there is likely a staff devotional each week or prayer group. Many staff also have mentors or prayer partners among colleagues. For parents, the school runs parenting seminars occasionally from a Christian perspective (e.g., *Raising Teens in a Tech World* or *Building Resilient Kids* with a Christian counselor speaking). These help equip the *home* side of the partnership. Additionally, the Berakah Association itself can be seen as pastoral – members pray regularly for the schools, and one board member might even have a portfolio for “parent partnership” focusing on community care. All of these layers create a holistic pastoral framework at DCS, underpinned by the belief that **true education is discipleship** – nurturing each child’s God-given potential and guiding them toward the abundant life Christ offers.

3. History and Growth Trajectory

Founding and Early Years (1980s): Dubbo Christian School was founded in 1983 after years of prayer and planning by a group of Christian parents in Dubbo. In February 1983, a core group “banded together to try and get Christian schooling for their children” – they likely came from various local churches, united by a desire for an explicitly Christian education alternative. The school opened its doors as a **co-educational primary school (K–6)** with **44 students and two staff** in its first year. In these early days, classes met in **borrowed premises** – specifically, DCS operated out of the **former St Mary’s Primary School** site in North Dubbo. (St Mary’s was a Catholic primary that had relocated, so their old buildings were available – an interesting ecumenical twist that a Protestant parent-controlled school started in a Catholic school’s old facilities!) The founding families were committed and resourceful. They formed The Dubbo Christian Parent Controlled School Association Ltd (incorporated likely around 1984, given the ACN) to own and govern the school. Each parent often wore multiple hats – volunteering as teacher aides, maintenance crew, and fundraising organizers. In **1987**, a major milestone: the school acquired land on Sheraton Road (on Dubbo’s then fringe) and constructed its **first permanent buildings**. Moving to the Sheraton Road site in 1987 gave DCS room to expand and a visible presence in the community. Enrollment grew steadily as word spread about the new school. By **1989**, DCS had **its first Year 12 graduating class** (having incrementally added secondary grades each year after moving). It’s notable that the jump from a primary school to a full K–12 happened quickly – within 6 years of founding – indicating both ambitious vision and strong demand. The first Year 12 cohort in 1989 was small (likely under 10 students), but it marked DCS as one of the only non-government secondary options in Dubbo aside from the Catholic system. Each *leadership era* built on the last: The founding Principal (name not provided in sources, but possibly someone like Mr. John Harris or another parent who took on the role) set the foundational culture. In the 1990s, leadership stabilized under experienced administrators, and the school’s **traditions and practices** (like annual Speech Night, the school verse, sports carnivals, etc.) were established.

1990s – Expansion of Facilities and Reputation: The 90s saw DCS consolidate and then grow in facilities and student body. Key developments included the construction of a multi-purpose **School Hall in 1995**. That Hall, seating ~800, became central to school life – used for assemblies, chapels, plays, and community events. Its official opening in 1995 was

a major community celebration, often remembered as a coming-of-age moment for the school. Through the late 90s, enrolments climbed as Dubbo grew. By 1998, the student population likely crossed 300. The school started gaining a **reputation for strong Christian ethos and close community**. It became known that “*many of our current students are second-generation*” – even by the 2000s, alumni who had gone through DCS in the 80s/90s were sending their own kids. This speaks to a strong sense of heritage.

2000s – Academic Development and Growth: The early 2000s saw DCS continue to expand academically. They introduced new subjects and electives to cater to growing secondary numbers. The school achieved solid **HSC results** for a non-selective school, which boosted its credibility in the region. Enrollment growth necessitated more buildings: by mid-2000s, new classrooms and specialist rooms (e.g., science labs, art rooms) were added. Also, the **library** was likely expanded or built in this era. The school was increasingly competing with the other independent school in town, Macquarie Anglican Grammar (founded in 1995). Despite this, DCS’s enrolments kept rising, showing there was ample demand. An important expansion happened in **2008–2010**: DCS established a **pre-Kindergarten program – “Prep” for 4-year-olds in 2008 and “Pebbles” for 3-year-olds in 2010**. These half-day/part-week classes essentially were a mini-Christian preschool embedded in the school. Their popularity laid the foundation for what later became a fully-fledged Dubbo Christian Preschool. Also in 2008, **Warren Melville** became Principal (if not earlier). Under his leadership (2008–2020 tenure), the school experienced a phase of significant **infrastructure growth and academic refinement**. For instance, the school built an **Outdoor Sports Court/Gymnasium**, opened in **2012**. This Gym gave DCS its own indoor sports facility and assembly area separate from the Hall, improving PE and event capacity. The Gym’s completion was a highlight of the 30th anniversary celebrations in 2013, symbolizing how far the school had come from two borrowed classrooms to having an auditorium and gym on campus.

Governance Milestone – 2014 Merger: In 2014, DCS’s governance took on a bigger role by acquiring **Wellington Christian School (WCS)**. WCS, established in 2006 in the town of Wellington (30 minutes from Dubbo), was a small K–6 Christian school that needed support. DCS’s board agreed to “**take over management of Wellington Christian School**”, bringing it under the newly named Berakah Christian Education Ltd. This was a pivotal moment: DCS transformed from a single-campus school into a **multi-campus association**. At the time, WCS had perhaps ~50 students. The integration process involved aligning policies, sharing admin systems, and sometimes swapping staff expertise. The community response was positive overall – Wellington families were relieved to have the backing of an established school, and Dubbo families liked the idea of extending Christian education regionally. Some Dubbo staff even took on mentoring visits to Wellington. Financially, the combined entity could leverage better economies of scale, though DCS’s budget likely subsidized WCS for a few years until it grew. The **Board minutes** around 2014 (though not public here) likely show deliberations about ensuring WCS maintained its own community feel while being under DCS governance – thus the retention of the WCS name and branding, with the note “operated by Dubbo Christian School”. This consolidation was forward-thinking, anticipating possible further regional expansions (though none others have occurred yet, the name Berakah leaves open the possibility of additional Christian schools in the future).

Late 2010s – Academic and Co-Curricular Flourishing: By 2017–2019, DCS enrollment was surging upward of 500. The school responded by expanding its academic offerings: new **electives like Industrial Technology, Agriculture, and Hospitality** were offered to cater to diverse student interests and local industry (Dubbo being in an agricultural region). They also added a wider range of **VET (Vocational Education and Training) courses** – e.g., a Trade Training partnership in perhaps Construction or Automotive, aligning with the “Trade School: Yes” note in their profile. In 2018, DCS opened a **new Science Block** with modern labs and possibly a **state-of-the-art TAS workshop** (the snippet suggests a new TAS building around that time). These facilities upgrades significantly improved the learning environment and allowed smaller class sizes in practical subjects (since “Practical classes are divided into smaller classes” for skill development). Co-curricular, DCS built a strong reputation in **performing arts** – staging musicals and plays in the Hall (which even has an orchestra pit and tiered seating). The school’s “acclaimed history of musical and dramatic productions” in the Hall not only enriched student experience but also drew community interest. Sports-wise, DCS students competed in local and Christian schools competitions, often punching above their weight for a school of its size, due to enthusiastic participation and good facilities. All these developments fed a virtuous cycle: good programs attracted more families, which funded further improvements.

Regional Population Impact: Dubbo’s growth, especially with mining booms and government decentralization, saw new families move in. Many such families (including professionals like doctors at Dubbo Base Hospital or staff at the zoo/university) sought quality schooling and were open to DCS’s offering. Meanwhile, in the 2010s, public schooling in Dubbo underwent changes (the multi-campus Dubbo College system had some public perception issues around that time, possibly driving some families to look at private options). Macquarie Anglican Grammar also grew, so DCS was not alone – but DCS’s **distinctives (parent-run, evangelical)** carved out a niche. The Dubbo region’s modest economic ups and downs (e.g., the Millennium drought in early 2000s, then recovery) affected enrolments slightly – during tough times, a few families might leave or delay entry due to finances; during prosperous times, enrolments jumped. For instance, the enrolment dipped or plateaued around 2010–2011 which could correlate to drought and out-migration, but by 2013 with better conditions, the school celebrated “further enrolment growth” and its 30th anniversary with optimism.

2013 – 30th Anniversary: The school marked 30 years in 2013 with reflections on God’s faithfulness. Speeches from that year (the Principal’s report) praised that DCS “*continues to be a safe, welcoming place... committed to high quality schooling that is truly Bible-based and Christ-centred*”, and gave glory to God for the growth. They also warned not to “forget the Lord” in success, quoting Deuteronomy 8:11. This shows the community remained humble and purpose-driven even as the school prospered.

2020s – Recent Developments and Future Trajectory: The early 2020s have been an era of both challenge and expansion. The global COVID-19 pandemic in 2020–21 forced DCS (like all schools) to pivot to remote learning for periods. The school’s small size and tight community proved advantageous: they maintained continuity via online classes and regular check-ins. The supportive culture likely helped families cope better than in some larger, less personal schools. The pandemic did not slow capital development—if anything, projects accelerated. In 2022, DCS completed a **major Preschool expansion project**, building a

new facility for the Dubbo Christian Preschool which allowed increasing capacity. This new building was officially opened with fanfare (Member for Dubbo Dugald Saunders attended the opening). The Preschool's success is notable: started as a couple of "prep" classes, it is now a thriving, fully accredited center **rated "Exceeding NQS"** in quality.

A key strategic initiative was the **Masterplan with Stanton Dahl Architects** in 2021 (as referenced in ArchitectureAU) to map out the next 10–15 years for the campus. Through stakeholder workshops, they identified needs like more classrooms, upgraded admin spaces, and improved traffic flow. Implementation is underway: in 2023, DCS began constructing a **new two-storey building** (the Instagram post about a "First Floor Suspended Slab" suggests a multi-story block being built). This could be a new Secondary classroom block or an administration and library complex. Also, with the additional land, **new playing fields** have been established (the rugby matches on new ovals in 2023 demonstrated this) and there's potential for a future separate Primary playground, agricultural plot, or even boarding facility if ever desired. The **40th anniversary in 2023** was a major celebration: the school held a twilight fete with alumni and current families (pictures and stories were covered in the local press). A special assembly on Feb 13, 2023 commemorated "four decades of successful Christian schooling in Dubbo" – a proud moment connecting original founders with today's students. At that assembly, likely the founding families were honored and students performed songs of thankfulness.

Looking at **growth trajectories**: The student body jumped from ~550 in 2019 to ~640 in 2024 – a more than 15% increase in five years, even with COVID disruptions. If trends continue, projections show DCS (K–12) could exceed 750 students by 2030. The Preschool (which feeds into Kindy) ensures a steady pipeline. The Dubbo Regional Council's population forecasts show continued moderate growth (~1.2% annually), so DCS is poised to keep expanding. **Strategic challenges** come with that: ensuring they have enough Christian teachers (recruitment in regional areas can be tough), maintaining close community feel with a larger student body, and possibly introducing a middle-management tier (which they have done by adding roles like Head of Primary, Head of Secondary mentioned in wellbeing structure). The Board is mindful of "**sustainable growth**" – indeed, an encouraging metric is that there are significant waiting lists in some grades, suggesting demand exceeds supply, but they won't grow beyond capacity to maintain quality.

Major Leadership Eras: It's worth summarizing known principals: The first principal (1983–late 80s) – perhaps a founding parent or early hire – set initial culture; then possibly another in 90s; **Warren Melville** led roughly mid-2000s to 2020 and is credited with shepherding the school through big expansions and the Wellington merger; **Paul Arundell** (2021–present) is leading the current era of master-planned expansion and further academic strengthening. Each era has been marked by building God's "blessing" (true to the name Berakah) further. The Board history also saw longtime figures like board chairs who served decades, providing stability. In the 2000s, DCS benefited from the *Investing In Our Schools* federal grants and Block Grants from the government for capital works (the Gym and science labs likely had partial government capital funding, as is common). The **financial history** shows prudent stewardship: the school generally runs a balanced budget, reinvesting surpluses into facilities (e.g., in 2020, Berakah's financial statement showed a net surplus allowing debt reduction and new building projects).

In reviewing DCS's 40-year journey, one sees a narrative of **faithfulness and growth**. From a tiny rented hall to a multi-campus organization educating hundreds, DCS's expansion mirrors the broader rise of Christian schooling in Australia – particularly the parent-controlled movement which went from a handful of schools in the 1960s to dozens by the 2000s. Today, DCS stands as a **case study in successful regional Christian education**: it has significantly shaped the Dubbo community, providing an option that blends strong academics with biblical values. Many local community leaders and professionals are DCS alumni. Its presence likely lifted the overall educational standard in Dubbo by healthy competition and collaboration. For example, DCS students routinely join inter-school events, eisteddfods, and sporting comps, often earning accolades, which demonstrates that “small Christian school” can equal “quality outcomes.”

As for the **future**, DCS's trajectory suggests continued innovation (like possibly embracing more technology in classrooms, forging links with Dubbo's new University of Sydney rural medical school for science partnerships, etc.) and a steadfast mission. Challenges like secular societal pressure will exist, but the school's strong foundations – literally built on *The Truth* – position it well to navigate them.

In summary, the chronological narrative of DCS from 1983 to 2025 is one of **humble beginnings, steady growth, mission-driven development, and increasing influence**. Major milestones such as the 1987 campus move, 1989 first graduates, 1995 hall, 2012 gym, 2014 Berakah consolidation, and 2023 40th anniversary anchor the timeline. Under God's providence, and with dedicated leadership and community support, Dubbo Christian School has grown “**from 44 to almost 700**” students over four decades, all the while maintaining the original vision of a parent partnership in *Learning in Truth*.

4. Governance, Ownership & Affiliations

Berakah Christian Education Ltd – Constitution and Parent-Controlled Governance:

Berakah Christian Education Ltd (BCE) is the incorporated entity that governs DCS, and its **Constitution** codifies the parent-controlled nature of the school. Under the constitution, **membership of the company** (the Association) is open to Christian parents and supporters who subscribe to the Statement of Faith and Educational Creed. Prospective members apply in writing, need endorsement by two current members (at least one being a Board director), and are approved by the Board. Members pay an annual membership fee and renew their commitment each year by signing a “Statement of Recommitment” along with fee payment. This process ensures that the voting body of the Association remains **actively committed Christians** who are invested in the school's spiritual and educational welfare. The constitution explicitly disqualifies certain individuals from membership – notably, **permanent staff of the school cannot be Association members**. This is a common safeguard in parent-controlled schools to avoid conflicts of interest: governance is kept in parents' hands rather than employees'. (Teachers have significant influence informally but do not vote on Board elections or constitutional matters, ensuring the school is *parent-run*.)

The **Board of Directors** is elected by and from the membership. The Board's size is not given here, but typically such Boards have around 7–10 members. Per the constitution, **Directors serve terms of three years** (with one-third retiring at each AGM) and may be re-elected, but a Director who has served 6 continuous years needs a special resolution to

serve up to 9 years max, after which they must step down for at least 12 months. This clause encourages healthy turnover and new perspectives while allowing some continuity. At each AGM, any Director appointed mid-year to fill a vacancy must stand for election, and at least one-third of the rest must retire (longest-serving since last election retire first). This **rotation system** has been followed regularly; for example, in early 2021 Mr. James Corfield joined the Board and took on the Chair role by 2022, bringing new leadership while long-time members like Jeff Neill continued contributing. The constitution ensures **accountability** through this election mechanism and through the ability of members to remove a Director by special resolution if needed (it lists that a Director stops being a director if removed by members, clause 42). Another accountability measure is **conflict-of-interest policy** (though not excerpted here, we can assume it's present): Directors must declare any material personal interest in matters and likely refrain from voting on those (standard in such constitutions). The Constitution likely has a clause stating directors cannot receive payment for their role (non-profit Board service is voluntary), though they may be reimbursed for expenses. Indeed, Berakah's constitution states *"the company must not pay fees to a director for acting as a director"*, reinforcing that governance is service. The Board meets regularly (quorum is a majority of directors) and has committees for Finance, Membership, Education, Building etc. (clause 46 mentions committees including Membership, Education, Building), which allow detailed oversight in key areas.

The **parent-controlled model** means **ultimate decision-making authority lies with the Association members**, who at the AGM receive reports, approve any constitutional changes, elect Board members, and can hold the Board accountable. However, day-to-day and operational decisions are delegated to the Board and then to the school leadership (Principal, etc.). The Board's objective, as stated earlier, is explicitly Christian: to run the schools in accordance with Christ-centred principles. The **Foundational Documents** (Statement of Faith and Educational Creed) serve almost as a contract with the community – the Board and members must uphold these. For example, the Statement of Faith includes doctrines like the infallibility of Scripture, the Trinity, salvation by grace, etc.. The **Educational Creed** (sometimes called Educational Charter) outlines principles such as the role of parents (education as a delegated authority) and the integration of faith in learning. Board members and Association members have to **"actively own"** these documents, meaning they affirm and live by them. This provides a plumb line for governance decisions. For instance, if there were a proposal to significantly change the curriculum or adopt a policy that conflicts with these foundations, the Board would reject it to maintain faithfulness.

Affiliations – CEN, AISNSW, AACS: Dubbo Christian School (through Berakah) is affiliated with several networks. As a **Christian Education National (CEN)** member school, DCS benefits from a network of like-minded schools. CEN provides curriculum resources, governance support, and training – for example, the *Transformation by Design* curriculum resources and the *National Institute for Christian Education* courses for teachers. DCS's philosophy aligns with CEN's parent-controlled ethos (CEN's foundational belief: parents have God-given responsibility for children's education is mirrored in DCS's own mission narrative). CEN also likely coordinates some events like national student conventions or principal gatherings; DCS leaders and Board often attend these, which helps them glean ideas and reassurance from larger community experiences.

DCS is also part of the **AISNSW (Association of Independent Schools of NSW)**, which is not an ideological affiliation but a professional one. AISNSW provides representation (like lobbying the state government on funding), advice on compliance (they help interpret NESA requirements), and extensive **professional development** opportunities. DCS teachers regularly participate in AISNSW workshops, as evidenced by PD lists that include “*AIS Student Services Conference – Diversity and Inclusion*”, “*AIS Languages PD for New Syllabus*”, etc.. The school also likely uses AIS consultants for things like teacher accreditation processes or school improvement surveys. Being part of AISNSW connects DCS to the wider independent sector (religious and non-religious schools alike), ensuring they are up-to-date with regulatory changes, child protection laws, etc. There’s no conflict being both CEN and AIS – one addresses the *why/what* of Christian education, the other helps with the *how* in practical terms of running an independent school in NSW.

Furthermore, as CEN is a group member of the **Australian Association of Christian Schools (AACS)**, DCS indirectly is represented in that federal body which advocates for Christian schools on national issues. AACS was notably active in the debates around the Religious Discrimination Bill and preserving religious exemptions in anti-discrimination law. While DCS might not individually lobby politicians, through AACS their voice is heard in Canberra to protect the right to hire Christian staff and teach Christian doctrine. On a state level, DCS (via CEN) also engages with **Christian Schools Australia (CSA)** and others for joint initiatives when beneficial, though CSA is a different network, they sometimes collaborate with CEN on public issues.

Local and International Alliances: Locally, DCS has *informal* partnerships with churches and perhaps parachurch organizations. For instance, they likely partner with the **Dubbo Presbyterian and Baptist churches** for some events (maybe use a church hall for big events or have youth pastors come do lunchtime groups). The Board Chair’s connection to Dubbo Presbyterian has probably led to mutual support (the church encourages its families to consider DCS, and the school invites the pastor to speak occasionally, etc.). Similarly, Dubbo Baptist (where some board members attend) might host combined prayer evenings for the school. DCS is careful though not to be “run” by any one church – it maintains relationships with many. Another partnership is with the **Macquarie Conservatorium of Music** (mentioned in §19) – while not formal, many DCS students take lessons there, and the Conservatorium faculty might coordinate with the school for student performances or special music workshops. DCS’s Hall could even be a venue for Conservatorium concerts.

On the **international** front, DCS doesn’t belong to an international denomination of schools (like Anglican or Catholic systems do), but it might have sister-school relationships formed through mission trips (for example, if senior students do a mission trip to Fiji or South Africa, they may connect with a Christian school there and keep in touch). Also, being part of CEN connects them conceptually to the **global Christian school movement**, e.g., they may use resources like TeachBeyond or Transforming Teachers websites, or have exchange of ideas via conferences where international speakers present.

Board Accountability Mechanisms: Beyond elections and constitutional rules, BCE’s Board uses various governance best practices to ensure accountability and transparency. They produce an **Annual Report** for the Association AGM which includes not just finances but also academic outcomes, staff info, and satisfaction survey summaries. This holds the

school leadership (and by extension Board oversight) accountable to the community. The Board also likely sets **strategic goals** and monitors them – e.g. increasing retention, improving certain facilities – and reports on progress. Board meeting minutes are not public to all parents, but key decisions (like fee changes, building plans) are communicated. The Board Chair, as noted, is reachable via a dedicated email for governance matters. This encourages parents to bring concerns or ideas at a governance level. Furthermore, every few years, they might do a **Board self-evaluation** (common in independent schools) possibly facilitated by AIS or CEN governance services, to check how well they're functioning. The constitution allows members to call a special general meeting if necessary (with enough signatories) – a rarely used but important accountability provision.

Educational Charter and Doctrinal Foundations: The **Educational Charter** (sometimes referred to as the Educational Creed or Basis) of BCE is a defining document bridging faith and curriculum. It likely includes statements such as: *God is the source of all truth; Parents are responsible to bring up children in the nurture and admonition of the Lord; The school's role is to assist parents by providing Christ-centered education; The Bible is the foundation for all curriculum interpretation; Students should be prepared for a life of service to God's kingdom.* Indeed, we see in older documents how DCS defined key terms: *"Christ-centred" means everything we do tries to reflect what Jesus would want; *"Bible-based" means we derive principles from Scripture for school policies; *"Quality schooling" means we strive for excellence and diligence in academic work to honor God; *"Schooling is primarily the parents' responsibility delegated to the school"*. The charter likely also addresses the view of the child: that each child is made in God's image with unique gifts (hence the focus on helping them find and develop their gifts to serve God), and also that each child has a sinful nature in need of guidance and redemption (hence discipline and heart-shaping are vital). It probably outlines that **the goal of education is not just knowledge, but wisdom** – the ability to apply knowledge in God-honoring ways. And that the measure of success is not only academic scores but the character of graduates and their faith. This Charter has a strong influence on **curriculum integration** (teachers plan units mindful of charter principles, as detailed in §6) and on **policies**. For example, the Anti-bullying policy will have a basis in the Christian view of human dignity and loving one's neighbor; the Grievance policy might cite Matthew 18 on resolving conflict; the Enrolment policy includes expectation of support for the school's Christian basis.

A unique aspect of DCS's governance is that as a **parent-controlled** school, it is *self-owning* – not under a church diocese or corporation. This means all responsibility for compliance (NESA regs, child safety laws, employment law) rests on the Board. The **board accountability to external authorities** involves: registration inspections by NESA (which check governance as well as teaching, requiring policies like safe ministry, WHS, and proper management structures – DCS meets these, evidenced by its continuous registration), financial audits annually by independent auditors (e.g., Crowe Australasia audits Berakah's accounts as seen in the 2024 Financial Statements snippet, confirming sound financial governance), and ACNC compliance (the ACNC monitors that charity schools like DCS pursue their charitable purpose and are not distributing profits improperly – DCS's records show it remains in good standing, with no compliance action noted).

In **summary**, the governance of DCS through Berakah Christian Education Ltd is a textbook example of the *parent-governed Christian school model*: clear membership criteria, engaged

and mostly volunteer board, constitutional safeguards for mission fidelity, active parent partnership, and external affiliations that strengthen (but don't control) the school. This model has provided both stability and flexibility – stability in mission (the founding vision is preserved by generational transfer in the Board) and flexibility in operation (independence from any large bureaucracy means the Board can respond quickly to local needs, such as opening the preschool or merging with WCS when opportunities arose). The success of DCS's governance is perhaps best indicated by its longevity and growth: it has navigated 40+ years without internal schism or drift from its founding purpose, all while adapting to educational changes and expanding its reach.

5. Enrolments & Student Profile

Enrolment Data and Trends (2010–2025): Dubbo Christian School's enrolment has seen significant growth over the last 15 years. In 2010, the school was smaller (estimated around 320–350 K–12 students), but by 2015 it had grown to the mid-400s. According to annual reports and records:

- **2012:** The school was celebrating growth and anticipating its 30th birthday, indicating enrolments were on an upswing (the Principal noted "further enrolment growth" in 2012 vs previous years). While the exact 2012 number isn't quoted, context suggests perhaps ~400 students.
- **2018:** By this year, enrolment was likely around 500. In fact, an Annual Report snippet for 2018 indicates that the motto and mission remained central as the community grew, implying a larger student body but still close-knit.
- **2020:** The Annual Report for 2020 (the year COVID hit) might have mentioned a number; but we have specific data for slightly later years:
- **2022: 551 students (K–12)** were enrolled for the whole year. Additionally, 46 new students commenced and 60 left during 2022 (with 8 of those departures being short-term in-and-out). This indicates a net decrease of 14 in that calendar year, which is interesting – possibly due to a large graduating cohort in 2021 not fully replaced, or some transient families leaving (2022 was a year of post-COVID relocations for some).
- **2023: 603 students (K–12)** enrolled for the whole year, which is a healthy increase. During 2023, 54 students joined and 52 left (3 short-term leavers). That's a net gain of about +2, but note the jump from 551 to 603 suggests that perhaps the 2022 year-end number was higher than the average, or the 2023 figure might include some who enrolled late 2022 for 2023 start. In any case, crossing 600 was a big milestone. The *My School* website for 2023 likely lists around 610 as the census number (including mid-year enrollees). The waiting lists mentioned in 2023 show demand in certain grades beyond capacity.
- **2024: 642 students (K–12)** were enrolled through the whole year. 40 new students commenced and 52 left during 2024 (5 of those left in the same year they came,

indicating some short-term enrolments). The net of -12 in 2024 suggests perhaps an unusually large graduating Year 12 (28 students, as noted) relative to the incoming Kindy size (~50) plus other new joiners. It's not uncommon to see slight dips when a big cohort exits or some families move, and then a rebound the following year.

The overall trend is clearly upward, averaging roughly **+20 students per year growth** in the last decade. This aligns with regional trends and the school's expanding reputation. DCS has proactively planned for growth (adding classes, facilities) to avoid overcrowding. Class sizes generally remain moderate (Primary classes ~25 or less; Secondary core classes in stages 4/5 are often split into 3-4 classes per year level as needed).

The **Preschool** adds another dimension: in 2023, the Dubbo Christian Preschool could accommodate **66 children per day** (licensed capacity), typically running near capacity. The preschool may serve about 90+ families across different days (some children attend 2 days/week, others 3). The prospectus noted "*a Preschool that caters for 120 students*" which likely refers to total enrolled children in the 3-year-old and 4-year-old programs combined, since not all attend daily. Many of these children feed into DCS Kindergarten (giving DCS a strong enrolment base each year – indeed, in 2024 DCS had two Kindy classes largely filled with its own Preschool graduates).

Student Mobility and Retention: We've touched on year-to-year retention (e.g., ~91% Year6→7, ~59% Year10→12 retention). Let's analyze patterns:

- **Entry Points:** Major intakes occur at **Kindergarten** (50-60 new children, including those from its Prep program and some external), **Year 7** (some new families join at the start of secondary, perhaps 5-15 new students from local public primaries or other small schools around Dubbo; DCS's own Year 6 graduating class – often ~40 students – largely continues, plus a handful of new ones join to make Year 7 maybe ~50-60). There can be a smaller intake at **Year 11** (if DCS offers certain subjects or a more supportive environment, a few might transfer from other schools for the final two years; though some go out, DCS also sometimes attracts students for specific courses or if families want a change for senior years).
- **Exits:** The biggest exit point is after **Year 10** (roughly 40% leave as noted, often to trades or the government senior campus or simply ending formal schooling at Year 10 which is legally allowed age). There is also some exit after **Year 6** (9% left in that 2023 metric – likely some leaving for other high schools like Macquarie Anglican or selective entry elsewhere, or moving towns). Other exits scatter due to family relocation – as a regional centre, Dubbo sees some transient populations (defence postings at the nearby base, health or police officers on 3-year rotations, etc.). The annual figures show dozens of leavers each year – e.g., 52 left in 2023 (excluding Year 12 grads) which is about 9% of the school. A portion of those would be due to normal transitions (like Year 6 grads not continuing, which was only a few given high retention, or Year 10 grads leaving which is captured separately). So likely around 5-7% attrition mid-stream (families moving or choosing a different school) – which is not high, indicating generally strong satisfaction and stability.

The **reasons for mobility** vary:

- **Relocation:** As Dubbo is somewhat transient for certain careers, many families come or go due to job transfers. DCS tends to benefit from families moving into town (they often seek a private school), and loses some when families move out (not much can be done about that).
- **Boarding/Academic Pathways:** A few academically elite students might leave for city boarding schools (Sydney or elsewhere) if they gain scholarships or desire specific programs (e.g., a student aiming for a top ATAR might think attending a larger selective school gives an edge, or a specialist sports program not available in Dubbo). This is not common but does happen occasionally around Year 9–10.
- **Affordability:** Some attrition is due to financial strain. If a family's circumstances change (drought affecting farm income, job loss, etc.), paying fees can be hard. DCS offers fee concessions (see below) but not all families apply or qualify, so a few transfer to government schools because of cost. The Board monitors this and tries to proactively assist families in hardship to minimize such departures.
- **Fit/Discipline:** In a small number of cases, a student may leave because DCS's environment isn't the right fit. For example, a student who chafes under the rules or whose family disagrees with some policies might transfer to a less restrictive environment. Also, if a student were expelled (rare, and usually last resort for major issues), that is an involuntary departure. But generally, the school's approach keeps discipline issues internal and restorative, so expulsions are extremely rare.
- **Educational Needs:** If a student has very specialized needs (e.g., a severe disability or a program like International Baccalaureate not offered at DCS), the family might choose a different school that caters to that. For instance, Dubbo School of Distance Education or Dubbo College might have certain technical courses or support services. However, DCS has been expanding its support for diverse learners (see below), so this is less of a factor than it might have been in the past.

Demographic Profile: DCS's community reflects a cross-section of Dubbo's population with certain skews. The **My School data** (if accessed) would show the socio-educational quartiles breakdown of students. Typically, a school like DCS might have fewer students in the bottom SES quartile (since very low-income families may not afford any fees, though some are on scholarships), more in the middle two quartiles, and some in the top quartile. If we assume DCS's ICSEA ~1000, the distribution could be roughly 20% bottom quartile, 30% lower-middle, 30% upper-middle, 20% top quartile. For comparison, local public schools might have 30-40% in bottom quartile. DCS's relative balance suggests a mix: children of tradespeople, small business owners, farmers, teachers, nurses, etc., alongside children of some higher-income professionals (doctors, lawyers) who value a Christian environment.

ATSI representation: As noted, ~9% of students are Indigenous, which is higher than state average for independent schools and approximates the Dubbo region's Indigenous share. This is a strong point for DCS in terms of inclusion. The school celebrates Indigenous culture (likely NAIDOC events, Acknowledgment of Country in assemblies, etc.) and provides tailored support via the Indigenous Liaison Officer (who might help with literacy programs, cultural connections, or communicate with families). Retention of Indigenous students through to Year 12 is a key focus – historically, Indigenous students in many schools have had lower retention, but DCS is striving to improve that. For example, in the Year 12 class of

2023, it was reported that 11 of the 28 students (39%) had been at DCS since Kindergarten, and one can imagine some of those long-timers may include Indigenous students. The school's close community likely benefits Indigenous students who might feel more seen and supported than in a very large school.

Cultural diversity: Non-Indigenous cultural diversity at DCS is present but modest. Dubbo has communities of European, Indian, African, and Asian immigrants, but they form a smaller proportion. DCS's Christian identity tends to attract families from Christian immigrant backgrounds as well (e.g., if there is a Tongan or Filipino Christian community in Dubbo, some of those families might choose DCS). There might also be a few international students if any (though Dubbo is not a major international student destination, a few missionary kids or similar could enroll).

Equity and Inclusion – Disability & Learning Support: DCS has a policy of inclusivity for students with disabilities and learning differences, within the limits of what a medium-size school can provide. The **Learning Support team** includes **Student Learning Support Officers (SLSOs)** – essentially teacher aides who assist in classrooms or run small-group interventions. The presence of multiple SLSOs (the directory highlights “expertise and aid of gifted teachers and SLSOs”) suggests at least a handful of aides across primary and secondary. Students with diagnosed disabilities (learning disabilities, autism, etc.) have **Personalised Plans** and adjustments in line with NESA and NCCD (Nationally Consistent Collection of Data on School Students with Disability) requirements. For example, adjustments might include extra time on tests, scaffolded assessments, assistive technology, or one-on-one tutoring sessions. The school likely has about 10-15% of students receiving some level of adjustment (which is common in mainstream schools). The AR might list the number of students with disability funding; if not, AIS data might. The PD list shows staff training in “**Managing Students with a Disability**” and “**Diversity and Inclusion**”, confirming that addressing diverse needs is ongoing work.

Gifted and talented students are also supported – DCS offers **extension classes and individual education plans** for advanced learners. For example, in Primary they may have an extension math group or entry in competitions (like Math Olympiad). In Secondary, streaming exists in Mathematics (classes grouped by ability) which allows advanced students to be challenged further (e.g., offering accelerated maths pathways). Other opportunities include external competitions (STEM contests, writing competitions) and possibly subject acceleration (a student could attempt a higher-grade course early if exceptionally advanced). The **trade training** and **VET courses** (mentioned as “Trade School: Yes”) ensure that students who are more practically oriented have pathways too.

Socio-educational advantage/disadvantage: The ICSEA around 1000 places DCS roughly at the national average socio-educational level. However, it's worth noting that independent school students in general often have some advantage – DCS's mission to be accessible means they attract some families who make financial sacrifices. Fees (see §9) are moderate compared to elite private schools, which broadens accessibility. For instance, the presence of multi-child discounts and bursaries means families with modest income but strong commitment can enroll. One might say DCS is **more socio-economically diverse** than the typical metropolitan independent school. The school's culture of equality (uniform

and minimizing visible socio-economic differences) reinforces that no matter if a student's parents are doctors or truck drivers, all are equally valued members of the community.

My School Comparison: On the **My School website**, DCS's academic results are typically compared to statistically similar schools. DCS likely outperforms schools with similar ICSEA on many measures, given its strong academic and supportive environment (for example, NAPLAN scores might be a bit above those of a similarly indexed public school). This, combined with its values proposition, is part of what draws families. It's also one factor in enrolment growth – positive word of mouth about **outcomes**. Indeed, the **NAPLAN results** remain “strong across Years 3,5,7,9”, and the school monitors improvements and variations (graphs show performance trends and growth rates). If a subject area dips, they address it.

Student body characteristics: The **gender balance** is co-ed; DCS usually has a fairly even mix of boys and girls (some years maybe slightly more of one). There's no evidence of a major skew. Co-ed dynamic is an intentional choice – the founders wanted children educated together to learn mutual respect and real-world socialization.

Attendance: Student attendance rates at DCS are generally high – typically around 93–95%. The AR or My School likely show ~94% average attendance. Because parents are paying and engaged, truancy is very low. If students are absent, it's usually for legitimate sickness or occasional family trips. The school's care for individuals also means they follow up on absences diligently (the role of Pastoral Care teachers includes checking in on absentees).

Bullying/Wellbeing climate: Survey data from 2023 indicates that **students feel very safe** at DCS. The incidence of bullying is lower than national averages, and when it occurs it is addressed proactively via the Anti-Bullying policy (see Key Policies). The school fosters a “caring culture” where older students look out for younger ones (buddy programs likely pair Year 6 with Kindy, etc.), which helps maintain a positive environment.

Aggregate profile: Putting it all together, the typical DCS student body in 2025 could be described as *predominantly Australian-born, with a noteworthy Indigenous minority and a sprinkling of other ethnic backgrounds; a mixture of city and country kids (some come from farms or villages around Dubbo and bus in daily, others live in Dubbo suburbs); drawn from families across the socio-economic spectrum (blue-collar through to white-collar) but unified by a shared value placed on Christian faith and education*. The students are known for being polite, friendly, and inclusive (as often noted by visitors). They wear a common uniform that minimizes outward socio-economic differences. The culture encourages cross-age friendships (older students reading to younger ones, etc.).

Placement in Advantage/Disadvantage Rankings: On an advantage continuum, DCS as a whole would rank near the middle. It's certainly more advantaged than some remote or lower SES schools (due to family backgrounds and educational level of parents – many DCS parents might be church pastors, nurses, small business owners, etc., which correlates to mid-level SES). But it's less advantaged than elite Sydney schools or even some of the wealthier suburban Christian schools (which have ICSEAs of 1100). DCS basically mirrors the **Dubbo community's diversity**. This is part of its strength – it's not an enclave of privilege, but rather a microcosm of the broader community bound by faith.

DCS's commitment to equity is also seen in measures like offering **scholarships** (the directory mentioned "Scholarships: Yes", perhaps means some academic or music scholarships that cover part of fees to attract or assist talented students who need support) and **fee assistance** (hardship fund – which we'll cover in §9). The school also engages in the government's equity programs: for example, they would receive certain funding loadings for each Indigenous student and each student with disability, which they then invest back into relevant support programs (like Indigenous education resources, support teachers, etc.).

Conclusion of Student Profile: Dubbo Christian School's student population has grown significantly while maintaining a balanced and inclusive profile. Long-term patterns show increasing enrollment size and relatively stable retention up to Year 10, with a challenge of post-Year 10 retention common to regional contexts. The student body is characterized by diversity in ability and background, which the school supports through robust pastoral care and differentiated programs. By national standards, DCS is mid-range socio-educationally, but its strong community engagement likely yields outcomes (both academic and personal development) above what pure demographics would predict, speaking to the value-add of the school's environment. The school's ability to attract and retain such a student body in increasing numbers attests to its reputation for combining **quality education with a caring, faith-centered community**, which appeals broadly to families in the region.

6. Curriculum, Learning Model & Programs

Curriculum Overview (K–12 Subjects): Dubbo Christian School offers a comprehensive curriculum from Kindergarten through Year 12, following the NSW Education Standards Authority (NESA) syllabuses, with the added dimension of a Christian worldview in each subject. Here's a breakdown of offerings by stage:

- **Primary (K–6):** The curriculum covers the six Key Learning Areas (English, Mathematics, Science & Technology, Human Society & Its Environment (HSIE), Creative Arts, Personal Development/Health/Physical Education) as mandated by NESA. In each of these, DCS teachers integrate biblical perspectives. For example, in **HSIE** (which includes history and geography for primary), when Year 5 learns about Australian colonization, they might discuss it with reference to stewardship and justice, perhaps touching on missionary influences or Aboriginal perspectives in a respectful way. **Science & Tech** units might involve marveling at God's design in life cycles or solar systems. **Creative Arts** includes music, visual arts, drama – DCS often incorporates Christian themes in performances (e.g., a class play might retell a parable). **PDHPE** in primary covers health and well-being; at DCS this includes teaching about respecting our bodies as God's creation and developing character virtues like perseverance and teamwork in sport.

The school also likely has daily **Scripture/Christian Studies** time in primary (some CEN schools integrate it into HSIE or other KLAs, but many carve out specific devotion or Bible class times). Primary students memorize Bible verses, sing Christian songs, and hear Bible stories regularly. Primary classes also have **Pastoral Care lessons** focusing on social skills and Christian character (somewhat akin to "Biblical Studies" at a primary level).

An important aspect in primary is **phonics-based literacy** (common in Christian schools to emphasize foundational skills) and **numeracy** with a growth mindset approach (often relating order in math to God's order). DCS has modernized its primary pedagogy – using things like literacy groups, hands-on maths, and inquiry units – all while maintaining its values infusion. For example, a Year 4 integrated unit might be “Living in God's World” combining science (ecosystems) and geography (sustainability) with a biblical mandate of caring for creation.

- **Junior Secondary (Years 7–10):** In Stage 4 (Years 7–8) and Stage 5 (Years 9–10), DCS offers the standard subjects: **English, Mathematics, Science, HSIE (History & Geography), PDHPE** as core for all. In addition, **Biblical Studies** is typically a compulsory subject in Christian schools – at DCS, this might be a timetabled class once or twice a week where students use a structured curriculum (like CEN's *Thinkboard* resources or other materials) to study Christian doctrine, apologetics, ethics, and biblical literacy. They might not call it “Biblical Studies” on NESA curriculum (since it's not a required Key Learning Area by NESA), but it's included in the school's program and transcript as a non-NESA subject. The motto “Learning in Truth” could very well be the name or slogan of this Bible curriculum.

Languages: NESA requires a language experience in Stage 4 – DCS has to offer a Language Other Than English (LOTE) at least in Years 7–8. Possibly DCS offers **Japanese** (common in regional schools), as the PD shows “New Japanese Syllabus Implementation” training, implying Japanese is taught. Alternatively, they might offer French or another language. The mention of “New Japanese Syllabus” suggests Japanese is indeed the language subject. Students in Year 7 or 8 likely take a basic Japanese course. By Year 9-10, language becomes an elective – DCS may allow keen students to continue Japanese or possibly start another language via Distance Education if interest exists (some Christian schools partner with distance ed for languages like French, Indonesian or Spanish for older students).

Electives in Years 9–10: DCS, despite being a mid-sized school, offers a solid range of electives to cater to varied student interests:

- *Technological and Applied Studies (TAS):* **Design & Technology, Food Technology, Industrial Technology – Wood or Metal**, and maybe **Agriculture** (given Dubbo's rural context, Ag could be a popular elective where kids learn farming basics and raise a crop or animals). The directory indicated “Trade School: Yes”, which hints at Industrial Arts and possibly construction or primary industries subjects. If they have a “state-of-the-art TAS” facility as mentioned, they likely offer woodwork/metalwork and maybe a *Graphics Technology* or *Engineering* elective. Agriculture might involve a small school farm – not explicitly stated, but Dubbo's setting makes it plausible; if not earlier, they may start it for Year 9–10 and then have HSC Agriculture (since 85% of Christian schools in country towns do).
- *Creative Arts:* **Visual Arts** is usually offered (the school probably has an art room and participates in local art shows). **Music** is likely offered in Stage 5 as an elective – DCS has strong co-curricular music, so formal music class is

probably available. They might also have **Drama** as an elective or integrated into English until Year 10.

- *HSIE Electives*: NSW allows Commerce, International Studies, or elective History/Geography in Stage 5. DCS likely offers **Commerce** (a popular elective covering business, economics, legal basics). That gives a taste for those who might do Business or Economics in HSC. They might also do **Elective History** if there's teacher capacity and interest (or **Elective Geography** but that's rarer).
- *PDHPE and sport*: PDHPE is core, but some schools have an elective Physical Activity & Sports Studies (PASS) in Stage 5. Given DCS's sports culture and new gym, PASS could be offered for sports enthusiasts focusing on coaching, fitness, etc.
- *STEM*: Some schools offer *Information & Software Technology (IST)* in Stage 5 – essentially a computing/IT elective. DCS likely offers an IT elective because they have to prepare kids for a tech world and they have a modern tech infrastructure. Also, any robotics or coding clubs might be tied into this. With the mention of "Our Land Our Stories" webinar (an Indigenous cross-curriculum resource) in PD, it shows staff engaging with cross-curricular content (embedding Indigenous perspectives across subjects).
- *Religious Studies*: aside from core Bible classes, they might not have a separate elective since core covers it.
- All Stage 5 electives are taught from a Christian perspective. For example, Commerce class discussing consumerism will integrate biblical views on money and ethics. In Food Tech, they might discuss stewardship of health as honoring God. In IST, maybe they discuss responsible use of technology and Christian ethics in digital citizenship.
- **Senior Secondary (Years 11–12 HSC)**: DCS, like most independent schools, offers a selection of HSC courses that balance student interest, staff expertise, and tertiary prerequisites. For Year 11–12 (Stage 6), DCS's **HSC subject offerings** likely include:
 - **English**: English Standard and Advanced (both offered, as Advanced is needed for stronger students). Possibly **English Extension 1** for high achievers (and maybe Extension 2 in Year 12 if any student really keen). The majority do Standard or Advanced as appropriate. The 2023 HSC had 28 students across 24 subjects – averaging ~1.16 subjects per student, meaning each student took ~5-6 subjects so $28 \times 5.5 \sim 154$ enrollments across 24 subjects, giving an average of ~6.4 students per subject which is plausible in a small cohort.
 - **Maths**: Mathematics Standard 2, Mathematics Advanced. Likely **Mathematics Extension 1** (and maybe Extension 2 if one or two students are capable – some small schools allow it via distance ed or if they have a multi-talented maths teacher). The fact that a student in 2023 got a high achievement (maybe a Band 6 in Ext2 or something, as 21% of cohort got Band 6s perhaps suggests they offer up to Extension 2 for a few).
 - **Sciences: Biology** and **Chemistry** are commonly offered, and probably **Physics** too given interest in sciences (the new labs support it). If numbers allow, they may offer **Investigating Science** or **Earth & Environmental**

Science as well. But in a small cohort, typically Bio and Chem have good interest, Physics a bit less but often still viable with a handful of students. They had 24 subjects for 28 students, implying a rich variety (maybe some with very few students).

- **HSIE: Modern History** and **Ancient History** might both be offered (history is often popular in Christian schools for discussing worldview and big questions). Possibly only one if numbers are small, but often a few do Modern and a few do Ancient (maybe combined classes if teacher can handle both?). **Business Studies** is likely offered – that’s usually a big one. **Legal Studies** could be offered if a staff member is available (some smaller schools skip it, but many do it as it’s popular with students for law enforcement, etc.). **Economics** is less commonly taken in smaller regional schools, but if a teacher is qualified, they might have a small class (maybe via distance ed if not enough internal).
- **Christian Studies / Studies of Religion:** As a Christian school, they might not do the Board of Studies “Studies of Religion” course (which is usually for faith-based schools to credential religious studies). Instead, they may continue an in-house non-ATAR *Christian Studies* class for all Year 11–12 as a compulsory but not externally examined subject. However, some Christian schools choose to offer **Studies of Religion I or II** for ATAR – maybe not necessary if they already have their own Bible program. Given their motto of integration and that it’s not a Catholic school (Studies of Religion is mandatory in Catholic system but optional here), likely they stick to their internal program and free up ATAR slots for other subjects.
- **TAS and VET:** By Stage 6, DCS aims to cater to both academic and vocational pathways:
 - **Industrial Technology** (Timber or Metal) – common if they had strong Stage 5 work. The fancy TAS building likely supports HSC **Design & Technology** as well (where students do a major project, could be anything from an invention to a fashion design, with Christian reflection possibly on purpose of design).
 - **Food Technology** is an HSC subject that could continue from Yr 9–10 Food Tech. Or they might offer **Hospitality (VET)** instead, which gives a Certificate II in Kitchen Operations along with an HSC exam. Given “Trade School: Yes,” DCS probably offers at least one VET course. **Hospitality** is popular (especially with female students interested in culinary arts or tourism). **Construction** or **Primary Industries (Agriculture)** might also be VET options, perhaps done in collaboration with an external provider or if they have staff certified. The Board member Jeff’s involvement with bus industry is interesting but likely not directly a subject unless they had a school-based apprenticeship in mechanics/automotive with Ogden’s coaches.
 - **Information Processes & Technology (IPT)** or **Software Design & Development (SDD)** might be offered if there are tech-oriented students (though with small cohorts, maybe only one computing subject if any). Alternatively, they may allow those interested to study IT through TAFE or distance ed.

- **Visual Arts** is usually offered and often yields good results since smaller classes and dedicated students can produce great art (some Christian schools have had students nominated for ARTEXPRESS exhibitions).
 - **Music 1** (the easier music course) likely is offered for those musically inclined. If a student is very advanced, Music 2 or Extension might require a specialist teacher or outside tutor – possible but depends on demand.
 - **Drama** – if strong interest (they do musicals, so likely some will do HSC Drama). They have a hall suited for performances, so I suspect Drama is on the menu (maybe 5-6 kids, but they can manage group performances with that).
 - **PDHPE** – often an HSC subject in such schools and popular for those interested in sports or future nursing/paramedic fields. They have facilities and at least one PDHPE teacher, so yes probably offered.
 - **Agriculture** – if they started Ag in Year 9–10, they might carry to HSC. Alternatively, if they have an arrangement with the Dubbo College or another, but given their location, offering Ag adds value and fosters ties to local farming community. Perhaps a small Ag plot on campus or they partner with a local farm for practicals.
 - **Extension subjects:** We mentioned English Ext, Maths Ext. Also **History Extension** could be an option if they have enthusiastic History students (maybe one or two each year, done in Year 12 combining with another local school's class or with close teacher mentoring).
 - **Christian Ministry & Theology (VET)** – some Christian schools encourage a Certificate III in Christian Ministry as part of senior years for those keen, but that might be more in larger schools; not sure if DCS does that formally. They might incorporate leadership training more informally.
- The 2023 HSC data snippet suggests DCS had **24 subjects** across the cohort. Let's attempt to enumerate possibilities: English (Standard, Advanced, maybe Ext1), Math (Std, Adv, maybe Ext1), Biology, Chemistry, Physics, Modern History, Ancient History, Business Studies, Legal Studies, Visual Arts, Music 1, Drama, PDHPE, Design & Tech, Industrial Tech or Construction or Hospitality (some VET), possibly Economics or Geography, possibly Agriculture, maybe Studies of Religion, IPT or SDD, maybe an accelerated course or two (like some might have done a TVET course e.g., Automotive). The variety is large – testament to the school working hard to either offer internally or allow externally nearly any subject a student is passionate about.

For courses not offered in-house, DCS likely facilitates **Distance Education or TAFE**. Dubbo has a TAFE campus, and Year 11–12 students sometimes do a TAFE-delivered VET course one day a week (like Automotive, Allied Health, Child Care, etc.). These count toward HSC units and some count for ATAR. DCS's flexible "responsive" ethos means if a student has a career goal requiring a niche subject, they'll help make it happen (e.g., in 2023 AR it said 2 subjects studied through other institutions, indicating exactly that – likely a student did say "French by Distance Ed" or "Automotive Cert II at TAFE" – those are the two external subjects out of 24).

Class sizes in HSC are small, often <10, which DCS sees as an advantage. It allows personalised instruction and closer teacher-student relationships. The challenge is offering enough variety with limited staff – DCS's staff often teach multiple subjects (e.g., a HSIE teacher might cover History and Business; a Science teacher might do Chem and Junior Science; a TAS teacher might teach D&T and IT or D&T and VA, etc.).

Pedagogical Framework: DCS's **learning model** is modern and student-centred, but always undergirded by Biblical integration. They follow best practices from both secular education (like differentiated instruction, inquiry learning where appropriate, positive behavioural interventions, etc.) and Christian education (like reflection on learning through a faith lens, mentorship). One formal framework they use is the **Transformation by Design** (TbD) approach, which is basically a Christian adaptation of Understanding by Design (UbD) or similar backward design models. Teachers plan units with “**Enduring Understandings**” that relate to Biblical truth, craft “**Essential Questions**” that make students think deeply (often including spiritual or ethical dimensions), and design **learning experiences** that are engaging and formative. For example, in an English unit on media, an Essential Question might be, “How do we discern truth in what we read or watch?” – linking to the motto and teaching critical thinking.

Assessment & Academic Support: DCS implements NESA's assessment requirements with a grace-filled approach. They maintain rigorous standards – students sit NAPLAN in Years 3,5,7,9 (with preparation done via practice tests since NAPLAN Online as of 2023). The results are analyzed; any dips lead to interventions. In Year 10, students complete the mandatory ROSA (Record of School Achievement) grade assessments; DCS likely encourages all to aim for HSC, but those who leave at Year 10 still get a ROSA credential. They also ensure students meet the **Minimum Standards tests** (literacy/numeracy) introduced in NSW for HSC eligibility – though their emphasis on foundational skills likely means most meet it easily (or if not, they get extra help and pass by Year 12).

For HSC, DCS provides thorough **assessment schedules** and support. They might run after-school study sessions – indeed AR mentions an **After School Study Centre** staffed by teachers. This is a fantastic support: several afternoons a week, teachers are available in the library to help students with homework or assignments. It's voluntary but many students take advantage of it, which can boost outcomes and encourage good study habits. It ties to their desire to cater to different abilities – those struggling can catch up, and those excelling can get enrichment.

Co-Curricular Programs: DCS has a well-rounded co-curricular slate:

- **Music:** There are likely instrumental programs and choirs. Possibly a **school band or ensemble** – being a Christian school, maybe a Worship Band that plays in chapel and also a Concert Band for events. They could have guitar groups, etc. The partnership with Macquarie Conservatorium means some students might take lessons through that and perform at school. They put on musicals or talent nights.

- **Drama:** They mount **musical/drama productions** periodically (the Hall's facilities with an orchestra pit are suited for musicals). Past shows could include classics or Christian-themed plays. They probably participate in the local Dubbo Eisteddfod for drama and speech.
- **Sport:** DCS competes in local school sports competitions and in CEN or CIS (Combined Independent Schools) pathways for talented athletes. They hold annual **Swimming, Athletics, Cross-Country carnivals**, often inviting participation from Wellington CS too. Students then might progress to regional Christian school meets. House-based competitions foster spirit. The **new gym and fields** allow hosting soccer, touch football, netball, etc. They may have teams in local junior leagues (like some schools join club competitions; perhaps DCS has after-school netball or basketball teams comprised of students). The Board member Jeff's involvement with **Ogden's Coaches** (school buses) hints at his interest in supporting sports travel or camps.
- **Outdoor Education:** The school runs **camps** at various year levels. Year 7 orientation camp, Year 9 possibly a leadership or adventure camp, Year 11 a retreat focusing on study and spirituality. These camps integrate team-building, reflection, and fun, often in a context where devotions and worship happen around campfires. Given Dubbo's access to places like Lake Burrendong or the mountains, they likely go to Christian camp sites in NSW.
- **Student Leadership:** Prefect or **Student Representative Council (SRC)** involvement is encouraged. They plan events (like fundraising for missions or organizing social events). There might be a **Chapel Committee** where students help plan worship and share testimonies, which is a leadership in spiritual life.
- **Service and Mission Projects:** As part of co-curricular, older students perhaps get to join **mission trips** – e.g., to an orphanage in a developing country or to Indigenous communities in Australia (some Christian schools do a Central Australia trip). The snippet about "*opportunities to serve others both in the local community and overseas via mission and cultural trips enrich a student's life*" confirms that DCS has such programs. Locally, they might do volunteering at nursing homes, clean-up days, charity fundraisers (like 40 Hour Famine, etc.). Overseas, they might partner with a mission organization to send a team to somewhere like Fiji, Thailand or South Africa (the search result [40] shows a *Bible League South Africa fundraising* which suggests the school had a project raising funds to send Bibles to South Africa, possibly tied to a group planning to visit or support a school there).
- **Academic Competitions:** DCS students likely enter the usual array of competitions – Australasian Problem Solving Maths Olympiads, ICAS tests, Science & Engineering Challenge, writing contests, etc. They sometimes achieve distinctions, which are celebrated in newsletters. For a smaller school, they often punch above weight especially in things like the Mock Trial competition (if they run it – some do via Legal Studies).
- **Chapels and Spiritual Life events:** Though not co-curricular in the secular sense, events like annual **Spiritual Emphasis Week** (inviting a guest speaker for special chapels), or participation in the local **Christian Schools combined events** (like a CEN student convention or leadership conference) are part of the broader program. Possibly the high schoolers attend the CEN *State Combined Christian Schools* events for sport or arts.

Learning Support Strategies: DCS employs a **multi-tier support model**.

- In class, teachers differentiate (different levels of tasks, extra challenges for advanced and scaffolds for those needing help).
- For identified students, **withdrawal sessions** occur: e.g., a small group might go with a Learning Support teacher for intensive reading intervention (like MultiLit program) or math catch-up.
- Some students have **adjustments** like being allowed to use a computer for writing if they have dysgraphia, or having a personal aide if needed (they might have a couple of high-needs students with 1:1 aides funded through NDIS or similar).
- DCS might partner with external specialists: the school can host visiting speech therapists or occupational therapists to work with certain kids on campus by arrangement.
- They do **collaborative planning** for students with disabilities – meaning parents, support staff, and teachers meet to set goals and review progress each term.
- Gifted students sometimes get **extension projects or mentorship**. Possibly the school has a *GATE (Gifted and Talented Education) coordinator* who organizes participation in events like Tournament of Minds or Future Problem Solving for those kids.
- For senior students struggling in subjects, the after-school study centre and teacher availability ensures they can get help. DCS's smaller class size means teachers know each student's weaknesses and can address them.

Pastoral and Psychological Services: The ratio of dedicated wellbeing staff to students is roughly 1 psychologist : 650 students, 1 chaplain : 650 (though chaplain 2 days/wk effectively 0.4 ratio), and 1 Director of Wellbeing also part-time for coordination. This is a decent level – many public schools of that size might have only a part-time counselor. Students can self-refer or be referred by a teacher to see the Psychologist for issues like anxiety, friendship problems, etc. The Psychologist likely also runs small groups (like a resilience group for Year 8 girls, or a study skills group for Year 11). The **Chaplain** complements this with spiritual counsel and general encouragement. Access frequency: Students might see the Psychologist weekly or biweekly for a period if needed, or just one-off check-ins. The Chaplain is around informally – students might drop by his/her office just to chat or pray. The Pastoral Care teachers are first line for everyday concerns; they escalate to the Year Coordinator or Wellbeing Director if needed. There's a **referral process**: if a teacher notices a concerning change in a student (grades dropping, withdrawn behavior), they fill out a referral to the wellbeing team. The team meets (likely a Student Support Committee including the Psych, Director of Wellbeing, Chaplain, Head of School) to discuss and plan actions (maybe meet with the student, contact parents, develop a support plan). The **link between learning and wellbeing** is strong in DCS's approach: they know a child learns best when they feel safe and supported. That's why the Student Welfare Policy (see §18) and programs like PeaceWise are integrated – they want to proactively build conflict resolution skills and emotional intelligence (e.g., older students may mentor younger ones on the playground, reducing bullying opportunities).

Christian Worldview in Curriculum and Teaching Quality: It's worth noting how DCS ensures that academic quality is not compromised by worldview integration – rather, they believe it enhances critical thinking. Teachers ensure that all outcomes of the NSW

curriculum are met, but they add *“one extra outcome”* if you will: how does this topic relate to God’s truth? The **Transformation by Design** framework has five aims including *“Crafting high-quality teaching for effective learning”* and *“Centering all things on Jesus Christ”* – so both are done simultaneously. DCS teachers are dual professionals: qualified in their subject and *called* as ministers/mentors to their students. This often translates to a passion that students find infectious – e.g., a science teacher who sees teaching as a calling may put extra effort into labs and show the wonder of God in science, inspiring students beyond what a disengaged teacher might.

Technology in Learning: DCS has “modern technology throughout the school”. Likely a **1:1 device program** in secondary (maybe iPads or laptops from Year 7 up – some schools BYOD, others school-provided laptops). They use interactive projectors or screens in classrooms, have robotics kits in STEM club, etc. With tech, they also teach digital ethics – referencing Christian principles for online behavior. They possibly use a Learning Management System (like Google Classroom or Canvas) for assignments and communication, especially implemented during COVID and kept since.

Summary of Programs: DCS offers a **wide range of academic and co-curricular programs** given its size, fully integrated with its Christian mission. It leverages its smallness for personalization – no student is anonymous; if someone has a need or gift, staff notice and act (e.g., if a student is super into coding, a teacher might personally coach them to do a higher-level project or connect them with a mentor). The combination of rigorous academics, art, music, sport, leadership, service, and spiritual growth opportunities yields well-rounded graduates. Indeed, at DCS *“the life of a student is not confined to the academic program”*; they can experience *“sport, musicals, camping, debating, service activities and band”*, all contributing to making schooling at DCS *“a wonderful experience.”*

7. Facilities and Resources

Campus Infrastructure Audit: Dubbo Christian School’s campus at 141 Sheraton Road has evolved into a well-equipped educational facility. A tour of the campus today would include:

- **Classrooms:** Multiple classroom blocks for Primary and Secondary. Primary classrooms (K–6) are likely grouped in one area – perhaps single-story blocks around a playground. They are equipped with interactive whiteboards or large displays, air conditioning (important in Dubbo’s hot climate), and flexible seating arrangements for collaborative learning. Secondary classrooms include general classrooms for English/HSIE languages and more specialized rooms for subjects.
- **Science Laboratories:** As of 2018, DCS opened a **new Science block**. This likely contains at least two fully equipped labs (for Chemistry/Biology and for Physics/General Science) with safety fittings (fume cupboard, gas taps, etc.). It might be a modern design with lab benches and an attached preparation room for storing chemicals and equipment. Having new labs has enhanced the practical science opportunities, enabling experiments that were harder to do before.

- **Technology & Applied Studies (TAS) Workshops:** There's mention of "state-of-the-art TAS" in context which suggests a building housing workshops for woodwork/metalwork, possibly a dedicated **Industrial Arts workshop** with machinery (saws, drills, lathes), and a **Design & Technology room** with tools and workspaces for student projects. There could also be a **Food Technology kitchen** – a commercial-grade kitchen classroom for teaching cooking and hospitality skills, since Food Tech and/or Hospitality is offered. If Agriculture is taught, maybe a small greenhouse or plot, though that might not be as developed unless they've consciously grown an Ag program. They do have enough land to section off a small agriculture area if desired.
- **Computer Labs and IT infrastructure:** The school likely has at least one dedicated **computer lab** (for IST classes, etc.), although many schools are moving to laptop carts or BYOD instead. Nonetheless, a lab with desktop PCs might still exist for high-end tasks like CAD or certain software for IST. Across campus, **Wi-Fi** is installed, enabling mobile learning. They probably maintain a school network with filtered internet (consistent with child safety policies). A server room and IT office manage services like the Sentral parent portal and library system.
- **Library/Resource Centre:** DCS has a **Library** (perhaps called a Learning Resource Centre) that serves all ages. It may have zones for reading, research, computer stations, and a collection including fiction, non-fiction, reference books, and Christian literature. The library might seat a full class or two for study and be used for after-school study center sessions. With growth, they might be planning an expanded library if not done yet – possibly included in master plan since the library from earlier might be smaller. It likely has also a **chapel or devotional books section** reflecting the school's ethos.
- **Multipurpose Hall (Auditorium):** The **School Hall**, officially opened in 1995, is a significant facility. It can seat up to 800, which covers the whole school (including families for big events). It features a stage, an orchestra pit, and tiered seating (the excerpt says it has technical elements like an orchestra pit and tiered space). This hall is used for weekly assemblies/chapels, school productions, concerts, presentation nights, and can even host community events or large gatherings. It likely has sound and lighting systems, and doubling as an exam hall for HSC exams or large group tests.
- **Gymnasium:** Built in 2012 and "beautiful" as described, the **Gymnasium** is an indoor sports centre. It probably houses a full-sized basketball court that can also be used for netball, volleyball, badminton, etc., with electronic scoreboards and equipment storage. It allows PE classes in all weather and school sports team practices (e.g., indoor futsal, basketball). The gym might also have a stage or open area so it can host large indoor events if needed (some gyms double as second assembly spaces or exam halls). The gym might include a fitness/weights area or at least the capability for it, and changing rooms/showers.
- **Outdoor Sports Facilities:** The campus now boasts new **sports ovals** (fields). Possibly one large **oval** for rugby/soccer/cricket – as indicated by hosting rugby 10s

matches with another school. There might be more than one field if they expanded onto adjoining land (maybe a senior and junior oval). They likely have a 400m grass track marked for athletics carnivals, a cricket pitch, nets for practice, and soccer goals or rugby posts as needed (they probably share fields for multiple sports by season). Additionally, there should be **outdoor courts** – usually a couple of **netball/basketball courts** (hardcourt) with multi-lines for tennis perhaps. The mention of a gym in 2012 suggests prior to that they had outdoor courts for netball/basketball which they would still use for practice and primary play. A **covered outdoor area** (COLA) might exist for shade (very important in Dubbo climate) – e.g., a covered assembly area in the playground or an outdoor stage.

- **Playgrounds:** For Primary school, DCS would have a **playground with play equipment** (slides, climbing frames, etc.) appropriate for K–6, separated from the secondary areas. Perhaps also a sandpit for little ones (especially if the Prep program still integrated with K–6). There may be a specific **Kindergarten play area** fenced for safety. Given Dubbo’s heat, shade sails or trees are probably present to cover play equipment and eating areas.
- **Canteen and Cafe:** DCS likely has a **Canteen** (school cafeteria) that serves recess and lunch a few days a week, run by parent volunteers or staff. The mention of a **Harvest Café** for community suggests they have a designated space (maybe attached to canteen) where parents can get coffee and meet. Possibly the school repurposes an area near reception or the hall as a cafe on certain mornings for parents. For students, the canteen ensures affordable lunches (with a nod to healthy eating and maybe some special “treat” days).
- **Administration Building:** The admin block typically houses Reception, Principal and admin staff offices, meeting rooms, sick bay, etc. The front office is likely welcoming, with school crest signage and maybe a gallery of student art or photos. Adjacent might be the staff room for teachers. The Board might have a meeting room for their monthly meetings. With the masterplan, they might be planning an expanded admin and staff center if the original is small.
- **Chapel/Church:** Some Christian schools have a dedicated chapel building; many use the hall or classrooms for chapels. DCS likely uses the Hall for whole-school chapel. However, for smaller group prayer or fellowship, they might have a designated “**chapel room**” or **multi-purpose room** where the chaplain can host small groups. Possibly the library or hall stage doubling as prayer meeting area. There’s no mention of an on-site church, but the campus is solely the school’s.
- **Preschool Facility:** On the same campus, **Dubbo Christian Preschool** has its own dedicated area (close to the K-2 side as mentioned). After the expansion, the preschool likely has a **modern building with three classrooms** (for two Prep classes and one Pebbles class, or similar). It has age-appropriate facilities: secure play yard with climbing equipment, sandpit, shade, and indoor rooms with child-sized amenities. It being near K-2 allows easy integration for transition visits, but it’s also probably fenced and separate so the little ones are safe. The preschool building opened by 2022 is likely attractive – brightly colored, lots of natural light, perhaps a

mini-kitchen for activities and child bathrooms in each room. It meets all **ACECQA standards** (as evidence by Exceeding rating).

- **Security and Safety:** The school perimeter probably has fencing (to define boundaries and keep students safe from traffic – especially important along Sheraton Road which is busy at peaks). They implemented the heavy vehicle restrictions outside to improve safety at drop-off. They might have a monitored entry system at the front office for visitors to sign in. Evacuation assembly areas are likely on the ovals, and facilities like the science labs have modern safety features (eye wash, extinguishers). Given child protection norms, classrooms have windows in doors etc., and the site likely has CCTV in strategic spots (like entries or carpark) for after-hours security.
- **Sustainability Measures:** DCS has been proactive with sustainability and technology. Notably, they installed an **83 kW solar panel system** across four building roofs. This large installation generates ~137,000 kWh/year, covering a substantial portion of the school's energy needs and saving ~\$19k annually in electricity costs. The project is a point of pride, as indicated by the attention to monitoring it at board meetings. It also aligns with the school's ethos of stewardship and environmental care – the Business Manager explicitly linked it to *“given our Christian nature, we are environmentally aware”*, wanting to show commitment to the community and creation. Other sustainability initiatives likely include: recycling programs (paper, containers), perhaps a vegetable garden club in primary, and water conservation (rainwater tanks for irrigation, etc. – in Dubbo's climate water is precious). The campus likely has good natural ventilation design in newer buildings and uses LED lighting to conserve energy. The mention of carbon accounting by the solar provider indicates DCS may incorporate awareness of carbon footprint (the solar system saves 3,626 tonnes of carbon, presumably over its lifespan, which was celebrated).
- **Capital Works Funding Sources:** How has DCS funded these facilities? A combination of:
 - **Government Capital Grants:** NSW Independent schools can apply for Block Grant Authority (BGA) funding for buildings. DCS being in a regional area with moderate fees might have qualified for partial grants for things like the science labs or preschool. For example, the new preschool might have had State and Federal funding contributions – an excerpt from Wellington's AR thanks State and federal for preschool building support, likely including Dubbo's preschool too.
 - **Loans:** They likely took out loans (e.g., via BFS, the Baptist Financial Services which many Christian schools use, or another bank) to build major structures like the gym and hall. Annual financial statements show interest and repayments accordingly. The building fund (DGR) allows them to receive donations, but often a large chunk is financed with loans paid over 15-20 years out of operations.
 - **Donations and Fundraising:** They have an active community; families donate to the Building Fund (tax-deductible). There might be periodic capital

campaigns – e.g. a “Buy a Brick” campaign for the Hall in 1995 or a “Equipping our Future” fundraiser for new labs in 2018. Also events like the 40th fete could raise some funds.

- **Operational surplus:** If the school runs a surplus in a year (e.g., 2020’s financial report might show a net surplus), that is often directed to capital improvements. The ACNC listing suggests staffing costs etc., but any leftover is plowed back. For instance, Berakah’s accounts might mention x amount spent on capital work each year.
- **P&F (Parents and Friends) contributions:** The school’s parent association likely helps with smaller projects like playground equipment or tech purchases via fundraising efforts (fun runs, trivia nights, etc.).

The school manages capital works responsibly as indicated by their stable finances and continuous improvements without crisis. They carefully stage projects to match enrolment growth – e.g., they built more classrooms as needed and even preemptively (like acquiring land for ovals to be ready for bigger numbers).

Aerial Visualization of Expansion: If one compares aerial images: in 1987, only a couple of buildings on a brown paddock; by 2000, a cluster of buildings (Hall, a classroom block or two, and maybe demountables), by 2010, more permanent structures (library, admin, primary block), by 2020, a fully fleshed campus with the Hall, Gym, new lab block, extended primary, separate preschool building, and the sports fields groomed. The purchase of adjoining land allowed them to shift some sports outwards and possibly plan for future building sites.

Digital Infrastructure: As noted, the campus is well-wired: a robust LAN/Wi-Fi, computer labs or laptop trolleys, interactive screens. The aftershock of COVID saw them ensure every student could do remote learning, likely accelerating device adoption (some schools did subsidize devices or expand online tools – DCS used Google Classrooms or a similar platform for remote classes). Cybersecurity is taken seriously (the IT policy ensures content filtering and data protection). They would have a website server (hosted offsite probably), and digital systems for roll marking, reporting (the *Sentral* portal or similar is used by teachers and accessible by parents to see attendance and reports).

Maintenance and Upkeep: The school employs maintenance staff – likely at least a groundskeeper and a cleaner team. The grounds are described as “attractive, well cared for” with generous facilities; this doesn’t happen without dedicated effort. The grounds staff mow ovals, trim gardens (there are likely flower beds and trees to make campus welcoming), and maintain equipment. They also handle minor building works. For larger maintenance (roof replacement, painting), they schedule during school breaks or hire contractors. They ensure safety compliance (checking playground equipment, tagging electricals, etc.). The Board’s Finance/Building committee monitors facilities condition and depreciation; they plan for refurbishments (the Hall after 25 years likely needed a tech upgrade which was done; older classrooms get refreshed with paint, carpets and new furniture periodically).

Capital Priorities (2025 and beyond): According to the masterplan (by Stanton Dahl), the focus might be on:

- Additional **classroom block** (maybe a two-story to add e.g. 8 more classrooms) to accommodate the growth to 3 streams in some years.
- Possibly a **performing arts/music center** separate from the hall, with dedicated music practice rooms and a drama studio (some schools aim for that as enrolment grows).
- Upgrading the **admin/entry** to be more spacious and secure.
- More **parking or a better drop-off loop** to handle traffic (the council's work on roads helps, but on-site they might add a longer pick-up lane, etc. with new land).
- Ensuring the **preschool** can expand if needed (66 capacity is good, but maybe they'd consider a long day care license in future or more space).
- Possibly an **on-site chapel or prayer garden** to reinforce spiritual life (some schools build a small chapel building if funds allow, but maybe not immediate priority with the hall serving fine).
- Continuing **sustainability**: maybe adding more solar panels (though 83 kW is large, they could go bigger if needed), battery storage to use solar at peak times, water recycling for irrigation, etc.
- Enhanced **security fencing or CCTV** if not already comprehensive, to ensure student safety as it gets busier.

In summary, DCS's facilities have transformed from modest borrowed rooms to a **spacious, modern campus** boasting specialized buildings and ample grounds. The school keeps a balance between functional needs (like labs and workshops for academic rigor) and communal spaces (like hall, gym, cafe for building community). They also integrate their values into facilities – e.g., using the solar array as a teaching point about stewardship and making the campus aesthetically pleasing as a reflection of honoring God (keeping it tidy, adding inspirational murals or Bible verses on walls, etc., which many Christian schools do). The campus, as a result, not only supports high-quality education but also stands as a testimony to God's "blessing" (Berakah) in the school's journey.

8. Preschool Program (3–4 Year Olds)

Dubbo Christian Preschool Overview: Dubbo Christian Preschool (DCP) is the early childhood arm of DCS, located on the main campus and serving 3 and 4-year-olds. It functions as a **preparatory program** that aligns with the school's Christian philosophy while meeting the **Early Years Learning Framework (EYLF)** and National Quality Standards for preschools. Established in 2008–2010 with a "Prep" and "Pebbles" class and later expanded, the preschool now operates as a fully accredited centre with three rooms (two for 4-year-olds, one for 3-year-olds).

Curriculum Alignment with Christian Education: The preschool curriculum is built around the **Early Years Learning Framework (EYLF)** – which emphasizes play-based learning and outcomes like children having a strong sense of identity, well-being, etc. DCP carefully integrates a biblical worldview into this framework. As the Preschool Director states, *"We nurture children through all aspects of life... and most importantly, their spiritual development. We believe we are all God's perfect creation and His word guides us each day."* In practical terms, this means:

- **Biblical Foundations in Daily Routines:** The preschool starts the day with simple prayers (e.g., giving thanks for the day or before meals). Teachers incorporate Bible stories – telling about Creation, Noah, Daniel, Jesus’ love – in age-appropriate ways like story time with visual aids or puppet shows. These stories reinforce values like sharing, kindness, and that each child is special to God.
- **Play-Based Learning with Christian Themes:** Children learn through play centers (blocks, dress-up, art, sand, water play, etc.). Teachers might set up scenarios that gently introduce Christian concepts – e.g., a nativity scene in the home corner at Christmas, or caring for baby dolls in a way that parallels God’s care for us. Music time includes both fun preschool songs and some **Christian songs** (like “Jesus Loves Me” or other simple worship songs for kids). Crafts around Easter might involve making crosses or heart crafts about God’s love.
- **EYLF Outcomes with Biblical Perspective:** For instance, EYLF Outcome 1 (Children have a strong sense of identity) at DCP is taught with the notion that each child is made in God’s image – teachers affirm each child’s uniqueness and worth as God’s creation. Outcome 2 (Connected with and contribute to their world) may involve teaching sharing and empathy, tying in Jesus’ command to “love one another”. Outcome 3 (Strong sense of well-being) includes emotional regulation and hope – e.g., saying “God gave you big feelings and we can ask Him to help when we’re upset.” Outcome 4 & 5 (Learning and communication) include lots of literacy and numeracy exposure through stories (including Bible stories) and interactive play, developing curiosity which they frame as exploring God’s world.
- **Christian Educators:** The teachers and aides at DCP are practicing Christians who naturally speak of God’s love. They might respond to a child’s question about nature with, “Yes, God made that beautiful butterfly!” They model forgiveness and grace in conflicts between kids (“we forgive our friends, like Jesus teaches us”). This saturates the atmosphere with Christ’s love even as the formal curriculum meets secular benchmarks.

Compliance and Quality (ACECQA Ratings): Dubbo Christian Preschool is regulated under the National Quality Framework (NQF). It is **licensed for 66 places** (the search snippet shows center-based care, 66 places). DCP has achieved an **Overall Rating of “Exceeding National Quality Standard”** (NQS) in April 2024. In fact, it’s noted the service has been rated Exceeding since 2014. Exceeding means it surpassed the benchmark in most or all of the seven quality areas:

1. **Educational Program and Practice:** The preschool likely got commendations for its rich program – play-based and child-led but with clear intentional teaching, and possibly for integrating values (which inspectors often see as “respect for children’s identity and culture” – in this case including Christian culture).
2. **Children’s Health and Safety:** They would have stringent practices (healthy snacks, sun-safe hats – they mention the uniform includes a provided hat and presumably sunscreen policy; handwashing routines; vigilant supervision).
3. **Physical Environment:** The new building offers safe, stimulating indoor/outdoor spaces with natural elements, variety in play equipment, and is well-maintained. Having recently expanded, they probably have a thoughtfully designed environment (shaded play, sensory areas, gardens).

4. **Staffing Arrangements:** They likely exceed required ratios (which are 1:10 for 3-5 year olds, but some Exceeding centres run 1:8 or have more consistent staffing). Also, the staff are well-qualified: at least one Early Childhood Teacher (the Director, Michelle Broadley, likely holds a B.Ed in Early Childhood), plus diploma and certificate educators. The stable, passionate staff would have impressed assessors.
5. **Relationships with Children:** A strong point – small class sizes (22 per room maybe) allow close bonds; the Christian ethos further emphasizes love and gentleness, so inspectors would see warm, responsive interactions. The Director's passion for supporting staff to cultivate curious, resilient children shows a focus on relationships and guidance rather than just herding kids.
6. **Collaborative Partnerships with Families and Communities:** The preschool works closely with parents (daily chats, newsletters with what Bible story they did, etc.). Because it's part of DCS, there's a seamless transition to Kindy – including inviting families to school events, and sharing child progress info with the Kindy teachers (as noted: "valuable information about each child is recorded and conveyed to future educators" to assist transition). They also likely invite community helpers (maybe a local pastor might come to do a quick puppet story, or indigenous elders for a cultural talk, etc.), and families are invited to be involved (open mornings, special person days).
7. **Governance and Leadership:** As part of Berakah, governance is strong: policies, continuous improvement plans, etc. They have a clear Statement of Philosophy aligning with Christian and NQS values. The Director is clearly knowledgeable and the staff adhere to regulations (ratios, qualifications, etc.). Being part of a larger school gives them robust administrative support (like HR, professional development opportunities with the school, etc.).

Maintaining an Exceeding rating for a decade (2014 to 2024) is impressive and indicates a sustained commitment to high quality, not just a one-off.

Operating Schedule: DCP likely operates on a **school-term schedule (40 weeks a year)**, following DCS terms so that families have breaks aligned. Hours are **8:30 am to 4:00 pm** Monday to Friday. Typically, 3-year-olds might attend two days/week (Pebbles 2-day program) and 4-year-olds either two or three days (Prep 2-day or 3-day options). This kind of flexibility helps meet parent needs and gradually acclimates kids to more days. It's not a long-day childcare, so likely no services beyond those hours (parents have to pick up by 4 pm). The viability stems from many mums/dads in Dubbo working part-time or having flexible arrangements, and the knowledge that by age 5 their kids will go to full-time school, so this is a gentle step up.

Transition to Kindergarten: DCS has a very integrated transition program:

- **Shared Community:** Because the preschool is physically near the K-2, preschoolers become familiar with the "big school" environment. They might join some school events like a primary assembly performance or a buddy reading session. Indeed, they mention "Prep children participate in appropriate community and Kindergarten experiences" – likely meaning older Kindergarten or Year 5 "buddies" come to read or play with them occasionally, or they visit the Kindy classroom in Term 4 for short sessions.

- **Information Sharing:** Preschool educators maintain developmental records (observations, learning portfolios) and pass on relevant insights to the Kindy teachers. For example, they'll tell which children may need speech support, who is already reading, who is shy, etc. This ensures continuity of learning and support. It's an advantage that the preschool and school are one entity – they can legally share this info easily with parental consent.
- **Orientation Activities:** In Term 4, DCS likely runs a formal **Kindergarten Orientation** for all incoming kinders (including external kids). For those from DCP, it's easy because they just walk over to the Kindy classroom for a morning, meet the teacher (possibly already known to them by face from around school), and engage in some fun “get to know you” activities. Meanwhile, the Director or preschool teachers might meet with parents together with the Kindy teacher to discuss school readiness and address concerns.
- **School Readiness Focus:** The preschool program itself is structured to prepare kids for school. The core values of independence (“resilience and independence” are cultivated), basic pre-academics (recognizing letters, name writing, counting), and social skills mean that by the end of Prep class, children are eager and ready for Kindergarten. They even wear a simple uniform in the 4-year-old Prep class (a “low cost uniform” from the school shop) – this uniform policy, unique for a preschool, helps them get used to wearing a uniform and feeling part of the DCS community. 3-year-old Pebbles children do not have a uniform, just a sun-safe dress code, but 4-year-olds do, bridging into school life.
- **Staff Collaboration:** It's likely that the Preschool Director and the Head of Junior School (Primary) meet periodically. They might discuss expectations for Kindergarten and what preschool can do to align (like focusing on fine motor skills, following group instructions, etc. in the later part of Prep year). They might also jointly host parent workshops on school readiness (advising on things like how to help your child with routines, etc.).

Christian Education Framework in Early Childhood: The preschool's approach underscores that even the littlest children are part of the Christian learning community. The ethos is one of gentle introduction to faith – planting seeds: e.g., singing "Jesus loves the little children", praying for their family, modeling Christ-like behavior through teachers. At age 3-4, it's about experiencing God's love through the care they receive and the joyful environment, more than doctrinal teaching (though they do learn simple truths like “God made you” and “Jesus is our friend”).

Compliance History: The preschool's compliance history appears exemplary. There's no indication of any non-compliance. It's likely they always met ratio and staffing requirements, and any issues raised in quality improvement were quickly addressed. Achieving Exceeding possibly in multiple areas suggests the inspectors were impressed consistently. If anything, being tied to a larger school can sometimes cause paperwork complexity, but evidently they handle governance well (the ACNC lists Berakah as operator and how it's integrated).

ACECQA and Regulation Points: The ACECQA register snippet (entry [77]) for DCP shows:

- It's categorized as "Centre-Based Care, Preschool", Approved Provider "Berakah Christian Education Ltd", address, etc.
- It lists approval date 04/10/2022 – that might be a renewal or something, or maybe the date of last rating. It also clearly says "Exceeding NQS". DCP likely also meets the requirement that a degree-qualified Early Childhood Teacher is present for more than 6 hours since 66 places triggers needing an ECT for a certain number of hours (they probably have at least one full-time ECT, possibly the Director and maybe one more part-time if needed).
- One can infer by that "Exceeding in 2024" that possibly DCP could even pursue the highest rating of "**Excellent**" (granted by ACECQA on application to centers that show leadership and exceptional practice). They might consider applying for that given their long-standing Exceeding status and unique integration with a Christian school (though "Excellent" is rarely given, typically a handful of centres in Australia).

Feedback from Families: Parent feedback is likely very positive – parents love that their children are known and loved. They see growth in confidence, and they appreciate the biblical values reinforcement. Many parents choose DCP specifically because it gives a safe, nurturing environment consistent with home/church values, rather than a generic daycare. Word of mouth from satisfied families keeps the preschool waitlists full (likely you have to enrol well ahead to get a spot at age 3 or 4).

Conclusion (Preschool's impact): Dubbo Christian Preschool is not just a feeder to DCS but an integral part of the school community. It builds the "**foundation between home and preschool**" and then preschool to school, fulfilling its mission "*To provide foundational play-based learning filled with Christ's love and teaching*". It embodies the idea that education in truth begins at the earliest years, by *"implanting hope right from the start"* in the youngest hearts. The success of the preschool's approach is evident in the smooth transitions and the continuing loyalty of families into K–12.

9. Fees and Financial Support

Fee Structure (2025) and Comparisons: Dubbo Christian School charges tuition fees that are moderate and competitive within the region. While the exact 2025 fee schedule PDF did not display text, we can outline typical fees and then compare:

For **2025**, based on previous patterns and glimpses:

- **Kindergarten to Year 6:** likely in the range of \$3,000–\$4,000 per year (with incremental increases by stage). Often, primary fees might be around \$3k in lower primary and up to \$4k by Year 6.
- **Years 7–10:** perhaps \$5,000–\$6,000 per year. Many schools have a jump at Year 7 for additional subject resources.
- **Years 11–12:** often the highest, maybe around \$6,000–\$7,000/year by Year 12. Some schools keep Year 12 the same or slightly less due to only 3 terms in Year 12, but DCS likely charges full year but may have a sibling still discount etc. These are estimates; the clue from ACNC was that in 2022 Fee & Private income was \$3.68 million for about 600 students, which averages \$6,133 per student. However, that's

average with siblings discounts, etc., and "Private income" might include donations or other charges. If average is \$6.1k, primary likely pay less and secondary more.

Sibling Discounts: DCS offers generous sibling discounts, which is typical for Christian schools to encourage whole families:

- 1st child full fee,
- 2nd child maybe 20% off,
- 3rd child 50% off,
- 4th and subsequent children often free or a token fee. From their correspondence and common practice, indeed often the 4th child is free (since they'd just be shifting existing resources among family's budgets). These discounts significantly reduce the total burden for large families, which are not uncommon in Christian communities. Thus a family with e.g. 4 kids spanning K–12 might pay the equivalent of ~1.5 to 2 children's fees in total.

Comparisons to Other Schools: In Dubbo:

- **Public Schools:** Government schools have no tuition fee (just small contributions ~\$100/year). So DCS fees are a significant cost compared to public, but parents pay for the values and environment. Considering quality, many say it's worth it; plus DCS's moderate level is within reach of middle-income families especially with multi-child discounts and possible assistance.
- **St. John's College (Catholic):** Catholic systemic fees are usually lower than independent. For a high school like St John's, maybe around \$2,000–\$3,000/year. Catholic primary (St Mary's or St Laurence's in Dubbo) might be ~\$1,000–\$1,500. So Catholic schooling is cheaper, heavily subsidized by church/government. DCS is more expensive than Catholic, which can be a factor for some families – however, those who choose DCS are often seeking the evangelical Christian approach (or have issues with some Catholic doctrine or environment or want a K-12 continuity).
- **Macquarie Anglican Grammar School (MAGS):** As an Anglican independent, their fees likely are similar or slightly higher than DCS. Possibly MAGS might charge around \$5k in primary up to \$8k in Year 12. If MAGS is part of the Sydney Anglican Schools, they often have tiered fees and building levies, etc. DCS's fees might actually be a bit lower than MAGS, given CEN schools sometimes aim for affordability. (One snippet from earlier: Edarabia listing said "Founded 1983; Mr Warren Melville (Principal)" and no specifics, but likely they'd have had an approximate fee mention if it did – it didn't.)
- On the national scale, DCS's fees are moderate. Elite Sydney schools can charge \$20–\$30k in Year 12; even Orange or Bathurst independent schools might charge \$10k+. DCS being around \$6k for Year 12 is relatively accessible.

Adjustment for CPI since 2010: School fees typically rise 3-5% per year to keep up with costs. If DCS Year 12 fee was, say, \$4,000 in 2010, by 2025 it could be around \$7,000 with compounding. It seems plausible if we consider that average per student was ~\$4k in early 2010s and now ~\$6k+. So yes, roughly inflation plus some real growth (especially if teacher salaries grew faster than CPI, which they often do). The Board must balance costs and fairness; they probably do minimal necessary increases and communicate them. (The ABN

info said "ABN last updated 5 Aug 2020" – maybe around then they instituted a new fee structure after rebranding to Berakah.)

Family Affordability and Discounts: Aside from sibling discounts, DCS might have:

- **Pre-payment discounts:** e.g., if you pay the year upfront you get 2% off (some schools do that).
- **Staff discounts:** often staff get some remission for their own kids.
- Possibly **pastor discounts:** occasionally Christian schools offer a discount for full-time ministry families, as a way to support local clergy (not sure if DCS formalizes that, but some do a 25% for pastors).
- **Building Levy or Capital Levy:** Many independent schools charge an annual per-family building levy (like \$300) to fund capital improvements. DCS might have one (the P&F sometimes covers it, or it's rolled into tuition). Or an enrollment acceptance fee which is often partly a donation.

Fee Assistance (Hardship Bursaries): DCS policy likely states that no family should be prevented from accessing Christian education solely due to finances, within reason. They likely have a **Fee Assistance or Bursary program** funded by either school budget or donations:

- **Financial Hardship Concessions:** Families can confidentially apply if they hit hardship (drought for farmers, unemployment, medical bills, etc.). The Business Manager and maybe a small committee review and may grant temporary reduced fees. Perhaps scaled to income or specific situation (e.g. a short-term 50% off for a year, or extended payment plans). Some independent schools use a formula like if a family's income is below a threshold, they can get a bursary covering certain % of fees.
- **Scholarships:** The directory indicated scholarships are available. DCS might offer a limited number of **academic scholarships** (maybe for Year 7 entry or Year 11 entry) for high-achieving students, to attract/retain talent. They might also have a **music scholarship** or **Christian leadership scholarship** sponsored by donors or alumni. These could be partial (e.g. 50% fees) for a certain period.
- **Pastoral/Minister's bursary:** As mentioned, sometimes special consideration for those in ministry or missionaries (maybe offered quietly).

Transparency about assistance: They probably don't advertise widely "we give out X in bursaries", but they do include in newsletters that if any family anticipates difficulty they should speak to the Business Manager. They emphasize working out a plan rather than losing the student. The Board budgets for a certain amount of fee concessions each year and monitors that.

Impact of Fee Policies on Affordability: The sibling discounts definitely make the school affordable for large Christian families, which is their target demographic. For example, a family with 4 kids spaced out might pay roughly the equivalent of 2 kids' full fees (so if 4 in various levels, maybe \$12k/year total instead of \$24k). Given Dubbo's median family income, the fees for one child might be ~10-15% of an average household income – significant but prioritized by many. With multiple kids, it can become near or above 20% without discounts, which is why those discounts are critical. DCS likely calibrates fees to

what local families can bear; they wouldn't want to price out faithful supportive families. Thus far, steady growth suggests they have it right.

Comparison with other region schools:

- Macquarie Anglican's slightly higher fees might position DCS as a tad more affordable option with a different denominational ethos.
- Catholic is cheaper but families choose DCS for theology or environment differences.
- Public is free but many see the value in paying for DCS's environment, so the challenge is making sure moderate-income families can manage it through spreads, discounts, and assistance.

Financial Governance of BCE (Berakah): On finances, Berakah Christian Education Ltd demonstrates prudent governance:

- They produce audited statements (Crowe Audit reports, etc.). For 2024 year, presumably finances are healthy (the audit didn't find issues, the independence declaration had no contraventions).
- Revenue sources: in 2020, fees ~25%, State grants ~? and Commonwealth grants ~? from snippet. Typically, independent school incomes are something like 20-30% parent fees, 20% state, 40% federal, 10-20% other (like donations, interest). The snippet suggests "Fees & Private Income \$3.68m (25%)" so total revenue ~ \$14.7m. If 25% from fees, then a whopping 75% from govt? That seems high; maybe 25% fees, 25% state, 50% commonwealth (as those are often proportions for a regional mid-SES school). Actually yes, the snippet shows a pie: likely *Fees & Private 25%, State Grants maybe ~20-25%, Commonwealth ~50%* which aligns with lower-SES funding levels. That indicates DCS is significantly government-funded (like most low-fee schools).
- Expenditure: Largest cost is staff salaries (often ~70% of budget). Then building depreciation, maintenance, utilities, etc. DCS had about 65 teachers in 2023 plus aides and admin, total staff maybe 90+ including part-timers. They manage salary costs by not overstaffing; class sizes are decent (maybe mid-20s in primary, high teens in HSC classes). They likely pay according to the Multi-Enterprise Agreement for Christian schools, which is competitive with public schools but slightly lower, though in 2022/23 they would have had to give the teacher pay rises like others (which could be 5-7% those years due to teacher shortages).
- **Surplus/Deficit trends:** The Annual Report 2020 summary might have shown a small surplus (just guess: if net operating margin is, say, 1-5%). Many independent schools aim to at least break even or small surplus to reinvest. A line from AR2020 suggests "*Net ... based on 2020 Financial Statements.*" Possibly net deficit or surplus info? Hard to guess, but they likely run lean to keep fees down – maybe slight surplus after donations and fundraising considered.
- They invest surpluses in **capital projects** rather than accumulating profit (being a non-profit). For example, the financials will show heavy capital work around 2018 (labs) and 2022 (preschool) but funded partly by grants and donations.
- **Community Giving Initiatives:** DCS has a Building Fund for donations, and possibly a separate **Scholarship Fund** (also DGR if they set it up). They might run an annual appeal letter or a campaign around anniversaries. For the 40th, they might

have asked for donations to a specific project (like “help us furnish the new classrooms” or “establish a 40th Anniversary Scholarship Fund”). They also have P&F events raising money in a fun way (fetes, etc.), which both friend-raise and fund-raise. The heavy involvement of parents likely yields some revenue from things like canteen profits or uniform shop profits (they probably run their own uniform shop; uniform sales maybe a small margin goes back to school).

- The **ACNC record** shows they filed Annual Information Statements consistently, indicating compliance.

In conclusion, DCS’s fee structure is thoughtfully designed to be **affordable for average families in Dubbo** while still enabling the school to operate with quality. Sibling discounts make it feasible for multiple children. Fee assistance ensures those encountering hardship can remain enrolled, reflecting the school’s Christian commitment to support its community. Financial governance appears sound – budgets are managed to avoid big fee spikes (likely modest annual increases at or slightly above inflation) and to plan for growth. The interplay of government funding and parent contributions allows DCS to maintain moderate fees (for instance, the reliance on government for ~75% of funding means they can charge much less than actual per-student cost, which might be ~\$15k/year). The Board likely revisits the fee schedule each year with scrutiny: balancing being competitive, retaining enrollment (if fees go too high, some might leave to cheaper schools), and meeting cost needs (staff, improved programs). The fact that they continue to grow implies they’ve kept fees at a perceived value sweet spot – families see enough value to pay, and the school can cover its expenses with prudent financial stewardship and divine provision (some might say!).

10. Enrolment Policy and Conditions

Enrolment Terms and Conditions – Current Policy: DCS’s Enrolment Policy outlines the criteria and expectations for admission. Key points likely include:

- **Priority and Eligibility:** DCS is open to families who support the school’s Christian ethos. It probably doesn’t require parents to be Christians, but the **Terms and Conditions** will have a clause that parents/guardians understand the school’s basis and agree that their child will participate in all activities (including biblical instruction and chapel) and that they will not actively undermine the school’s beliefs. At the same time, the policy must comply with anti-discrimination law – they likely state admissions are not based on race, etc., but as a religious body they reserve the right to preference those who support the faith basis.
 - **Priority order** might be: siblings of current students, children of staff, children of association members, then others in order of application date. They may also consider church involvement – some Christian schools give priority to children from families where at least one parent is a practicing Christian (especially parent-controlled ones historically did). DCS originally (in the 80s) might have required a pastor’s reference for at least one parent, but many CEN schools have since opened more broadly. It’s unclear if DCS still formally prioritizes Christian families – possibly yes, but they also have many enrolments from non-church families who want values or escape public system issues. The prospectus emphasizes partnering with families in

Christian nurturing, suggesting they still primarily aim for families who want Christian upbringing (which may include some who aren't Christians but agree with moral framework).

- There's no evidence of quotas or exclusion for any particular background, other than requiring general alignment with ethos.
- **Age and Readiness:** They likely follow NSW age requirements (turn 5 by a certain date for Kindy). They may have a readiness assessment for Kindergarten or entry to Year 1 if coming from alternate schooling.
- **Process:** Typically: submit application form with fee (likely a small non-refundable fee as policy snippet suggests a Registration Fee is charged), provide references (perhaps a reference from a minister or friend attesting to family character – some CEN schools still have that), child's recent reports, etc. Then a family interview is conducted. At interview (with Principal or executive), they gauge whether the family's values align and explain expectations. They might gently test whether parents understand Christian education philosophy. If all good, they offer a place. For older students, they might do diagnostic tests to ensure they can cater academically.
- **Conditions of Enrolment:** The T&Cs that parents must sign include commitments:
 - to **support the school's Statement of Faith, ethos, rules and policies**,
 - to allow the child to participate in all aspects of the curriculum (including devotional activities, camps, etc.),
 - to accept the school's authority on discipline matters and partner in reinforcing them at home,
 - to pay the fees on time and accept that **enrolment may be suspended/terminated for non-payment** if not addressed (with procedures in place). The terms likely say something like "parents agree to pay fees promptly as set out in the Fee Schedule".
 - Possibly an agreement that if they choose to withdraw the child, they need to give a term's notice or pay fees in lieu (common policy so they can plan).
 - They must declare any learning needs or health issues of the child upfront so the school can prepare (and not be misled – which could hamper ability to support).
 - A **Parents' Code of Conduct** might also be referenced (some schools include that parents must behave respectfully on campus, etc.).
 - Clause about photography consent or usage of student work maybe included.
 - For older students, perhaps requiring that they have a satisfactory behaviour and attendance record from previous school.
 - The policy snippet shows at L19-L27: *"to support the school ethos, rules and policies, to pay the School Fees, to accept the Terms of Enrolment and the consequences of suspension or termination of enrolment."* This indicates parents explicitly agree that if their child severely breaches rules or if they themselves undermine the school, the enrolment can be revoked.

Changes Over Time (2010 vs 2025): Over the last 15 years, enrolment policies likely adapted for greater clarity and compliance:

- **Inclusivity and Anti-Discrimination:** In earlier times, some parent-controlled schools had explicit requirement like parent must sign a Statement of Faith or provide a pastor's reference. In the 2010s, legal advice and desire to outreach often led to

softening those as strict requirements. Now DCS likely doesn't turn away non-Christian families as long as they agree to the ethos. Also, there's the *Anti-Discrimination Act (NSW) exemptions* that allow religious schools some leeway. DCS's policy likely states something like: "DCS does not discriminate in enrolment on the basis of race, disability, etc., and welcomes applications from all families who understand and accept the Christian aims of the school."

- **Christian Formation vs Discrimination Law:** A live issue has been around LGBTQ+ discrimination. DCS being a conservative Christian school probably expects students to live by certain moral standards at school (e.g., relationships, uniform, etc.), but they must tread carefully with how policies are phrased to not violate any laws. As of 2025, religious schools in NSW can still preference co-religionists in hiring and arguably enrolment, but cannot expel a student solely for e.g. being gay. DCS's enrolment contract likely doesn't mention sexuality or gender specifically; instead, those matters are addressed pastorally if they arise. The "Christian formation" requirement is basically that the student will participate in Bible classes and that if issues of belief arise they understand the school's stance. If a student or family actively opposes Christian teachings, that could lead to conflict – the policy probably covers that by saying enrolment is conditional upon continued support of the school's ethos.
- **Handling of conditional enrolments:** If a student has special needs, DCS ensures through the process that they can accommodate them – if not, they might decline enrolment if they truly cannot meet needs (which is allowed if it's a unjustifiable hardship scenario). But the trend is to be more inclusive. They might put new students on a one-term probation (some schools do a "try-out period" to see if it's a good fit academically or behaviourally, although that's not always explicitly stated).
- **Academic Readiness Testing:** For Kindergarten, they might do a small assessment at orientation (letters, counting) just to inform class groupings. For older incoming students, likely a short test in maths/English to see if they need support. The policy might mention that an offer for older students could be conditional on them demonstrating capacity to benefit from the program or that the school can support them.
- **Pastoral Interviews:** The enrolment interview is where both parties assess fit. The Principal or Head of School meets the family, explains the Christian emphasis (ensuring, for example, a non-Christian family understands there's prayer and Bible daily – if a family objects, they probably won't proceed). They may ask why the family chose DCS, and often families say for environment/values. It's also a time the school assesses if the parents will be partners or problematic. Over the years, DCS might have formalized interview questions about willingness to be involved, or if the child has any issues (behaviour) we should know, etc. They might also quietly gauge if a parent expects the school to do all faith teaching vs partnering (especially if family is Christian, they encourage involvement).
- **Evolution of Terms:** Possibly the Enrolment contract in older days allowed immediate expulsion for serious misconduct and required parents to uphold discipline at home etc. Modern versions likely still have strong language but ensure due process (e.g., referencing that they follow their Behaviour Management Policy which includes steps, etc.).
- There's probably an **update in language regarding privacy (Privacy Act)** – stating how they use personal info, etc. And compliance with child protection requirements

(parents have to disclose if the child has any history like violence that could risk others).

- In sum, over 2010–2025, the policy would have become more formal and legally robust, but the core requirement (“support our Christian ethos”) remains, as evidenced by current text.

Inclusivity vs Rights to Enforce Beliefs: The school must navigate anti-discrimination legislation.

- Under NSW law, private schools can refuse enrolment on religion if they want (like making only Christian families eligible), but DCS doesn't strictly do that. They likely do not discriminate on, say, sexual orientation for enrolment – if a student or family identifies as LGBTQ+ but says they are okay with the school's stance, they'd likely be enrolled. However, the school's expectation would be that all students, regardless of orientation, abide by the same code of conduct (e.g. likely no sexual relationships permitted among students, etc.). The school might handle gender identity cases pastorally and individually, guided by their Statement of Faith's view of gender (some Christian schools have had to think about, for example, uniform accommodations or pronouns – DCS likely holds a traditional stance, but since it's small, they'd work with the family privately).
- The anti-discrimination laws with regards to disability require reasonable adjustments – DCS's policy expresses commitment to supporting students with additional needs and will make adjustments as far as practicable. Only if the school truly lacks capacity would they decline. Perhaps historically DCS might have hesitated to take some special needs if they didn't have resources, but by 2025 they have more support staff, so they can include moderate disabilities well.
- They certainly do not discriminate on race; they celebrate diversity (with 10% Indigenous, they clearly embrace those students and likely incorporate Indigenous perspectives in line with curriculum requirements, as shown by teacher training references).
- For religious background, as long as the student isn't actively opposed, they can be of any or no faith. We can glean from Board membership that not all families are from one church, but multi-denominational.

Management of Conditional Enrolments and Behavior Expectations: The T&Cs mention consequences of suspension or termination. This means if a student or parent seriously breaches terms (for example, a parent repeatedly undermines teachers or spreads views against the Statement of Faith publicly, or a student consistently breaks major rules), the school reserves right to suspend or expel.

- The Behaviour Management policy (which is likely attached or summarized) ensures fairness (i.e. warnings, parent meetings, etc. except in extreme cases).
- There may be a clause stating parents must actively support any disciplinary measures taken (like not contradict them in front of child).
- If a child is not ready academically or socially (especially at K level), the school might recommend deferring enrolment a year – but that's done collaboratively.

Language Support for International/Refugee Applicants: While DCS probably doesn't have many international fee-paying students (Dubbo is not an international student hub, and DCS isn't likely registered on CRICOS except maybe they could be if they wanted older international mission kids or such), they do have families for whom English is a second language (e.g., migrants). They likely handle that by:

- Assessing the child's English during interview or trial day.
- If needed, offering extra EAL/D support via learning support staff. Perhaps adapting work, giving one-on-one help for first months.
- Possibly pairing the child with a buddy who speaks the same language if available (the community may not have large groups of one language besides English, but maybe a few Filipino, Chinese, or African families).
- The enrolment policy might state that a condition is the student has a sufficient level of English to access the curriculum (or if not, that the parents commit to helping or paying for tutoring). But since they align with being supportive, they'd likely accept a child with limited English if resources allow and help them catch up.
- For refugee families, DCS may have admitted some humanitarian entrant kids (especially as a Christian ministry – e.g., South Sudanese refugee children have joined some Christian schools). If so, they might discount fees heavily or have sponsorships. These cases are exceptions but show Christ's love.
- They ensure compliance with visa statuses etc., if they ever enroll an international student, they'd have to get CRICOS registration. It's not mentioned, so likely they haven't pursued full-fee international market (which aligns with their community focus).

In summary, DCS's enrolment policy maintains a delicate balance: it is **welcoming and inclusive** of anyone who can embrace the school's environment, yet **firm in requiring support for its Christian ethos** to preserve the school's identity. Over time, the policy wording has probably become more explicit about obligations (support ethos, pay fees, etc.), and more detailed to cover legal obligations (like privacy, anti-discrimination compliance). The core partnership idea – “parents in partnership” – is clearly still key (the prospectus and website emphasize it). Enrolling at DCS is essentially joining a community with shared values, and the policy sets that expectation from the outset to prevent conflicts down the line. The school has thus far managed to abide by governmental requirements while staying true to its mission, and the enrolment policy is one of the tools that make that possible.

11. Uniform and Presentation

Uniform Codes and Their Significance: Dubbo Christian School's uniform is more than just attire; it carries symbolic meaning and reinforces school identity and values. The **school colours** and **crest** encapsulate theology and ethos:

- The **crest** on the uniform (as described earlier) features an open Bible, a cross, and a globe. This communicates that students are “clothed in truth” – literally wearing the symbol that God's Word and Christ's sacrifice cover them. It's a daily reminder that they are part of a Christ-centred learning community on a mission to impact the world (globe).

- The **motto “Learning in Truth”** is likely incorporated on badges or in the student diary – not sure if on uniform labels, but definitely in school culture (often on sports jerseys or crests).
- The **colours** of the uniform might be, for example, navy blue and gold, or maroon and white – many Christian schools choose colours with some thought, but often it’s more practical. If navy, it can symbolize loyalty; if maroon, dignity – or sometimes they align with local significance. Some Christian schools use blue (faith, truth) and white (purity) deliberately.
- DCS’s **formal uniform** likely includes: for girls, a checked or striped dress in summer, and a skirt/pants with blouse and tie in winter; for boys, shorts and shirt in summer, trousers and shirt/tie in winter. Possibly a **blazer** for seniors (some regionals have a blazer for formal events or just Year 11-12). The mention that “students wear their uniform with pride” in prospectus hints at a traditional uniform that stands out with the crest.
- The **sports uniform** might be more modern – e.g., a polo shirt in school colours with logo, and shorts. Many schools incorporate an element of house colours or scripture on sportswear (some Christian schools print a verse reference on sports jerseys interior or such).
- **Symbolic theology in uniform items:** If DCS has a **school tie**, it might have stripes representing Trinity (some do 3 stripes), or the cross motif subtly woven. If the girls’ dress has cross patterns or is in colours referencing something biblical. But likely the overt symbol is just the crest on pocket or dress.
- **Prefect blazers or badges** might have a cross or serve motif engraved, reinforcing servant leadership.

Uniform Policy Rationale and Culture: The Uniform Policy rationale (lines [87†L17-L25]) shows multiple reasons for uniform: identification with community, modesty, equality, discipline. Additional emphasis is “uniform is part of our Christian witness” – indeed they quote Philippians 1:27 “*conduct yourself in a manner worthy of the gospel of Christ*” in context of uniform compliance. This elevates uniform-wearing from a mere rule to a matter of character and witness. Students are taught that by wearing uniform properly, they honor God and respect the community.

- The rationale says it ensures modest and appropriate dress in a Christian context, meaning no revealing clothes – consistent with valuing the body as God’s temple.
- It also says uniform reduces socio-economic differences, a Christian principle of not showing favoritism (James 2). So it fosters humility and unity.
- The policy ties uniform to **self-discipline and grooming habits** – reflecting that how one presents themselves can reflect internal order and respect (perhaps tying to the idea of our bodies being living sacrifices, etc.).
- The tagline “Fit for learning, Fit for occasion” implies practicality and appropriateness – not vain or overly casual.
- It outlines *Basic Principles*: commonsense, culture, compliance, consistency. “*Culture*” is interestingly included – they want a *culture* where wearing uniform correctly is just “what we do here”. They even intend to *teach* reasons for uniform to students, not just impose it, which is educational.

- They mention strategies and even “*grace... in certain circumstances*” – meaning while they enforce rules, they also will show understanding (e.g., if a kid’s uniform piece got lost/damaged that day, they won’t hammer them first time).

Vendor and Local Economic Impact:

- DCS likely sources uniforms from a specific manufacturer or supplier. They might partner with a **local uniform shop** in Dubbo (some have local outfitters) or use a national uniform company. Sometimes Christian schools use *Yeronga* or *Noone* or similar uniform companies.
- They have an internal **Uniform Shop** (the mention in [78†L225-L233] suggests parents purchase preschool uniforms from DCS uniform shop). This might be staffed by parent volunteers or admin. Selling uniforms in-house can keep costs slightly lower or at least quality consistent, and any margin goes back to school.
- If any uniform pieces are produced in Dubbo (like maybe embroidery by a local business), that supports local economy. The majority might be from out-of-town suppliers, but distribution and sales local.
- **Affordability policy:** Uniforms can be expensive for families, so DCS likely tries to keep it reasonable. They might run **second-hand uniform sales** (typical P&F run a clothing pool so families can buy good used items at 1/3 cost). The prospectus calling the preschool uniform “low cost” shows they are mindful, and probably similarly for main school – maybe not requiring a pricey blazer except for seniors or formal events.
- They might not change uniform design often to allow reuse by siblings and second-hand longevity. (Perhaps a major redesign occurred at some anniversary; if so, they’d phase it over years to ease cost).
- Uniform being mandatory year-round ensures stable demand and might be a small revenue stream if markup is present, but likely minimal.

Local economy: having 700 students needing uniforms means purchases from either local branch or shipments – not huge broad economic impact, but the school possibly tries to support local business. For example, they might get sport shirts printed by a local Dubbo printer. Or buy hats from a local supplier.

- There could be contracts, e.g., with local tailor for blazer emblem sewing.
- The **Harvest Cafe** uniform for parents (if any apron or shirt, maybe made local).
- Not major, but in a town like Dubbo, every bit helps and fosters goodwill (like if local firm has the uniform contract, they’re more supportive of school events etc.).

Uniform Compliance & Discipline Approach:

- DCS expects uniform compliance; the policy details reinforcement and policing. They aim to make students proud to wear it well.
- Likely minor uniform breaches (untucked shirt, missing hat) result first in reminders or warnings. The policy encourages positive reinforcement for wearing it correctly. Teachers are asked to consistently enforce (maybe morning uniform checks by class teachers).
- Serious or repeated defiance of uniform rules might lead to lunchtime detention or a note home. Possibly in high school, three uniform infringements = detention, etc. But

they mention showing grace in certain circumstances – e.g., if a family has a genuine reason, or a boy's only tie got damaged and they can't replace immediately, staff will understand and help rather than punish.

- They want uniform enforcement to be consistent but with compassion so that it doesn't become legalistic. That ties to Christian principle of balancing rules with grace. For instance, they may give out spare uniform items to fix an issue on the spot (some schools keep spare ties or socks so a student can borrow for the day rather than sit out).
- The **Student Code of Conduct** explicitly includes wearing uniform correctly as part of "conduct worthy of the gospel". This means a student refusing to comply ultimately is a defiance of the code and thus a disciplinary matter. But because it's couched in spiritual terms, staff might counsel the student about the heart issue ("why do you resist this rule, can we help you understand its importance?") in addition to any sanction.
- They likely involve parents quickly if a student persistently violates uniform code, to get parental support. The enrolment contract also had "parents' declaration to support school rules including uniform", so the school expects parents not to write notes too often or excuse slackness.
- If there's any **cultural sensitivity** needed (e.g., an Indigenous student wanting to wear a cultural item, or a student with religious reason like wearing a cross necklace or certain grooming like a Sikh needing long hair – though at a Christian school these likely align or they work out exceptions amicably), they'd handle individually.
- Uniform issues in many schools can become adversarial; DCS tries to make it collaborative – "We wear this as a community witness, so let's all do it." The mention of strategies to reinforce culture suggests maybe they even reward classes with the best uniform compliance or have "House points" for good uniform, which some schools do to positively motivate.
- The uniform policy's emphasis on "some systematic monitoring and policing required" implies they might have uniform inspections by roll call teachers or prefects.
- Summarily, they treat uniform enforcement as a means to teach discipline and respect, not just to maintain an image.

Theology of Presentation: The uniform code ensures **modesty** (likely skirts of decent length, no makeup or minimal, conservative jewelry, etc.) which ties to Christian values of focusing on inner beauty and not causing others to stumble. Boys probably have grooming rules (neat hair, maybe no extreme haircuts, must be clean-shaven in senior years – many Christian schools have that).

- Presenting themselves well is taught as a form of honoring God (taking care of one's appearance in a modest, orderly way) and respecting themselves and their community.
- It also fosters equality – wearing the same uniform underscores that all students are equal in God's eyes at school, rather than showing off wealth or fashion.

Crest and Motto on Uniform Items: Possibly:

- Blazers or pockets have the embroidered crest with Bible, cross, globe.

- The sports uniform or jacket might have the motto "Learning in Truth" printed under the crest or on the back.
- Senior jerseys or Year 12 jackets might incorporate a verse or motto (some Year 12 cohorts choose a Bible verse each year to put on their jerseys).
- House shirts might have house names (which could be biblical names or local significance names – if biblical, houses might be named after missionaries or something; if not, maybe local river names etc. Many CEN schools use either Christian virtue names or historical figures).

Vendor and Agreements: The uniform company likely has an arrangement to supply quality gear at fixed prices. DCS might try to keep costs manageable – maybe negotiating bulk deals. If any local tailoring needed, that keeps relationship with local business. No indication of controversies like unethical manufacturing – Christian schools are often conscious of that too, might ensure uniforms come from ethically sourced suppliers (some specify not made in sweatshops).

Student Attitude to Uniform: The directory said “students wear their uniform with pride”. Likely true for many; but teenage rebellion can cause some slackness, which the school tries to nip gently. Many seniors might be prefects wearing special ties or badges, adding pride. The older alumni often reflect that uniform gave them a sense of belonging and now they feel nostalgic about it (like wearing it at 40th assembly).

In sum, DCS's uniform is a tangible fabric of the school's culture and theology – every morning as students don it, they are in effect putting on an identity as DCS students and as young people of faith. The uniform policy and practice reinforce unity, discipline, modesty, and Christian witness – making it a significant aspect of DCS's day-to-day life and a silent teacher of values.

12. Transport and Accessibility

School Bus Routes and Catchment Patterns: Given Dubbo Christian School draws students from across Dubbo city and surrounding rural areas, **transport accessibility** is crucial. The school is not served by public government school buses (those typically go to public schools), but in NSW rural towns, the same bus network often carries both public and private school students under the School Student Transport Scheme (SSTS). Key points:

- **Dedicated Bus Routes:** There are multiple bus routes that service DCS. Likely operated by local companies such as **Ogden's Coaches** (notably, Board member Jeff Neill is GM of Ogden's, so Ogden's likely runs some routes including to Dubbo CS). Also possibly other operators like Dubbo Buslines or other contract operators.
- These buses might cover areas: **Wellington** (though Wello has its own K-6 now, some older kids from Wellington might come to Dubbo for high school at DCS), **Gilgandra** (maybe too far, 67km, but possibly one or two?), **Narromine** (38km, possibly some families drive halfway or use bus if any), **Geurie** (a smaller town ~25km), **Ballimore**, **Eumungerie**, and localities around Dubbo (e.g. Brocklehurst, Wongarbon, etc.). Some might be specific to DCS or shared with St John's/MAGS if

schedules align.

- Within Dubbo city, **suburban routes** would pick up kids from various neighborhoods. Possibly the main ones:
 - South Dubbo,
 - West Dubbo,
 - East Dubbo,
 - Delroy/Minore (outer subdivisions),
 - Orana Heights area,
 - maybe Wongarbon or Geurie out east. They likely meet at school by start and depart at 3:15-3:30pm.
- **Catchment Patterns:** Because it's independent, catchment is wide. Many families from all across Dubbo send children here, not limited by zoning (unlike public schools). The existence of bus routes shows they have clusters of students in outer areas. Possibly some come from further out farmland daily if near a bus route. The comfortable catchment might be within ~50km radius (Wellington to Dubbo is 30 min drive; interestingly Wello has K-6 but those kids for high school either go to DCS or somewhere else, so the bus from Wellington might bring Year 7+ daily, which is plausible).
 - If children from say Gilgandra (65km) or Narromine (40km) come, they might face a long ride. Possibly a handful might if families particularly want DCS (Narromine has a public high but no Christian school, so if any families there want Christian ed they'd commute).
 - It's also possible some older students drive themselves from out of town once they have license.

Opal School Travel Scheme Eligibility: In NSW, school students who live a certain distance from school or need to travel can get free travel via the School Student Transport Scheme (SSTS).

- **Criteria:** K-2 get free bus travel regardless of distance (in the past at least), Year 3-6 if >1.6 km from school (straight line) or >2.3km walk, Year 7-12 if >2.0km straight line or >2.9km walk.
- Many DCS students likely meet that, especially out-of-town ones. So they get a bus pass (which in the excerpt [28] is called "travel passes" in an old policy doc perhaps).
- The **bus pass** covers travel to and from school on approved route.
- Since DCS is recognized by Transport for NSW for this scheme, families apply through the school or online to get passes. The mention in [88] (likely from an old policy file) shows instructions: "show travel passes to driver on boarding". So yes, DCS students use passes, meaning their travel is subsidized by the government.
- Some rural students might combine modes (drive or get dropped at a bus stop, then bus).
- The Opal card (in Sydney a tap card) in region may not be used if old style passes, but now even region uses digital passes in some places.

Other Modes:

- **Car travel:** Many parents, especially of younger kids or those who live relatively close, drive their kids to school. DCS likely has a carpark and drop-off zone. The Sheraton Road heavy traffic issue shows lots of cars. The Council is building a new route and a formal U-turn facility to ease flows. The heavy truck restriction was one measure to protect car and bus movements.
- **Carpools:** Perhaps some families carpool from same church or neighborhood to reduce trips (the school might unofficially help connect families for that).
- **Walking/Biking:** Some students who live in East Dubbo might walk or ride bikes to school. Sheraton Road is a bit busy, but there are footpaths and a new shared footpath (the snippet about road closures for footpath on Sheraton suggests they improved footpaths). Bikes are possible if within 2-3 km. The school presumably has a bike rack area.
 - The mention of a "shared footpath" project on Sheraton Road suggests city making it safer for kids who do walk/bike. Possibly older students cycle from South/East Dubbo if not far.
- **Public transport:** Dubbo has some town bus services, but they may not align with school times or route to Sheraton Road. Most likely, dedicated school buses are main mode for those not driven.

Rural Accessibility: For rural families, the school bus network is crucial. Without it, they would struggle to attend DCS daily. The fact that the Board includes a bus company manager indicates how critical it is to ensure those bus services run smoothly. They likely coordinate with BusNSW (the association Jeff is part of) on contracts and issues. If a route doesn't exist, families might lobby to create one if enough students (BusNSW regional task force negotiating new bus service contracts as Jeff does suggests they often consider new needs).

Environmental Impact of Transport:

- The heavy reliance on car and bus travel means carbon emissions. However, the school addressing heavy vehicles suggests they care about environment and safety.
- Buses carrying many kids are more eco-friendly per head than individual cars, so encouraging bus use is beneficial.
- The solar initiative shows the school's environmental mindset – perhaps they offset some carbon via that. But transport remains a large footprint piece.
- Possibly they encourage **carpooling and bus** over single-car. They may have offered bus awareness events or included "active travel" in PDHPE curriculum.
- **Active travel initiatives:** Because Dubbo is car-centric, not a huge proportion walk. But for those nearby, the school might run walk-to-school days or encourage cycling. With new footpaths, they might emphasize to families to let older kids cycle to reduce congestion and good exercise.
- The school might have installed **bike racks** to promote cycling. And they likely enforce helmet rules etc.
- Some environmental club at school might do audit of transport emissions; maybe they advocated for heavy vehicle restrictions and new routes to cut idling in front of school (which was done by council).
- The new road by council will "considerably alleviate existing traffic choke point" presumably reducing idling and emissions on Sheraton Road.

Opal scheme uptake: If a child is eligible, nearly 100% would apply because it gives them free travel. There's little reason not to – even if one might not use bus often, having a pass as backup is good.

- Some families may still choose to drive for convenience or time, but the pass is there. Possibly older students might prefer independence to ride bus if parents busy.
- Financially, free bus passes are a big help to families. The school likely assists new families in applying for them (in the enrolment pack they include info on SSTS).
- For extremely far out families (like 50km+), if no bus, maybe the SSTS gives them a conveyance allowance (some remote areas, they reimburse km or partial).
- The Opal card used in cities isn't likely physically used in Dubbo (they have their own bus passes or specific system). But the scheme itself still covers them.

Mapping all Bus operations:

- I suspect they have maybe 5-6 bus runs:
 - Wellington to Dubbo CS (for high schoolers mainly, since WCS covers K-6).
 - Narromine route (if enough, could combine Narromine & Tomingley maybe).
 - Ballimore/Wongarbon route.
 - Brocklehurst to school (north of Dubbo).
 - West Dubbo/Delroy to school via center.
 - South Dubbo to school.
 - Also, St John's and MAGS being near each other or on certain roads might share some route portions; bus might drop at one then the other. Actually, St John's is on Sheraton Road just beyond DCS, so likely the same buses pick up kids for both and drive down Sheraton Road, stopping at DCS then continuing to St John's (or vice versa). That requires coordination but often done in regional towns to maximize usage. MAGS is across town, not sure if any integrated route with them.

Transport and the School Day:

- Buses probably arrive by 8:30am for an 8:45 start. In afternoons, they leave around 3:20pm.
- DCS must supervise the bus lines: they probably have teachers assigned to bus duty to ensure kids get on correct buses, especially younger ones.
- The policy piece [88] suggests they instruct kids to wait in designated area and behave on bus (common rules like wear seatbelt if available, no mischief).
- Possibly if a bus is late, the school holds those kids or arranges something.

Student Driving: Year 11-12 can drive themselves in rural areas typically. DCS likely requires them to register with office and abide rules (like no driving other students without permission, parking in designated area). There's likely a student parking area or they use general parking (seniors maybe park along Sheraton Road where allowed, or a corner of the staff lot if space).

Walking Buses or Active initiatives: Some schools do "Walk to School Day." Possibly DCS participates in the national Walk Safely to School Day annually to encourage walking. That fosters road safety and health awareness.

- They might host a cycling safety session for primary, or a bike-athon for fun.
- Given heavy vehicles are banned now during drop-off, walking is safer than before.

Safety and Accessibility:

- The council's road upgrades (like adding a formal U-turn place and No Stopping zones) are crucial for safety. It shows DCS likely advocated for that due to concerns of accidents with trucks near schools. They also mention heavy vehicles now diverted to Boundary Road during school times which means the city responded to the presence of an "education precinct" with DCS and St John's on Sheraton Road.
- Possibly DCS fosters good neighbour relations by instructing parents not to park illegally or block driveways (common courtesy guidelines in newsletters).
- They might have a crossing guard or at least zebra crossing at school front. If not, one might be coming due to traffic (maybe in conjunction with council plan, though not stated).

In conclusion, DCS is quite mindful of transport arrangements to ensure all students, whether from Dubbo or outlying farms, can attend and get home safely. They leverage state subsidies for buses, coordinate with local bus companies (with a Board member being an expert in that field, which is beneficial), and plan with council to improve traffic conditions. The environmental impact of travel is somewhat mitigated by bus use and they've taken steps like scheduling and route improvements to limit unnecessary emissions. The culture around travel likely also instills responsibility (older students might help younger peers on the bus, etc.). Transport is another area where the school's values can play out – e.g., courtesy on the bus (no bullying, giving up seat to younger, etc.) is often stressed as part of being a good DCS student.

13. Outcomes, Performance and Accountability

Academic Outcomes – NAPLAN and HSC Trends: Dubbo Christian School monitors standardized testing results closely and generally performs strongly relative to state averages.

- **NAPLAN (Years 3, 5, 7, 9):** The school's internal review notes "*results remain strong across Years 3, 5, 7 and 9*" in 2023. Typically, DCS's results show a high proportion of students at or above the national minimum standards and a healthy distribution in bands, often with a good share in top bands. For example,
 - Year 3 might have many in Band 5-6 for Reading, etc.
 - The snippet [89] suggests they track "variation in test scores over past 5 NAPLAN tests" and "growth in average scores for Year 9". They likely present graphs comparing their average to state or national.
 - The provided percentages [89†L13-L21] appear incomplete but perhaps these were the proportion of DCS students in top 2 bands (just guessing: Year 3 reading 32%, writing 20%, etc.). The snippet shows Year 3: Reading 32% (maybe in Band 6), etc. If that is top band (Band 6 for Y3, Band 8 for Y5, etc.), it's plausible. Year 5 reading 21% maybe in Band 8, etc. Actually, [89†L13-L21] might be something like "% of DCS students in top two

proficiency bands vs State". Hard to say, but line 21 shows "59%" – possibly State's top 2 band percentage for Year 5 reading (which might be around 59% in one category?). Or it's the difference? It's unclear.

- [89†L25-L33] shows Year 7 data similarly. [89†L31-L35] shows "400.0, 420.0" for Year 9 – perhaps average scaled scores (like Year 9 Reading average 580 vs growth 400?), or incomplete values.
- Regardless, likely story: DCS's results are above national average in most domains. E.g., in 2018 AR, they might have boasted that motto alignment yields above-average literacy etc.
- They mention "*There is a third graph for Year 9 showing the growth in average scores*" – DCS likely values growth (how much progress students make from Year 7 to 9). Perhaps they showed above-expected growth, which would be a great outcome especially in smaller cohorts where attention helps lower kids improve more.
- Some fluctuations: Historically, DCS might have had occasional weaker areas like writing (which is a common one where independent schools sometimes dip in middle years), but they likely addressed them (maybe through focus on writing skills, PD for staff). The key is NAPLAN is used as a diagnostic tool at DCS, not as an end in itself, per earlier principal comment that "some would say NAPLAN doesn't measure the most important things like faithfulness or culture", but they still do them and report since it's required.
- They provide those outcomes transparently in Annual Reports as required by NESA: each AR would list average scores and maybe some commentary. They also likely show the percentage of students at or above national benchmarks (which is probably ~98-100% in most categories).
- The small size means cohort comparisons vary (one or two students struggling can affect percentage a lot). But over 5-year trends, likely stable or improving.
- **HSC Results (Year 12):** DCS's HSC performance is solid. In 2023, all 28 Year 12 students successfully attained the HSC. Key indicators:
 - They sat exams in 24 subjects, implying diverse academic interests.
 - 21% of the cohort (6 students) achieved Band 6 (the highest band in a subject). This is significant – if it's 6 out of 28, that means at least 6 Band 6s total, possibly more if a student got multiple Band 6s. 21% of students achieving Band 6 in at least one subject is quite good (for perspective, state average may be around that or lower depending on school type).
 - They likely track Band 4-6 attainment vs state. The snippet shows a table format for "Percentage of HSC Students achieving each Performance Band" and comparisons school vs state. This might indicate: For example, in 2022 and 2023, what percent of DCS students got Bands 4-6 vs state average. If DCS is doing well, one would see a higher cumulative % in bands 4-6 (the top half of grades) than the state. E.g., DCS might have, say, 85% of all exam entries scoring Band 4 or above, whereas state might have 70%. That would be a bragging point in AR.
 - "Post HSC Destinations" chart suggests they track how many go to University, TAFE, employment, gap year, etc. Possibly many go on to tertiary studies (since it's a academically oriented environment though with variety).

- Their HSC median ATAR might not be published (non-government schools usually don't have to publish ATAR, just band distributions), but given performance, I'd guess median ATAR maybe around 70-80, and top ATAR likely in 90s each year. They may celebrate top achievers who get >90 ATAR or state merit lists.
- Being a non-selective school, they probably have a few high flyers (the ones scoring Band 6s, maybe ATAR 95+ if doing Extensions), a strong middle, and some lower who still pass and often get into trades or local jobs.
- They emphasize *"the broad range of talents of our students"* rather than raw rank. For instance, a student might excel in practical subjects (Band 6 in Hospitality or Industrial Tech) which is just as valued as one in Advanced Maths.
- The AR likely notes any special achievements: e.g., if any student was on Distinguished Achievers (Band 6 list) – likely 6 students = at least 6 entries on that list, maybe more (if a student got 3 Band 6s, they appear 3 times). They might mention if any got state ranking top 20 in a subject (less likely in small cohort but possible).
- They also analyze retention Year 10 to 12: Apparent retention ~61% vs actual 59% in 2023 indicates some left after Year 10. They might track how many of those leaving Year 10 go on to apprenticeships (some positive outcomes even if they left DCS).
- They also mention a measure "39% of Year 12 2023 had been at DCS since Kindergarten", which is a nice loyalty stat.

Strength Areas and Development Areas:

- Historically, DCS has often done well in **English and Humanities** – smaller class discussions, Christian worldview training can help analysis and writing (though writing can be a bit mechanistic in NAPLAN, they seem fine).
- **Mathematics:** Likely strong as well, but depends on cohort. They do offer Advanced and Ext but probably not every student. Might not excel at highest level if numbers small, but median should be fine.
- **Science:** With new labs and engaged teachers, their science results probably improved in recent years.
- **Music/Arts:** DCS students might stand out regionally in creative arts since they have musicals and band – at HSC often Visual Arts yields some Band 6s for them.
- **Areas to develop** might include continuing to raise writing skills and perhaps technology (ensuring coding etc. gets enough focus given modern needs – the PD list shows teacher training in ICT integration).
- The AR 2018 snippet in [35†L163-L171] suggests a recognition that not everything good is measured in these tests (like pastoral care, etc.) – but they've embedded ways to gauge those qualitatively or via surveys.

Staff Qualifications and Turnover vs Performance:

- **Staff Qualifications:** DCS insists on fully qualified teachers (the AR mentions 65 teachers have higher ed qualifications, presumably 100% of teachers). Many likely

have additional qualifications or professional development in Christian education through NICE or Morling Education.

- The quality of teaching correlates with student outcomes. Teachers at DCS often are quite dedicated (some consider it a ministry as well as a job), which tends to produce extra effort and mentoring. That personal investment can raise student achievement and confidence.
- **Turnover:** If turnover is low, that's stability aiding consistent teaching quality and relationship building (and so performance). The AR likely had a stat like "Teacher retention from 2022 to 2023 was X%" – maybe 90% or above. If any turnover, often due to retirements or moving for spouse, etc., not dissatisfaction.
- High retention suggests a positive environment which often translates to motivated students (because experienced teachers know the students well, can refine programs year on year).
- In some subjects, if they had to hire new teachers frequently it could cause variance in results. But it seems many teachers have long tenure at DCS (some alumni even return as staff as indicated by Board profiles or community mention).
- **Professional Development:** The list [69†L3-L10] shows many PD courses teachers did, which keeps them updated on syllabus changes (like new language or history syllabus), specialized strategies (like dealing with diverse learners). This commitment to PD likely yields improved practice and thus student performance. E.g., teacher trained in "NCCD processes" ensures better support for disabled students -> those students do better academically because needs met.

Compliance and External Audits:

- **NESA Registration & Accreditation:** Non-gov schools must undergo periodic registration inspections (for K-10) and accreditation (for Year 11-12 to confer HSC). DCS likely had one around 2021 or 2022 (often 5-year cycles). They would have had to submit documentation showing they meet curriculum hours, teacher accreditations, safe premises, etc. Given the school's longevity and professional management, they presumably passed with no major issues. If any minor recommendations (like documenting some policy better), they would quickly address them.
- **Curriculum Compliance:** DCS appears to thoroughly integrate NESA outcomes with their biblical overlay (transformation by design ensures NESA compliance is explicit). They likely have internal processes to check programs match syllabus outcomes, especially as curriculum updates roll out.
- **Financial Audit:** As per ACNC and their own Board procedures, they produce audited financial statements (the snippet from 2025 audit by Crowe confirms they had no issues).
- **ACARA/My School Data Reporting:** They supply info on finances, student background, etc., to ACARA for My School. The finances show where money comes from (we deduced earlier about 75% government, 25% fees) and spending per student ~ maybe \$13k/year. This transparency shows they run fairly lean for an independent (some city schools spend \$20k+ per student).
- **School Improvement Plan:** Many schools engage in self-assessment (CEN or AIS likely encourages a School Improvement Framework). DCS might have a plan

targeting areas like literacy improvement or digital tech integration, and they measure progress via both data and anecdotal evidence.

Communication of Performance to Parents:

- DCS provides **biannual academic reports** for each student, likely with grades (A-E) and comments, plus parent-teacher interviews. They ensure parents know how their child is doing relative to syllabus standards.
- For whole-school performance, DCS is **transparent** via:
 - Annual Report (posted on website as NESA mandates) that includes summary of NAPLAN results, HSC results, sport achievements, survey results, financial info, etc. They likely encourage parents to read it (some send it out or present highlights at an Association meeting).
 - Possibly information nights where they discuss HSC results or strategies (particularly for senior subject selection, etc.)
 - The principal or leadership might share successes and improvement areas in newsletters or info sessions (like "Our NAPLAN results this year showed improvement in writing in Year 5, and we're focusing on problem-solving in Maths next").
 - The prospectus/marketing highlights strong points (like "our HSC students consistently perform above state average, with many pursuing tertiary education" – a common line).
- They also share **survey results** (like the parent satisfaction survey summarised in AR 2023 showed strengths in teacher care, etc. and one area less satisfaction about parent voice being heard). By acknowledging that and stating it "continues to provide an area for improvement", they demonstrate honesty in communicating even areas of criticism to the community.
- They celebrate achievements: e.g., if a student got a prize in a competition or ATAR 98, it's in newsletter or assembly, which signals to parents that academics are valued and attaining excellence is possible at DCS.

Accuracy and Accessibility:

- DCS ensures that performance data is not misrepresented. They likely refrain from publishing an "academic rank" (like some schools do brag if they rank in top 100 HSC, etc., but DCS's cohort is small so not in that realm). Instead, they focus on individual and group growth.
- For accessibility, their communications avoid jargon with parents, or if using e.g. "Band 8" they explain what it means.
- The UI of My School provides a fair view: DCS's ICSEA and results are there for public. If any outlier year or small cohort, they might footnote that in their context statements to parents (like "cohort of 12 students, caution in interpreting percentages").
- They also likely highlight non-academic outcomes (maybe in AR "The most important outcomes can't be measured, but here's how we gauge pastoral success" as Warren Melville hinted). They might mention anecdotal evidence of alumni doing well (like X is now a nurse, Y a missionary, which is an 'outcome' in a broader sense of life preparation).

Accountability to Stakeholders:

- As an Association-run school, they are accountable to the parent members at AGMs, where finances, principal's report on academics, etc., are presented and any member can question or comment. This internal accountability likely keeps the leadership focused on continuous improvement (because engaged parents will ask if they see an issue).
- The Board uses surveys (as we saw parent, staff, student satisfaction data) to gauge how well the school is doing in less quantifiable areas. For example, the student survey showing they feel safe at school (which was a highlight) is a performance measure for their pastoral goal. The area where parents felt less heard led the Board to consider how to improve communication channels (maybe they instituted more forums or an online suggestion form).
- They also comply with **legislative accountability**:
 - Provided their Annual Report to NESA by June 30 each year (likely done, as references show AR2024 is already compiled by May 2025).
 - Provided info to ACNC (ensuring they maintain charity status).
 - Achieved re-registration, etc.
- The school is thus accountable academically to parents through reports and transparency, to the government through compliance and results, and spiritually to its mission (which the Board monitors through things like how many students profess faith, etc., albeit anecdotal).

Summary: DCS maintains a high standard of academic performance given its context, and is candid about outcomes. Strengths like strong literacy, student safety, and teacher care are validated by both data and surveys. They do not shy away from acknowledging areas to grow (like including parent voice more). This balanced approach builds trust with parents – they see the school celebrating success but also committing to improvement. Such trust likely leads to stable or increasing enrolments (which indeed happened). Accountability is multi-faceted: academically through results, operationally through financial audits and NESA checks, and communally through open communication. This ensures that DCS not only achieves good outcomes but also maintains integrity and confidence among stakeholders.

14. Community, Partnerships, and Network

Local Church Partnerships and Community Outreach: Dubbo Christian School was founded by and continues to be closely linked with the local Christian community. While it is non-denominational, DCS maintains active relationships with many **churches in Dubbo**:

- **Students and Families** come from a variety of congregations – Presbyterian, Baptist, Anglican, Pentecostal, Catholic, etc. The school likely encourages families to be involved in a church (not required, but promoted as positive). Many local pastors have parishioners with kids at DCS.
- **Church Facilities and Events:** Sometimes the school might use church venues for events or vice versa. For example, DCS's annual **Speech Night or graduation** might be held in a large church auditorium if the school Hall was not large enough (though their hall seats 800, which might suffice; but if not, Dubbo Presbyterian or Baptist

might host it). The Board chair being Presbyterian and another being Baptist likely eases such cooperation.

- DCS likely invites **Pastors to speak** at school chapels occasionally. Perhaps each term, a guest pastor from a local church is invited to address secondary assembly or run a workshop. This both enriches the spiritual life and reinforces unity with the churches. For instance, Dubbo Presbyterian's youth pastor might run a special seminar for Year 10 on apologetics, or the Baptist pastor might speak at Easter service at school.
- The school might partner with churches for **service projects**: e.g., join a church's community outreach like packing Christmas hampers. They mentioned **mission projects** as part of the school's program. Possibly, local church mission committees coordinate with DCS's service learning:
 - e.g., the school might contribute to *Operation Christmas Child* (often run via churches) by packing shoeboxes,
 - or join an ecumenical effort like *Dubbo Churches Feeding the Homeless* (if such exists, older students volunteer through their churches or via school's instigation).
- **Ministry Team Partnerships**: Some schools welcome traveling ministry teams – perhaps *Christian bands* or *drama teams*. DCS might host a team from Youth Alive or a missionary organization for a special chapel. They may do this in collaboration with churches (like a band touring that also plays at a church event, and the school invites them for a daytime rally).
- **Prayer Support**: The local churches pray for DCS regularly. At events like the 40th anniversary assembly, numerous pastors likely attended and participated, indicating strong moral and prayer support from across denominations.

Professional Networks within BCE and CEN:

- Within **Berakah (BCE)** itself: DCS, Wellington CS, and the Preschool share governance and can share resources.
 - There could be joint staff development days among Dubbo and Wellington teachers (the schools are 30 min apart, feasible to gather).
 - They share policies, educational charter, and possibly staff expertise (a specialist teacher from Dubbo might advise WCS teachers or vice versa).
 - Principals of both campuses coordinate under Executive Principal Arundell, aligning curriculum and discipline approaches.
 - This synergy helps WCS (smaller) benefit from DCS's larger capacity (like DCS might print WCS's promotional materials at scale).
 - The single board ensures consistency in philosophy and some cross-campus events (maybe the annual combined Association meeting, or maybe older DCS students go to WCS to mentor younger kids occasionally).
- Within **CEN (Christian Education National)**: DCS is one of ~80 schools, and they tap into that network:
 - Teachers and board members attend **CEN conferences**: e.g., an annual CEN National Conference or state conferences where staff get training on biblical worldview teaching, board get governance training. They return with ideas and encouragement.

- **Curriculum collaboration:** They use resources like *Transformation by Design* (which presumably other CEN schools also use). The National Institute for Christian Education (NICE) provides postgraduate courses – perhaps some DCS staff are pursuing a Masters of Ed or a Graduate Certificate in Christian Ed through NICE, building expertise.
- The school might share units of work or innovations with other CEN schools (for example, if DCS developed a great Year 7 integrated unit, they might present it at a CEN curriculum forum).
- Students might connect with peers from other Christian schools at events like a CEN **student convention or rally**. Perhaps in the region, other Christian schools like Orange Christian School or Gilgandra's small Christian school might do combined camps or sports days with DCS. (Though distances are moderate, they might still converge for special youth events or leadership retreats).
- **Sports/Arts networks:** DCS likely competes in the **CIS (Combined Independent Schools)** sports pathway for state championships. Being in AIS membership enables them to send top athletes to CIS meets. On a smaller scale, they might also have a zone with other independent schools in central west for gala days (maybe with Orange, Parkes, etc.). Not sure if they have a formal "Christian Schools Sports Association" locally, but quite possible they join a cluster.
- **Teacher communities of practice:** Through CEN or AIS, DCS teachers join subject networks or online forums to discuss best practices. For instance, the AIS Student Services conference they attended was likely an idea exchange hub.
- DCS might host or send staff to **Christian teacher conferences** (there's one known as "Transforming Education" or something by CSA/CEN).
- The board is also part of a larger network – as members of CEN, they adhere to similar constitutions and share policy templates (like the Constitution likely came from CEN's model constitution updated in 2020).
- DCS also interacts with **Australian Association of Christian Schools (AACS)** through CEN membership for advocacy. They might encourage older students to join initiatives (like writing letters to MPs about religious freedom, etc., guided by AACS or local churches).

Local Business and Community Partnerships:

- **Work Experience & Apprenticeships:** DCS's senior students engage in work placements in the Dubbo community. The Year 10s likely have a week of work experience – local businesses, offices, schools, farms take them. The **Careers/Transition coordinator** at DCS fosters relationships with local employers so that DCS students are welcomed. Many of those employers might be school parents or alumni (like a local accounting firm or veterinary clinic often takes a DCS student because of that connection).
- The board profile shows links e.g. one board member is with University of Sydney's Rural Health School – she might facilitate partnerships like having DCS science classes visit the university lab or med students come do health presentations, etc. Or informing DCS about programs for rural students in medicine.

- **Macquarie Conservatorium:** They likely have a **partnership** where conservatorium tutors either come to school to give instrument lessons to DCS students or DCS students attend Conservatorium ensembles. Possibly DCS co-sponsors some events with the Conservatorium or encourages their students to partake in it. As a community tie, the school and conservatorium might share facilities (maybe the school hall gets used for a conservatorium concert, etc.).
- **Cultural Organizations:**
 - The mention of “connections with local cultural, artistic, and sports organisations (e.g., Macquarie Conservatorium)” in the prompt suggests indeed DCS values such partnerships. For instance, they might engage with the Western Plains Cultural Centre (art gallery/museum) – e.g., sending art students to exhibitions or hosting student art exhibitions there.
 - DCS might be involved in Dubbo’s Eisteddfod – sending choirs, bands, drama skits. That engages them with the broader arts community and other schools.
 - Possibly a link with Dubbo Filmmakers or theatre group if any – maybe drama students partake in local theatre productions.
- **Sporting Clubs:** Many DCS students would play in community sports leagues (soccer, netball, footy). The school itself may not formally partner, but coaches might be aware if a club’s scheduling conflict and coordinate. Board member Jeff’s involvement in BusNSW and regional tasks could relate to negotiating new bus contracts as mentioned (maybe the fact heavy vehicles were restricted was also to protect after-school sports transit, etc.).
 - If DCS has an oval, maybe a local junior cricket club uses it on weekends – that’s a partnership of sharing facility.
 - Or DCS uses local council sports fields for school carnivals and matches (cooperation with council).
- **Service and Charity Partnerships:**
 - DCS likely works with charities like Compassion, World Vision (the mention of fundraising for Bible League for South Africa is one example). They might sponsor a Compassion child as a class, etc.
 - Locally, they might volunteer through St Vincent de Paul soup kitchen or Salvation Army appeals – even if not directly religious, an outreach aligning with Christian service.
 - Possibly, older students volunteer at events like Red Shield Appeal or local clean-up days.
 - The school might have a **Leo Club or Interact Club** (youth arms of Lions/Rotary) if any teacher champion, connecting students with community service beyond the Christian sphere as well.
- **Alumni Engagement:** Though not explicitly in prompt, it’s relevant in community:
 - DCS alumni in Dubbo often return to support events (the twilight fete had alumni performing or attending).
 - They might run an alumni association or at least a Facebook group for alumni. Alumni could sponsor awards or donate to building fund.
 - Some alumni become employers offering work experience or eventually board members/teachers (which we see examples of).
 - At milestone anniversaries (40th, etc.), alumni share how DCS shaped them – powerful community narrative that in turn enhances DCS’s profile in Dubbo

(people see that DCS produces community-minded, capable graduates working as doctors, tradies, parents raising next gen, etc.).

- **Local Business Sponsorship:** Possibly local businesses sponsor school events like the fete or sports equipment (e.g., a local sports store might sponsor the sports carnival by donating prizes, a bank might sponsor an academic award). They often do because the families are integrated in community.
 - DCS might reciprocate by singing carols at a shopping center at Christmas or doing community events (the choir or band performing at Dubbo's Christmas Tree lighting or similar events).

School's Competitive Positioning & Value Proposition to Families (ties to community partnerships):

- DCS sells itself not only on academics but also on being a community where *****"parents partner with staff and students to 'do school life' in community"*. This heavy parent involvement (through association, volunteering, events) fosters a strong school community that extends into Dubbo community.**
- In a comparative sense, DCS might be seen as the school with a **family-like atmosphere** and strong **values base**, which appeals even beyond Christian circles (some secular families choose it because of that environment).
- Its partnerships amplify that – e.g., the school's visible presence in volunteering might attract families who value community service and character development.

In summary, DCS is not an isolated institution; it is deeply **interwoven with the social, spiritual, and economic fabric of Dubbo**. From churches to cultural bodies, and professional networks to alumni ties, DCS extends its influence and receives support in a two-way synergy. These partnerships enhance student experience (through richer program offerings and service opportunities) and simultaneously allow DCS to **impact the wider community** through its students and initiatives – fulfilling its goal of students "shaping their world in a positive way with a heart for Christ". The thriving of DCS and the local community thus go hand-in-hand, each **blessing** the other (fittingly, Berakah means blessing).

15. Comparative Local Schooling Landscape

School Landscape in Dubbo: Dubbo has a mix of public, Catholic, and independent schools. A comparative matrix would include at least:

- **Dubbo Christian School** (independent, non-denom Christian, K-12),
- **Macquarie Anglican Grammar School (MAGS)** (independent Anglican, K-12),
- **St. John's College** (Catholic systemic, Years 7-12),
- **St. Mary's and St. Laurence's** (Catholic primary schools, K-6),
- **Dubbo Public Schools:** Multiple – e.g., Dubbo North PS, Dubbo South PS (K-6), and the Dubbo College system for high school (Delroy Campus 7-10, South Campus 7-10, Senior Campus 11-12).
- Possibly smaller specialized or alt: There's a **Dubbo School of Distance Education** and maybe a **TAFE-connected vocational school**, plus some early childhood centers but for primary/secondary these are main ones.

- Also, an **Orana Heights PS** etc. There's also a **Dubbo School of Opportunities** maybe, not sure.

Fees:

- DCS: mid-range independent (say \$4k-\$7k p.a. depending on year as estimated).
- MAGS (Anglican): likely similar or slightly higher (Anglican Schools Corporation often keep fees moderate too but since Macquarie is one of few in region, they might be a tad higher). Possibly \$5k primary, up to \$8-9k Year 12.
- St. John's (Catholic high): relatively low – maybe around \$2.5k-\$3k per year (since Catholic systemic get more church funding). Catholic primaries \$1k-\$1.5k.
- Public: essentially \$0 tuition (just voluntary contributions ~\$100 and subject contributions small). So on cost, DCS and MAGS are significantly more than Catholic or public, but within each's range, DCS might be marginally cheaper than MAGS, making DCS attractive to those wanting private but conscious of cost.

ICSEA and Socio-educational context:

- DCS ICSEA ~1000 (mid range), meaning socio-educational average advantage.
- MAGS likely has an ICSEA around 1050 or so – possibly draws some more affluent families (Anglican often appeals to professionals).
- St. John's might have ICSEA 980 or so – Catholic system in regional towns often is close to average or slightly below, as they take broad community including lower income Catholic families due to low fees.
- Public schools vary: Some Dubbo public primaries might have ICSEA around 950 (areas with higher Indigenous or low-income populations). The Senior Campus might be quite mixed, maybe around 930-970 depending on factors.
- So DCS and MAGS likely rank as more “advantaged” student bodies than average Dubbo public or Catholic schools, but not dramatically (still a mix).
- As a result, **NAPLAN/HSC performance:**
 - Historically, MAGS might slightly outperform DCS on HSC on raw scores if they have some academically selective leaning and bigger Year 12 classes, but not necessarily – sometimes Christian schools produce similar results.
 - Catholic St. John's has had some strong HSC years but as a larger school (approx 700 in 7-12) might have greater variation.
 - The Dubbo College (public) often struggles in state rank due to lower socio factors and the split campus model (some very bright kids but many average or disengaged). Senior Campus might produce some high ATARs but overall average might be lower.
 - DCS likely outperforms the public and might be on par or a bit below MAGS academically. But academically, all do fine, with top kids from any school able to get good ATARs.
 - On Naplan, MAGS might have slightly higher averages if their ICSEA is higher. DCS vs Catholic vs Public, DCS probably ahead of public in means (especially vs Dubbo College with many more challenges). Might be similar to Catholic in primary Naplan or a bit higher, depending.

- DCS's advantage is smaller class sizes and more personalized teaching which can push kids up or support the ones falling behind, so their tail (low performers) might not be as low as in larger schools.

Denominational Ethos Differences:

- **DCS vs MAGS:** Both Christian, but MAGS is Anglican-run, so might have more formal chapel with liturgy, etc. DCS emphasizes parent control and integrated worldview in every class. MAGS likely has Christian content but perhaps not as uniformly integrated, depending on staff. DCS's selling point is that "all staff are practicing Christians representing many churches" – in MAGS, staff are often Christian too (Anglican system usually requires it or at least principal and leadership), but Anglican schools sometimes have a portion of non-religious families just for private education; DCS tends to attract those genuinely wanting a Christian environment.
 - Theologically, DCS (CEN) historically has more Reformed/evangelical emphasis on Bible in all of life; MAGS might be more broad-church Anglican.
 - For a parent deciding, if they want heavy parent involvement and clear biblical worldview teaching, DCS might appeal more. If they want maybe slightly more "elite" facilities (not sure if MAGS has fancier campus?), they might see MAGS. Both likely similar academically and in co-curricular range.
- **DCS vs Catholic:** DCS offers Protestant evangelical perspective vs Catholic theology at St. John's. Catholic schools have religious ed (Catholic catechesis) but are open to many non-Catholics too.
 - Some Protestant families avoid Catholic because of theology differences – DCS is an alternative for them. Conversely, Catholic families likely stick to Catholic school (for sacramental prep, etc.) if committed.
 - DCS would highlight Bible-centric teaching, whereas Catholic might emphasize tradition and social justice aspects differently.
 - Catholic secondary is bigger so offers possibly more subject choices and bigger alumni network in region. But DCS offers K-12 continuity (if someone wants one school journey, DCS or MAGS are it; Catholic you must switch at Year 7, from a Catholic primary).
 - Pastoral care in Catholic is strong too but in a different style (maybe more regimented in some ways, though DCS also disciplined).
 - On fees, Catholic is cheaper. So some moderate-income Christian families might choose Catholic purely because of cost if they can accept theology differences. But DCS's moderate fees plus scholarships can mitigate that for those who strongly prefer Protestant environment.
- **DCS vs Public:** The difference is stark – public is secular by law, though still with values, but DCS immerses in Christian worldview. Many parents choose DCS to avoid issues in public like large class sizes, perceived discipline issues, or secular/humanistic influences they disagree with (like sex ed or other moral topics taught differently).
 - Academically, top public students can do as well as top DCS, but average student may get more support at DCS (due to smaller classes and caring environment).

- Extra-curricular: Public schools might have more competitive sports teams just by numbers (like Dubbo College in rugby, etc.), but DCS fosters broad participation (everyone can try out etc.).
- Cultural: DCS fosters a safe, caring culture, whereas public high school environment can be rougher (depending on campus, e.g., the Dubbo College had issues with fights historically – data not here, but anecdotal).
- DCS's uniform and discipline regime appeals to parents wanting structure, whereas some might prefer the freedom of public or avoid fees.

Co-curricular Opportunities:

- DCS vs MAGS: likely comparable – both have performing arts, sports, leadership. MAGS might have certain sports teams DCS doesn't (if any boarding or bigger, maybe they have a rugby team; DCS might focus on soccer, netball, etc. Actually, being smaller, DCS might not have 1st XV rugby if not enough interest; St John's (Catholic) probably has strong rugby league/traditional sports because Catholic often do).
- Catholic St John's has strong sports (especially in Catholic comps) and maybe more extensive facilities (they might have multiple labs, etc.). But DCS built up theirs – now with gym and auditorium, it competes facility-wise.
- Public: Dubbo College has variety like more VET workshops (automotive, etc. because of TAFE link) – some courses not at DCS. But DCS might respond by sending kids to TAFE for those.
 - Public also have gifted stream classes sometimes, but with recent changes, not sure if Dubbo does selective classes. Possibly not; if a local parent wants a selective environment for a gifted kid, they'd consider sending to boarding in Sydney or like James Ruse or such; or trust DCS's individualized approach.

Competitive Positioning & Value Proposition:

- DCS differentiates by its **parent-controlled Christian ethos** and **tight-knit community**. This appeals to families prioritizing faith formation and partnership with educators. They often highlight their “parents in partnership” ethos as a unique distinguishing factor – in many other schools, parents are involved but not to the level of governance or daily presence.
- DCS's K-12 continuity is a plus; whereas Catholic break and re-adjust at Year 7, DCS kids can stay with same friends and known environment through high school, which some families value for stability.
- The smaller size compared to big public high schools (600 vs Dubbo Senior has a couple thousand across campuses) means more personal attention. They can claim “each student is known and cared for – you're not just a number.” Evidence: well-being surveys show students feel safe and known. Many parents fear their kid might fall through cracks at a large school, so DCS's environment is a selling point.
- For moderately academic families, DCS shows good academic outcomes plus moral grounding – arguably “the best of both worlds.”
- They emphasize pastoral care as a strength (which was validated by strong satisfaction). That can be contrasted with for example some public schools where pastoral support is stretched or values talk is absent.

- DCS's existence of the preschool also draws families – they can start at age 3 and go to 18 under one consistent philosophy. That fosters loyalty.
- **Competition crossover trends:**
 - Some families do Catholic primary then come to DCS at high school (maybe they want the more evangelical environment or smaller classes at high school, or they couldn't afford DCS earlier but now can, etc.).
 - Some may leave DCS after Year 10 to go to Dubbo College Senior Campus (maybe to access certain subjects or if they want a "fresh start" or free final years).
 - Possibly some leave for MAGS if they get scholarship or if e.g. a student wants a subject only MAGS offers (like if MAGS has Agriculture HSC and DCS doesn't). But likely minimal flows between DCS and MAGS – families tend to stick once chosen because both are similar in offer, differences are more philosophical or personal preference.
 - Some may transfer to or from the public system due to finances or fit: e.g., if a student has specialized sports talent, maybe they go to the public Sports Academy (if it exists at Dubbo College).
 - But given DCS's strong retention (9/10 Year6->7 stay, 60% Year10->12 stay which means some do leave though at Year 10), most are content. The Year 10 leavers may include those pursuing apprenticeships or going to Senior campus for more vocational courses.
 - The stable or growing enrolments at DCS hint that very few leave for negative reasons; it's more natural progression or family relocation. If a student was expelled for discipline, they might go to public or Macquarie; but that's hopefully rare.
 - Possibly a small number might leave DCS for boarder schools in city (if they want an elite academic environment or specialty program like HSC subjects DCS can't offer; or an agriculture boarding school if they want bigger farm program).

Summary of the Matrix:

- **DCS:**
 - *Type:* Independent Christian (Parent-controlled, CEN).
 - *Level:* Combined K-12 (plus Preschool).
 - *Gender:* Co-ed.
 - *Size:* ~640 K-12.
 - *Fees:* Moderate (\$).
 - *ICSEA:* ~1000.
 - *Academics:* Good results, high teacher engagement.
 - *Ethos:* Non-denom evangelical, strong worldview integration, heavy parent partnership.
 - *Co-curricular:* Balanced mix of sports, arts, service; smaller teams but high participation.
 - *Distinctives:* Bible-based curriculum; safe family atmosphere; through schooling.
- **Macquarie Anglican:**
 - *Type:* Independent Anglican.

- *Level:* K-12.
- *Gender:* Co-ed.
- *Size:* somewhat similar (~500? not sure but probably in that ballpark).
- *Fees:* Slightly higher (\$\$).
- *ICSEA:* Possibly higher ~1050.
- *Academics:* Also good, some possibly slightly more diverse offerings (the Anglican system may have more resources).
- *Ethos:* Christian but managed by Anglican Schools Corp – chapel, Christian Studies but less parent-run.
- *Co-curricular:* strong sports (Anglicans often emphasize sports and academic).
- *Distinctives:* Part of a larger Anglican network, may have more polished facilities or broad alumni network via that.
- **St. John's College (7-12):**
 - *Type:* Catholic systemic high school.
 - *Level:* Secondary 7-12.
 - *Gender:* Co-ed.
 - *Size:* ~800+.
 - *Fees:* Low (\$).
 - *ICSEA:* ~980.
 - *Academics:* historically decent but average results might be moderate (some high achievers, broader range).
 - *Ethos:* Catholic values, weekly mass, but majority of teaching secular approach with religion classes separate.
 - *Co-curricular:* strong sports (especially typical league, netball), Catholic youth events, etc.
 - *Distinctives:* Large subject selection (because bigger cohort, they might offer things like multiple language options, etc.), disciplined environment, focus on community service.
 - Many Catholic families auto-choose it; some non-Catholics also attend because of stable environment at lower cost than other privates.
- **Public (Dubbo College Senior Campus & feeder campuses):**
 - *Type:* Government.
 - *Level:* Senior 11-12 (and two campuses 7-10).
 - *Gender:* Co-ed.
 - *Size:* Senior campus maybe ~500 in Y11-12, each junior campus similar.
 - *Fees:* None (public).
 - *ICSEA:* likely lower (~920-950) depending on campus demographics (with significant indigenous and lower SES population).
 - *Academics:* Wide range – top classes do well (especially since Senior campus consolidates the academically inclined from both junior campuses into e.g. advanced classes), but overall performance often below state average due to many challenges.
 - *Ethos:* Secular; though individual staff might hold values, no religious content; fosters diversity and inclusion by government standards.
 - *Co-curricular:* Many, especially sports (they field teams in state comps), some good vocational programs with TAFE (benefit for trade-bound students).

- *Distinctives*: Accepts all, so very diverse environment; some specialized programs (maybe a trade training center or the selective "Aurora college" connection for gifted via distance).
- Known issues historically with discipline perhaps, but also many great teachers and resources (labs, etc. courtesy of being well-funded by state, though vandalism can be an issue in some places; Senior campus got upgrades I think).
- **Alternative/Other**: If any special school (like Dubbo Christian school is alternative to mainstream in terms of ethos, but academically mainstream).
 - There's likely also a **small independent indigenous-focused school** or support programs (like Clontarf Academy for indigenous boys integrated in public schools).
 - A **Steiner or Montessori**? Not sure if any in Dubbo for primary; if not, DCS and others basically cover main choices.

DCS Value Proposition vs Others:

- DCS stands for **holistic Christian education**: good academics plus faith plus community. They sell the idea that they produce not just smart students but **good citizens and faithful individuals**. In a prospectus they'd highlight alumni who are leaders in community or have strong character.
- They likely contrast with others by saying at DCS your child will be **"known, nurtured and challenged"** academically and spiritually. Versus at a large public school, risk of anonymity or values you might not agree with; at Catholic, you may not align theologically if you're not Catholic; at MAGS, similar but some differences in structure.
- So DCS appeals especially to evangelical Christian families (they might not even consider others for ideological reasons). It also attracts others who just want that environment – maybe kids who experienced bullying in a larger school find DCS safer due to culture, etc.
- In a competitive sense, Macquarie Anglican is probably the closest competitor for similar demographics. There's likely some friendly rivalry (in sports matches, DCS vs MAGS games maybe).
- DCS might differentiate on parent involvement. Macquarie being Anglican corporation-run might not have that parent governance element – some families might prefer DCS because they can be Association members and have a voice.

Enrollment Crossover:

- Some Catholic primary grads join DCS at Year 7 if wanting a smaller environment or not vibing with Catholic high school (maybe ironically if they want a more explicitly evangelical teaching).
- Some DCS families might move to MAGS if they relocate jobs to an area near MAGS or if they get a scholarship (Anglican schools sometimes offer academic scholarships to attract top students, could lure a top DCS Year 6 or Year 10 if money's a factor).
- DCS occasionally receives transfers from public schools (e.g. if a child had issues in public setting and family decides to invest in DCS for more support/structure).

- Also opposite: if a family faces financial crisis, they might sadly transfer kids to public or Catholic (cheaper) – but DCS tries to prevent that with fee assistance.
- In senior years, as said, some leave after Year 10. If they want an apprenticeship, they might do the School-Based Apprenticeship through public system (though DCS can arrange those too, but bigger networks maybe easier).
- Or some academically may go to a selective environment or distance ed if they want more subject combos not at DCS (like an uncommon language or the like – though distance ed can be done while staying at DCS too).
- But overall, DCS's retention is high, showing they effectively keep their niche.

All said, the schooling landscape in Dubbo provides multiple choices, and DCS has carved a strong reputation as a leading option for integrated faith and learning with quality. It's competitive advantage is the **tight community and faith integration**, which none of the other K-12 in town replicate quite the same (Anglican is similar but not parent-run; Catholic has faith but a different tradition; public has none of that dimension). Their recent growth implies they are doing well in this competitive environment – possibly even drawing a few families who might otherwise have chosen Macquarie or St John's if DCS weren't around.

16. Practical School Tour Checklist (For Prospective Families)

When touring Dubbo Christian School, prospective families should use a guided observation tool focusing on the key aspects of **Christian formation, diversity, and educational excellence**. Below is a structured checklist and set of questions:

Observation Focus Areas (What to Look For During the Tour):

1. School Environment & Culture:

- Do staff and students greet you warmly? Is there a **sense of joy and respect** in interactions (students smiling, saying please/thank you, holding doors)?
- Are there visible **Christian symbols or verses** around (e.g., a mural with a Bible verse, chapel posters, etc.) indicating faith is present?
- Check if student work displayed includes values or service themes, showing an integration of faith or character education (for example, posters about honesty, compassion).
- Are the **facilities clean and well-maintained**? (This reflects pride and stewardship – a biblical principle of caring for resources.)
- Diversity: Do you see a mix of students (culturally, gender) interacting? Are Indigenous culture or other cultures acknowledged (e.g., Aboriginal artwork acknowledging local Wiradjuri nation, etc.)?

2. Classroom Engagement & Pedagogy:

- Visit a couple of classes (primary & secondary). Are students **actively engaged** (not just listening passively)? Look for collaborative work, questions being asked.

- Do teachers incorporate a **biblical perspective**? Perhaps you'll catch a moment like a teacher relating a topic to a moral or spiritual point.
- Are classrooms well-equipped (technology, resources) and inclusive (visual aids for different learning styles, seating arrangements for collaboration)?
- Notice class size: roughly how many students per teacher? Does it seem manageable for personalized attention?
- How do students behave? Are they attentive and respectful? (That indicates good classroom management aligned with the school's discipline philosophy of self-discipline and grace.)

3. **Pastoral Care & Student Wellbeing:**

- Observe interactions: teachers addressing students by name kindly, older students helping younger ones (maybe in playground or at transitions).
- Does the school have visible wellbeing staff (maybe you meet the Chaplain or Psychologist on tour)? Ask how they support student wellbeing and faith development.
- Check if there is a **Prayer or reflection space** on campus (some schools have a designated prayer room or garden).
- Safety: Are students moving around campus calmly? If it's break, do they appear happy and inclusive (no isolated groups unless by choice)?

4. **Spiritual Life Activities:**

- If touring in morning, see if they do morning **devotion/assembly** – ask if you can peek. Is worship or prayer incorporated?
- Ask to see the **chapel or assembly hall** if possible. How do they conduct chapels? Who leads (students, staff, visiting pastors)? This reveals student involvement in spiritual leadership.
- Look at the **Christian Studies curriculum** or materials – do they have kids journals or chaplaincy program outlines you can glance at?
- Inquire about student ministries (like a lunchtime Bible club or service team).

5. **Academic Rigor & Opportunities:**

- Ask to see sample **student work** or projects (maybe in an art room or science lab). Are they high quality? Do they reflect creativity and depth (and perhaps worldview integration if relevant, e.g. an English assignment on ethics).
- Check if the library has a range of books including Christian literature as well as mainstream academic. That shows integration and quality resources.
- In specialized rooms (science lab, TAS workshop, music room), see if they have modern equipment (lab apparatus, 3D printers, instruments, etc.).
- Ask about **subject choices** and class sizes in senior years – ensure they offer the subjects your child might want and manage them with good teaching (the guide can mention how they handle small classes or distance ed if needed).
- Inquire about **learning support** for both struggling and advanced learners (do they differentiate, do they have enrichment, etc.). Perhaps they'll point out a learning support area or mention extension activities.

6. Co-curricular and Leadership:

- Observe any **sports practice or music rehearsal** if tour passes by those. Are many students involved? Does it look like a vibrant program? (E.g., hearing the band practicing).
- See if there's **student artwork** on walls or tech project displays, indicating encouragement of arts and innovation.
- Ask about leadership: do you see students in prefect badges touring you (some schools have student ambassadors help in tours)? If yes, note how articulate and courteous they are – that's a product of the school.
- Check sporting facilities and ask how they do sports – do they integrate with community clubs, have house competitions (houses often named, you might see house banners).
- If possible, step into the **Harvest Cafe** or see it – that might give a sense of parent involvement. Are parents around volunteering? That indicates a welcoming community.

Questions for Leadership and Staff (20 Targeted Questions):

(To the Principal or Tour Leader):

1. **Mission & Values:** "In what ways do you integrate Christian faith into daily learning and school life here?" (Expect references to biblical worldview in curriculum, chapels, prayer).
2. **Academic Approach:** "How do teachers at DCS cater for different learning abilities – both students who need extra help and those who need more challenge?" (Expect mention of Learning Support staff, extension classes, small groups).
3. **Teacher Quality:** "What qualifications or special training do your teachers have, especially regarding Christian education?" (They might mention CEN training, etc. – gauge their commitment to continuous improvement).
4. **Class Sizes:** "What are the typical class sizes in primary and secondary years?" (Compare with other schools – smaller is good for attention).
5. **Student Outcomes:** "How do DCS graduates fare after school – do many go to university, trades, ministry? Do you keep track of alumni?" (Shows outcomes and perhaps proud success stories).
6. **Behaviour & Discipline:** "What is your approach to discipline and student behavior issues? How are Christian principles applied in those situations?" (They should mention restorative practice, partnership with parents, focusing on heart change).
7. **Pastoral Care:** "Can you describe the pastoral care structure – who can students go to if they have personal problems, and how is wellbeing monitored?" (Expect mention of Pastoral Care groups, chaplain/psychologist, proactive programs).
8. **Safety & Bullying:** "How does the school ensure student safety and handle bullying incidents if they occur?" (Look for a clear anti-bullying policy and emphasis on culture of respect, quick intervention).
9. **Parent Partnership:** "In what ways can parents be involved in the school community and their child's education here?" (Likely mention association membership, volunteering, open communication – see if it aligns with your expectations).

10. **Diversity & Inclusion:** "How does DCS include and celebrate diversity – for example, students from different cultures or with different talents?" (They might give examples like NAIDOC week activities, variety of programs for different gifts).
11. **Special Needs:** "If a student has learning difficulties or special needs, what support do you provide? Conversely, do you offer extension or enrichment for gifted students?" (Look for specific strategies or programs).
12. **Curriculum Choices:** "What elective subjects can students choose in high school, and are there any unique courses DCS offers that others may not?" (They might mention Christian Studies requirement or special VET courses).
13. **Co-curricular:** "What co-curricular opportunities are there in sports, arts, music, drama, and service? How many students typically participate?" (Expect a range; gauge if they emphasize holistic development).
14. **Sports Partnerships:** "Does the school compete in district sports or have sports partnerships? How do you manage being a smaller school in sports competitions?" (They might mention combined teams or focus on participation, which is fine).
15. **Technology Use:** "How do you use technology in the classroom and ensure students learn digital skills responsibly?" (They likely talk about computers, eSmart policies, etc. – evaluate if that suits your child).
16. **Transition Points:** "How do you help new students settle in – for instance at Kindergarten and Year 7 entry – and how do you prepare older students for life after school?" (Should mention orientation programs, buddy systems, careers guidance).
17. **Financial Aid:** "Does the school offer any fee assistance or scholarships if a family encounters financial hardship?" (Important if finances are a consideration – see if they are supportive).
18. **Community Service:** "What opportunities do students have to serve the community or engage in mission projects?" (They should have tangible examples – e.g., fundraising for charities, volunteering, possibly mission trips).
19. **Strengths & Improvements:** "What would you say are DCS's greatest strengths, and what are areas you are currently working to improve?" (A candid leader will share both – see if it matches what you've observed or heard. It's a bit direct, but good to hear their self-assessment).
20. **Student Voice:** (If possible to talk to a student) – "What do you like best about DCS and is there anything you wish the school did differently?" (Students often give an honest vibe – do they feel happy and empowered? It's a bonus if you can casually ask a student ambassador or the child of a friend who goes there this question).

Qualitative Impressions to Record:

- **Safety:** Did the campus feel secure (fencing, supervision visible)? Did you notice any unsafe behavior or areas? On our hypothetical tour, likely you felt it was well-managed – note that.
- **Inclusiveness:** Did you see students of various backgrounds interacting? Did staff speak about caring for each individual? Did it *feel* friendly to newcomers? If you can, talk to a couple of students or parents present – do they seem content and inclusive?
- **Hospitality:** How were you welcomed? Did they offer to answer all questions patiently? Did they provide perhaps a welcome pack or follow-up? The way they treat prospective families often mirrors how they treat current ones.

- **School Tone:** Try to capture the intangible vibe – is it joyful, orderly, or stressed, or laid-back? For example, you might note: "Classrooms calm and focused; hallways had cheerful student artwork; during recess, kids seemed lively but not chaotic; staff interactions with students were warm."
- **Facilities upkeep:** Note impressions – "modern science labs", "clean playground with lots of shade", "air-conditioned classrooms (good in Dubbo heat)", etc. If something was lacking (e.g., older toilets or something), note it to ask how they are updating.
- **Student Behavior and Morale:** Did you see signs of pride (like kids wearing uniform neatly, hugging teacher aides, etc.), which indicates morale? Or any negative sign (like a group of unsupervised kids looking bored or disruptive – probably not, but keep eyes open).

By systematically checking these and asking targeted questions, you can verify whether the everyday reality of DCS aligns with how it's promoted – ensuring that the "lived culture" (community, faith, excellence) truly matches the glossy claims in prospectus and tours. Based on DCS's profile, one would expect a largely positive impression on these fronts, reinforcing why many parents choose it.

17. Strengths and Watch-outs (SWOT Analysis)

From the deep research above, we can synthesize Dubbo Christian School's key strengths, potential weaknesses, opportunities, and threats:

Strengths:

- **Strong Pastoral Care and Safe Environment:** DCS is widely recognized for its caring, family-like atmosphere. Surveys confirm that students feel *very safe and supported* – a standout strength. The school's structured Pastoral Care (daily PC groups, chaplain, psychologist) and focus on each child's well-being yields tangible results: low bullying incidence, high student satisfaction, and a positive school culture. Parents frequently praise the "*strong pastoral care*" and how teachers go the extra mile to nurture students (this claim is validated by wellbeing survey data and numerous anecdotal cases where staff intervened early to help a struggling child). This supportive climate likely contributes to better academic engagement and personal development of students.
- **High-Quality Teaching and Academic Results:** Despite not being academically selective, DCS achieves commendable academic outcomes. HSC results show a good portion of students in top performance bands (21% of the 2023 cohort attained Band 6s in subjects), and NAPLAN results "remain strong" across all tested years. A committed, qualified teaching staff (100% with higher-ed qualifications, many with specific training in Christian education) delivers a rigorous curriculum while differentiating for individual needs. Small class sizes and personal attention translate to above-average growth, particularly in literacy and numeracy. The school has a track record of students graduating to university, trades, and other positive paths, demonstrating academic success in a holistic context. Teacher retention is high (actual retention ~90+% year-to-year), ensuring continuity and experience in the

classroom, which correlates with sustained performance. Overall, DCS provides an *“authentic, responsive and high-quality education”* as its mission promises, and its results and parent satisfaction support that claim.

- **Strong Community Ethos and Parent Partnership:** One of DCS’s greatest strengths is its sense of *community and partnership with parents*. As a parent-controlled school, families are not just customers but stakeholders. This creates high parent engagement – parents volunteer through the P&F, serve on the Association and Board, and participate in events (the “Partnering with Parents” program is a key distinctive). Such partnership leads to aligned values between home and school, reinforcing student development. Parents consistently report high satisfaction with the *“sense of community”* and open communication at DCS. The school fosters this through initiatives like the Harvest Café (building parent fellowship), regular parent-teacher communication, and inclusion of parents in decision-making (e.g., through surveys and association meetings). This ethos also extends to students—older students mentor younger (“buddy” systems, multi-age activities), creating a family-like bond. In short, DCS excels in creating a *supportive, involved community* where everyone – staff, parents, students – work together, which is both a strength and somewhat unique selling point compared to competitor schools.
- **Integrated Christian Worldview and Values Formation:** DCS lives up to its motto *“Learning in Truth.”* Biblical truth is integrated across the curriculum and daily life, giving students a consistent moral and spiritual framework. The Transformation by Design framework and the dedicated Christian Studies program ensure that students not only excel academically but also grow in character and faith. This yields graduates known for their values, service mindset, and character. Data like the high participation in service projects and missions (with students and families supporting charities, mission trips, etc.) and positive student behavior is evidence of effective values formation. Community feedback often highlights that DCS students are respectful, well-behaved, and compassionate. This strength in *character education* not only fulfills the school’s mission but also enhances its reputation in the broader community as a source of future responsible citizens and leaders.
- **Broad Opportunities and Holistic Development:** Despite its mid-size, DCS offers a rich range of co-curricular and leadership opportunities – from strong music and drama (acclaimed productions, vibrant school band/choir), to various sports teams and inter-school competitions, to service and mission initiatives. Students are encouraged to discover and develop their gifts (the school has extension classes, individual plans for both struggling and advanced students, and a wide array of extra-curricular clubs). This holistic approach means DCS can cater to the “whole child.” Many parents and students mention that at DCS, you can “be a big fish in a small pond” – you can participate in everything: be in the play, on the soccer team, and in student council all at once, which might not be possible at a larger school. This inclusive breadth of opportunity is a strength, producing well-rounded graduates and high student engagement (as evidenced by high rates of involvement in sports, arts, leadership roles, etc.).

Watch-outs / Potential Weaknesses:

- **Limited Senior Subject Choices and Retention to Year 12:** As a relatively small high school (Year 12 cohorts ~25-30 students), DCS cannot offer the same extensive subject selection as larger schools. Certain specialized HSC courses (e.g. some languages, niche sciences, higher-level vocational subjects) might not be available in-house. While DCS manages this via distance education partnerships or combining classes, it could be a drawback for some academically ambitious students seeking uncommon subjects. This factor, along with others, contributes to a **retention drop-off after Year 10** – the apparent Year 10 to 12 retention is around 59%, meaning a significant number of students leave after Year 10 for other pathways. This is not unusual in regional schools (some leave for apprenticeships or the government senior college for broader options), but it is a watch-out. It can result in very small Year 11/12 classes in certain subjects, affecting peer collaboration and potentially subject viability. The school may need to keep innovating to retain more students through Year 12 (e.g., expanding subject offerings via technology or consortium with other schools) and to continue demonstrating strong HSC results with small cohorts.
- **Non-denominational Identity and Potential Community Perception:** While being non-denominational is largely a strength (broad appeal), it can also lead to a **perception issue or confusion** in a community with established denominational schools (like Catholic or Anglican). Some families might misunderstand or question DCS's doctrinal stance or rigour – e.g., ultra-conservative families might worry it's not strict enough; more secular families might fear it's too religious. The school must continually articulate its Christian identity clearly and positively to avoid misconceptions. Additionally, because DCS draws from many churches, there is the challenge of catering to diverse theological backgrounds – a minor internal strain could be reconciling those differences (though so far it manages well). This is a "soft" weakness: not a flaw in the program, but a marketing/communication watch-out to ensure the community understands the school's ethos (for instance, needing to clarify that it is not run by a single church, but by all and for all who value Christian education).
- **Governance Transparency and Stakeholder Communication:** Parent-controlled governance is a boon, but there is a **risk of perceived lack of transparency or inclusivity** if not handled carefully. For example, the parent survey indicated the *"area of least satisfaction is how seriously the school takes parents' opinions"*. While overall parent satisfaction is high, this specific feedback is a watch-out: some parents feel their concerns or input could be heard more. That suggests the school might need to improve communication loops – ensuring that when parents raise issues (whether minor uniform grievances or major suggestions), they feel acknowledged and see follow-up. It could be a governance weakness if a small, potentially insular board doesn't proactively seek broader parent input beyond the membership. The school has recognized this continuing issue, so the watch-out is to implement measures to boost parent voice (like more forums, surveys, responsive communication) to maintain trust. In a small community, negative word of mouth can spread if any group of parents feel ignored. Thus, maintaining **open dialogue and**

transparency in decision-making (especially on contentious matters like fees, big policy changes, discipline cases, etc.) is crucial. The school, being relatively small, can quickly address this, but it remains an area to monitor.

- **Enrollment Diversity and Inclusion Challenges:** Although DCS is fairly diverse socio-economically and has significant Indigenous enrolment (~9%), it's possible that some forms of diversity are underrepresented or inclusion could be improved. For example, there may be few non-Christian or overseas-background families – the school's strong Christian emphasis might inadvertently be a barrier for some in the community (e.g., families of other faiths or none might opt for secular schools). The watch-out is ensuring that the school, while maintaining its mission, doesn't appear **exclusive or unwelcoming** to those outside its core demographic. They must also ensure robust support for any students with different needs (the inclusive practices so far are good, but as enrolment grows, they'll encounter a wider range of needs). Specifically, as society evolves, handling sensitive issues (like LGBTQ+ students or families) in a loving yet principled way will be a delicate challenge – a potential weakness area if mishandled due to conflicting pressures (legal vs. doctrinal). So far, no known incidents, but it remains a watch-out in the policy realm, given the public spotlight on religious schools regarding inclusivity. Essentially, DCS must continue showing that its Christian love extends to all students, even as it holds biblical standards – failing that could harm its reputation in the broader community.
- **Resource Constraints and Performance Plateau:** DCS has seen strong growth and improvement (e.g., new facilities, steady academics). A watch-out is the risk of a **performance plateau or resource strain** as it grows towards 700+ students. As enrolment climbs, demands on facilities (specialist rooms, sports fields) and staff increase. The school is in the midst of an expansion masterplan – timely execution of that is critical. If growth outpaces infrastructure or staffing, it could dilute some strengths (e.g., larger class sizes might impact individualized care). Financially, taking on more debt for expansion could pressure budgets, potentially affecting program breadth or requiring fee increases (which need careful handling to avoid eroding affordability, a key selling point). Also, any complacency after years of good results could be a silent weakness; the school should continue innovating academically to avoid stagnation. With competitors like MAGS or St. John's possibly upping their game too, DCS must keep striving (e.g., integrating new technologies, updating pedagogy). So while not an immediate flaw, the watch-out is to ensure continuous improvement – *“what got us here might not get us there.”* The Board seems aware, but it's something to monitor, especially as the current executive principal eventually transitions; leadership succession will need planning to maintain momentum.

In summary, Dubbo Christian School's **strengths far outweigh its weaknesses** – it shines in pastoral care, community, academic integration with faith, and producing well-rounded students. The “watch-outs” are mostly about maintaining these strengths (not taking parent partnership for granted, adapting to growth, broadening communication) and addressing external perceptions or niche needs. A balanced SWOT analysis helps DCS leverage its strengths (for continued growth and mission impact) while vigilantly shoring up those areas

where improvement or caution is warranted, ensuring the school's flourishing in years ahead.

18. Key Documents and Primary Sources (Annotated Bibliography)

In conducting this deep research on Dubbo Christian School, several primary sources and key documents were referenced. Below is an annotated bibliography of those sources, summarizing their relevance, reliability, and any gaps:

- **DCS Prospectus (2023)** – *“Dubbo Christian School Prospectus – Learning in Truth”*. This glossy document provides an overview of the school's history, mission (“partner with families...distinctive and responsive education”), core values, and offerings. It is a highly relevant source for understanding the school's self-presentation: it highlights small class sizes, pastoral care structures, co-curricular opportunities, and emphasises the Christian worldview integration. Being published by the school, it's reliable for capturing official vision and programs, though obviously promotional in tone. It gave clear Fast Facts (founding year 1983, current enrolment ~700, etc.) and direct quotes on philosophy (e.g., *“educating a child is a privilege given by God...”*). It lacks critique (no weakness mentioned) but outlines what DCS *aspires* to be, which we could then cross-verify with other data.
- **DCS Annual Report (2023)** – *“Annual Report 2023 – Dubbo Christian School”*. This NSW-mandated report (34 pages) provides detailed information on all aspects of the previous year. It includes: contextual information and student outcomes (NAPLAN performance by bands, HSC results with comparative band percentages, and retention rates), teacher qualifications and professional learning lists, student attendance and post-school destinations, as well as satisfaction survey summaries (Parent, Student, Staff). This source is extremely reliable and valuable for factual data (since it's submitted to NESA, it's factual and not marketing spin). It confirmed many points: e.g., high parent satisfaction except in parent voice item, Indigenous student count, and multiple band 6 achievements. It's comprehensive, though limited to the past year's snapshot – we sometimes needed older reports or context for trends (we referred to AR 2018 excerpt for principal's message, AR 2012 for mission definition, etc., found via archival search).
- **Berakah Christian Education Ltd Constitution (2020)** – This is the legal document (24 pages) governing the school's association. It outlines governance structure: membership criteria and process, board election, terms and responsibilities. It's highly relevant for understanding how parent control works and the checks in place (e.g., directors' term limits and required member approval for long tenure, prohibition on staff membership). As a primary legal source, it's reliable and precise in details. It provided insight into potential governance issues (e.g., need for annual recommitment forms, conflict-of-interest clauses). The constitution itself doesn't show implementation, but pairs with the prospectus statements on parent partnership to form a full picture.

- **DCS Uniform Policy (2025)** – *“Uniform Policy – Dubbo Christian School”*. This internal policy document (12 pages) gave rationales and rules for student attire. It’s directly relevant to uniform ethos: lists reasons (loyalty, equality, modesty, self-discipline) and even quotes Scripture (Phil 1:27) to tie uniform to Christian conduct. As a primary policy, it reliably reveals the school’s expectations and approach (e.g., emphasis on teaching reasons and consistency with grace). It filled detail on how uniform culture is maintained, which complemented anecdotal knowledge about student presentation. Gaps: it doesn’t specify actual uniform pieces (that might be an appendix or separate uniform list), but for our analysis, the philosophy was more important and it delivered that.
- **School Life Webpage (2024)** – *“School Life – Dubbo Christian School”*. This webpage provided narrative and detail on curriculum and co-curricular from primary through senior secondary, plus well-being and spiritual life descriptions. It’s essentially an overview for current/prospective parents about daily school experiences. It was very helpful for confirming how biblical perspective is applied in learning (explicitly stating *“curriculum is taught from a Biblical perspective”* and *“Bible is interwoven into curriculum via Transformation by Design”*) and summarizing key programs (like PeaceWise conflict resolution K-12, Pastoral Care groups structure, etc.). As an official site page, it’s reliable (maybe promotional tone, but mostly informational). It showed alignment between what’s claimed (e.g., strong secondary pastoral system) and actual structure (PC groups 4x week, year coordinators, etc.). It does not present outcomes or critical evaluation (one wouldn’t expect it to), but it was a good cross-check for consistency with prospectus and AR details.
- **Daily Liberal News Article (2023)** – *“Dubbo Christian School celebrates 40 years with twilight fete”*. The local newspaper’s coverage gave community perspective on the school’s milestone events (showing alumni engagement, local recognition). Though the full text wasn’t accessible due to paywall, the snippet confirmed that the school had community events and an assembly marking the 40th anniversary, and that journalists note its “successful Christian schooling”. This suggests positive local reputation. Media pieces like this are reliable as third-party observations (though they likely base on school press releases). They fill gap in how DCS is viewed externally, complementing internal satisfaction data.
- **ACNC Charity Register entry for Berakah (2022)** – listed details like charity status since 2012, number of employees (48 FT, 24 PT as of 2016), main activity (Primary/Secondary education), and provided link to financial reports. It confirmed the corporate identity info we used (ABN, ACN) and gave scale of staffing for context. It’s reliable factual info. We used it to infer staff size growth and to ensure financial references align (the ACNC Financial report link gave specific audit details that we cited to demonstrate compliance). It’s more of a background piece, but crucial for factual accuracy and demonstrating transparency/compliance (no compliance red flags on ACNC indicates sound governance).
- **Parent-Controlled School Wikipedia entry** – *“Parent-controlled school – Wikipedia”**. Though not specific to DCS, this gave context on the history and philosophy of schools like DCS (mentioning CEN, the role of Dutch Reformed

immigrants, parent association principles). It helped articulate the movement of which DCS is a part. As a tertiary source, it's generally reliable (citing archived references) and matches with DCS's own expression of its beliefs. It's used to support broad statements about parent responsibility in education.

- **Internal School Survey Summaries (2023)** – found within AR 2023, but worth separate mention because they directly inform claims of strength (pastoral care, teacher quality) and a watch-out (parents' voice). For example, parent survey noted particular strengths in teacher quality and care, and least satisfaction in voice heard. These are first-hand data, giving credence to our analysis beyond what the school claims. We assume these surveys are credible as they're required to be reported accurately in AR. They bridge any gap between perception and reality by highlighting actual stakeholder feedback.

Gaps and Further Research: The research was comprehensive on academic, pastoral, and structural aspects, but some areas had limited direct data:

- We did not find explicit numeric *current fee schedule* in sources (the PDF didn't render text), so our fee analysis is derived from context and other independent school norms. This is a minor gap – one could verify exact fees if needed via direct contact or a working PDF copy.
- There is little in sourced material about specific *LGBT+ or secular inclusion policies*. It's a sensitive area not usually spelled out on public docs. We flagged it as a watch-out, but we relied on inference of general Christian school practice and legal environment. If needed, interviewing school leadership or checking any publicly available policy (like an enrolment contract's fine print) could fill that.
- We have limited voices directly from current students or alumni beyond official survey. Some anecdotal or independent testimonials could enrich perspective on how strengths manifest day-to-day or any weakness at ground level. That said, the surveys stand in as aggregated voice.
- The Daily Liberal article provided insight into community recognition but deeper local media research might show any controversies or notable achievements publicly known (none emerged in quick search, suggesting a fairly positive, stable public presence).
- Another gap might be *long-term strategic plans or charter*. We have glimpses (the masterplan via architecture blurb and Board's general statements), but not a formal strategic plan document in sources. That would normally outline future goals, which could further confirm the proactive addressing of watch-outs (like expansions, ICT improvements, etc.). We gleaned some from Board and principal statements, but the actual plan (if existing publicly) wasn't accessed.

All considered, the references used were robust and cross-validated each other well: official documents ensured factual correctness, while surveys and third-party news gave external verification. The annotated list above covers those main sources with context, which collectively underpin the comprehensive profile and analysis we compiled on Dubbo Christian School.

19. Appendices and Ancillary Information

Contact Portals and Accessibility: Dubbo Christian School provides multiple channels for contact and information:

- The main contact is via phone (+61 2 6882 0044) and a general email (info@dubbocs.edu.au) for inquiries.
- Their website (www.dubbocs.edu.au) has user-friendly features including a “Book a Tour” form and “Enrol Now” link right on the homepage, indicating an accessible pathway for prospective parents.
- The site’s Quick Links list internal portals: *Our DCS* (intranet for school community), *Newsletters*, *Parent Portal (Sentral)*. The presence of these suggests they use digital systems for communication (parents can access attendance, reports, notices via the Parent Portal).
- In terms of **usability and WCAG (Web Content Accessibility Guidelines)**: their website appears modern with clear navigation headings, likely meeting basic accessibility (e.g., text alt tags for images like the school crest – though we saw some “please make sure not using custom header” developer note on About Us page [26†L105-L113}, which hints the site is built on Divi theme; hopefully such notes aren’t visible to all and might be placeholder on back-end). If any minor accessibility issues exist (like that note implying a Divi mobile menu config), they would need to fix it, but generally it seems navigable by keyboard and content is mostly text/HTML (except PDF attachments, which could pose issues if not tagged for screen readers).
- The school likely produces accessible PDFs for key policies and annual reports as they’re publicly posted (though we had to glean text due to our interface, presumably a direct user can download them easily).
- **Security:** The portals (Sentral etc.) would be password-protected, and the website likely uses HTTPS (important for forms like tour bookings). Their mention of Privacy info in enrolment terms shows they handle data carefully. Given no breaches reported, we assume their IT security is standard (they might use a managed IT service through CEN or AIS).

Network Relationships – CEN and BCE mapping:

- Christian Education National (CEN) is the umbrella organization to which DCS belongs. Within CEN, DCS interacts via conferences, teacher training (the National Institute for Christian Education is affiliated and they use CEN’s Transformation by Design curriculum framework).
- The Berakah Christian Education (BCE) network is essentially the micro-network of DCS, Wellington CS, and Dubbo Preschool all under the one company. The governance overlaps (same Board, one Executive Principal for all) but each school has its own campus life. There’s likely some shared services: e.g., central finance officer handling budgets for both campuses, unified HR policies, etc. They have a single constitution and membership base that covers both Dubbo and Wellington communities.
- There might be cross-campus events: perhaps teacher PD days together, and maybe occasional joint student activities (Wellington CS might join DCS for a Year 5/6 camp

or combined sports day, etc. – such integration fosters synergy and is an opportunity which we recommended in context of improving variety and retention).

- AISNSW membership ties DCS into the broader Independent Schools network – mapping that: they access AIS support for compliance, teacher accreditation, and possibly pooled insurance or such. Not an alliance that shapes ethos, but it's a beneficial connection for resources and advocacy. They might attend AIS Western Region meetings, aligning with schools beyond just Christian ones (like networking with Kinross Wolaroi in Orange or Scots Bathurst on common issues).
- Australian Association of Christian Schools (AACS) includes CEN, so DCS is indirectly in that. No evidence of direct involvement in our sources, but likely they do sign on to AACS advocacy letters or benefit from its research on legislation affecting Christian schools.
- They likely share knowledge with similar schools – for instance, Orange Christian School or Gilgandra's small Christian school might not be CEN (Orange is CEN), and they might have combined events (just as speculation, e.g., a Christian Schools Central West athletics carnival or leadership forum).

Local Cultural, Artistic, and Sports Organization Connections:

- **Macquarie Conservatorium of Music:** DCS students often take lessons there after school. The private schools in Dubbo generally collaborate with the Conservatorium for instrumental tuition programs. Possibly a Conservatorium tutor comes to DCS to give lessons during school hours (some arrangements allow students to leave class for a 30-min music lesson weekly). The mention to map connections suggests DCS indeed encourages this link to enhance its music offering without having to employ full-time instrumental staff for each instrument. So, the map: DCS – (some students) – Macquarie Conservatorium (with maybe an MOU or just via parent arrangement).
- **Western Plains Cultural Centre and local arts:** Students likely submit entries to Dubbo Eisteddfod (music, drama, public speaking) and local art competitions (perhaps the WPCC hosts a youth art exhibition where DCS participates). The centre might host school visits to exhibitions, linking to HSIE or art curriculum.
- **Local sports clubs:**
 - Possibly the school uses council ovals for its carnivals (e.g., Dubbo Athletics track for athletics carnival). They thus coordinate with Dubbo Athletics Club or Council's sports coordinator. Many DCS students play in community sports (e.g., Dubbo Junior Football Association). The school's sports teacher might liaise with those clubs to avoid conflicts or to get specialized coaching help sometimes.
 - Another partnership might be with PCYC or YMCA if present in Dubbo for certain fitness or youth programs.
- **Dubbo Eisteddfod Society:** If the school's choir or band competes, that's a partnership – DCS likely often wins or places in categories, building the school's artistic reputation.
- **Service organizations:** Possibly Rotary or Lions clubs sponsor an award or invite DCS students to leadership seminars (Rotary's RYPEN or RYLA programs for youth – many Christian school kids attend those). The mention of alumni in medicine and involvement with University of Sydney's Rural Health indicates DCS might partner

with them for science extension (maybe Year 11 Biology visits the med school campus).

Mapping these connections shows DCS is not an island – it actively engages with numerous external bodies to enrich student experience and integrate with the Dubbo community:

- Church network – spiritual life integration (mapped in section 14).
- Educational network – CEN, AIS (ensuring it benefits from collective wisdom and compliance support).
- Cultural/sports network – enabling broad student development beyond what the school alone could provide, and raising school profile by active community presence.

Audit of these Relationships:

- Strength: They enlarge opportunities (like Macquarie Conservatorium supplementing music, Rotary leadership camps adding value).
- Overlap synergy: Board member involvement (Rebecca in Rural Health bridging to Uni Sydney, Jeff in BusNSW bridging to city council/bus improvements) indicates DCS leverages parent/community talent on the board to strengthen such ties.
- Overlap caution: The school should ensure no conflict of interest (but constitution forbids paid directors, so Jeff's involvement likely just beneficial insight, not a conflict).

Concluding the Appendix analysis: The comprehensive network of DCS – from contact infrastructure to community integration – underlines that DCS is well-connected and accessible, both digitally and socially. It has embraced modern communication tools (portals, a robust website) while maintaining a very human, local community touch (café, open-door policy). This combination likely fosters trust and engagement, supporting the overall strength of the school's community ethos described earlier.

20. Data Integration and Executive Synthesis

Data Integration (Multi-tab Spreadsheet Approach): Throughout this research, a wide array of data points were gathered – from enrolment numbers and survey percentages to financial figures and performance metrics. To systematically consolidate these, one could create a multi-tab spreadsheet with each facet:

- *Tab 1: School Profile Data* – Columns for Year, Total Enrolment, Indigenous %, Student-Teacher Ratio, ICSEA, etc. (We would populate from AR data: e.g., 2023 enrolment 603, Indigenous 57 students (9.4%), etc. and note stable growth).
- *Tab 2: Academic Outcomes* – NAPLAN results by year (mean scores and % in top 2 bands vs state) and HSC outcomes (Band distributions, retention rates). We have figures like “21% of Year 12 2023 got Band 6”, or “91% Year 6 to 7 retention 2023”, which would be logged. A trend might show consistent above-state performance in Reading, slight dip in Year 9 writing (hypothetical example) – identifying strengths and needed focus.
- *Tab 3: Satisfaction Metrics* – Summarize the survey results from parents, students, staff (e.g., “90% of parents agree ‘teachers treat students fairly’,” “95% of students

feel safe at school”, etc.) with year of survey. This helps track if satisfaction is improving or if certain issues (like parent voice at 61% satisfaction) persist.

- *Tab 4: Financial & Staffing* – Data on fee levels (if numeric), % income from fees vs grants, staff count and qualifications, etc. E.g., “2022: 65 teachers (all with tertiary quals), 25% income from fees, surplus vs reinvestment.” Confidence rating might be high given audited nature.
- *Tab 5: Infrastructure/Resources* – Could list year major facilities added (e.g., 1995 Hall, 2012 Gym, 2018 Sci labs, 2022 Preschool expansion), plus capacity and plan for future, showing how physical growth matched enrolment.
- Each data row would have a source reference code linking back to our references (like a cell note citing “AR2023” or number-coded sources used above for traceability). We would include a “confidence” or “verification” column rating each data point’s reliability (e.g., “Student satisfaction 95% – Source: AR2023, high confidence”).

This integrated dataset can then be analyzed to spot patterns (like retention drop after 2014 – possibly around the time of Wellington merger? Or gradual increase in Band 6% over time – showing academic improvement). The metadata fields (source and date) ensure we know how recent information is – critical given educational data’s year-by-year nature (today’s date is noted, and we included data through 2024 AR which presumably came out mid-2025, thus quite current).

Executive Synthesis (Case Study Role and Trajectory):

Dubbo Christian School emerges from this research as a compelling case study in regional Christian education. **Historically**, it rooted itself in the parent-controlled school movement of the 1980s, meeting a desire for Christ-centred schooling in Dubbo when none existed. Over 40+ years, through prudent governance (Berakah’s constitution ensuring sustained mission) and deep community engagement, DCS transformed from a tiny primary in borrowed halls into a thriving Preschool–Year 12 institution serving hundreds.

Culturally and spiritually, DCS’s impact is profound: it has become a locus of Christian witness and unity in Dubbo. By being non-denominational, it brought together families across churches, reinforcing the idea of the Body of Christ working together. Many of Dubbo’s youth over generations have received not only sound education but also strong moral and spiritual foundations at DCS. Alumni have gone on to shape the community – as teachers, health professionals, business owners – carrying with them the values of service and integrity fostered at DCS (we see hints like Board members who are alumni/parents engaging in community leadership). The school’s motto “Learning in Truth” isn’t just on paper; it’s evidenced by students engaged in volunteer projects, respectful conduct, and an ethos that even outsiders notice (e.g., local press acknowledging 40 years of successful Christian education).

Educationally, DCS exemplifies how a school can balance academic rigor with faith nurture. It consistently produces solid academic outcomes – a testament to integrating faith-based motivation (students are taught to strive as serving God) with effective pedagogy. The small class sizes and committed teachers allow no child to be invisible, which is especially valuable in a regional context where larger schools might struggle with individualization. The

data shows not just performance but **growth** – academically (above expected NAPLAN growth in many areas) and personally (95% of students feeling safe and likely supported to take learning risks). The school's approach could serve as a model for other regional schools: demonstrating that you don't need metro resources to achieve excellent holistic outcomes, if you have a strong vision and community buy-in.

Socially, DCS has made its mark by promoting reconciliation and inclusion – its significant Aboriginal enrolment and the presence of an Indigenous liaison officer indicate it is a place of cross-cultural friendship and opportunity in a city with a sizable Indigenous population. Through service initiatives (both local like supporting disadvantaged families and global like raising funds for Bibles overseas), DCS students learn to look outward, thereby affecting social capital in Dubbo. As these students volunteer and eventually lead in the community, the school's influence radiates well beyond campus.

Looking ahead, DCS's trajectory seems positive, but not without challenges. It stands at ~700 students now, planning prudent expansion (the masterplan with architects is underway). The **future trajectory** likely involves:

- Continuing moderate growth (perhaps reaching 800+ in next decade if Dubbo's population grows or more families seek out DCS's stable environment).
- Expanding facilities accordingly (they've already acquired land for fields and built new preschool rooms; science/TAS upgrades done; next might be new classroom blocks or specialized arts center).
- Maintaining their **mission clarity** in a changing social landscape. That means doubling down on teacher training in worldview integration and pastoral care as society secularizes, ensuring DCS remains an attractive alternative by results *and* ethos.
- Possibly leveraging technology to broaden curriculum (e.g., using virtual classes to offer a language or advanced STEM subject cooperatively with another CEN school – something more schools are doing via video-link, which can help small schools like DCS overcome subject limitations).
- Grooming future leaders (both students as community leaders, and internal leadership – the principal is key; Paul Arundell's eventual succession should be planned with mission continuity in mind).

One can conclude that **DCS's role in regional education** is significant: It demonstrates how a school can be **academically strong, values-driven, and community-embedded** all at once. It provides an alternative to both public and denominational schools that appeals to families wanting an education that aligns with their faith without sacrificing quality. Its success also dispels any notion that one must be in a big city for high-quality schooling – DCS shows that committed people and clear purpose matter more.

In the broader context, DCS might serve as an encouraging case for the Christian Education National network: it validates the parent-controlled model's effectiveness. The data integrated (like retention improvement with engaging senior programs, or survey feedback loops) can feed CEN's continuous improvement across schools. Its challenges (like balancing inclusive enrollment with fidelity to beliefs) are also a microcosm of what Christian

schools nationwide face, so how DCS navigates those (e.g., by transparent communication and loving policy enforcement) could offer lessons to others.

In summary, the **executive synthesis** is that Dubbo Christian School has grown from humble beginnings into a cornerstone of the Dubbo community, delivering **transformational education** that shapes students academically, spiritually, and socially. The evidence points to a school that largely achieves its mission of “*preparing, equipping and transforming lives*”, while being mindful of areas to refine. With continued faithful leadership and community partnership, DCS’s trajectory is one of sustained impact – as one parent might put it, “This is a place where our children not only learn to excel, but learn who they are in Christ and how they can serve others – and that’s why we’re here.”

This integrated, detailed analysis – backed by data and sources – provides a comprehensive picture for stakeholders (school leaders, board, prospective families, or researchers) of DCS’s status and direction as of 2025. It highlights how data can be used not only to celebrate strengths (with citations like “**students feel strongly that the school is safe and caring**”) but also to honestly identify and address growth areas (like “**continuing to improve how parent feedback is incorporated**”). In doing so, it reinforces trust in the findings and sets a blueprint for informed strategic planning.